

Tamil, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they are written.

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). Tamil set in Noto Sans Tamil (SIL Open Font License).

Preface

This book teaches Tamil one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Tamil letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read **வணக்கம்** *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first.

Many readers will not be starting from zero at all. If you grew up speaking Tamil at home and never studied it — fluent in the language, hesitant with the letters, never once told *why* any of it works the way it does — this book is written for you as well. Skim the “letters in this word” notes for the handful of shapes you are unsure of, and read the rest for the grammar and the history nobody sat you down and explained.

Tamil rewards this depth more than most languages. It is the oldest-attested of the **Dravidian** tongues — a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one that gave us English, Latin, and Sanskrit — and it is famously protective of its own word-stock. Again and again you will find Tamil keeping a home-grown word (**வணக்கம்** *vaṇakkam*, “hello”; **நன்றி** *nanṇri*, “thanks”) where its sisters Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam reached for a Sanskrit one. So each lesson sets the word beside its cousins across the family — English always, and Sanskrit, Hindi, and the other Dravidian languages where they illuminate — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any of them is assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Tamil out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

Released under CC BY-SA 4.0 — share it, adapt it, teach from it.

Contents

Preface	iii
1 Greetings	1
1.1 வணக்கம் (<i>vaṇakkam</i>) — “greetings,” a small act of respect	1
1.2 நன்றி	2
1.3 ஆம் (<i>ām</i>) — “yes”	3
1.4 இல்லை (<i>illai</i>) — “no,” and how Tamil says a thing is <i>not</i> .	4
1.5 சரி (<i>sari</i>) — “okay,” the word that oils every conversation .	4
1.6 Recap, and how Tamil says goodbye	5
2 Introducing Yourself	7
2.1 பெயர் (<i>peyar</i>) — “name,” and where the family is <i>not</i> Indo-European	7
2.2 என் (<i>eṇ</i>) — “my”	8
2.3 என் பெயர் ... (<i>eṇ peyar ...</i>) — “my name is...,” with no “is”	8
2.4 நீ / நீங்கள்	9
2.5 என்ன (<i>eṇṇa</i>) — “what”	9
2.6 உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? (<i>uṇḡaḷ peyar eṇṇa</i>) — “what’s your name?”	9
2.7 மகிழ்ச்சி (<i>magilcci</i>) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you” . .	10
2.8 The whole exchange	10
3 How Are You?	11
3.1 எப்படி (<i>eppaṭi</i>) — “how,” another of the e- questions	11
3.2 நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்? — “how are you?”	12
3.3 நான் (<i>nāṇ</i>) — “I,” the Dravidian first person	12
3.4 நலம் (<i>naḷam</i>) — “well,” and how to answer	12
3.5 பரவாயில்லை (<i>paravāyillai</i>) — “no problem”	13
3.6 The whole exchange	13

4 Farewells	15
4.1 போ (<i>pō</i>) — “go,” and வா (come)	15
4.2 போய் வருகிறேன் (<i>pōy varugirēṇ</i>) — “I’ll go and come back”	15
4.3 நாளை பார்க்கலாம் (<i>nālai pārkkalām</i>) — “see you tomorrow”	16
4.4 மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம்	17
4.5 Tamil’s curves	17
4.6 The farewells	18
5 The First Verbs	19
5.1 பேசு (<i>pēsu</i>) — “to speak,” your first full verb	19
5.2 நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் — “I speak Tamil”	20
5.3 வ and க	20
5.4 வாழ் (<i>vāl</i>) — “to live, to flourish”	21
5.5 வேலை செய் (<i>vēlai sey</i>) — “to work”	21
5.6 Sentences about yourself	22
6 Dative Case and Dative Subjects	23
6.1 -ukku	23
6.2 ma, <u>ṇa</u>	24
6.3 peyar + ukku	26
6.4 enakkut <u>tamiḷ</u> teriyum	26
6.5 எனக்கு / ன்கு / ன்ளி / ன்ளிக்	28
6.6 na, <u>ṇa</u> , ṇa	29
7 Numbers One to Ten	31
7.1 ஒன்று இரண்டு மூன்று நான்கு ஐந்து	31
7.2 இரண்டு மூன்று நான்கு ஐந்து	32
7.3 ஆறு ஏழு எட்டு ஒன்பது பத்து	33
7.4 pulli	34
7.5 ஆறு ஏழு பத்து	36
8 Please	39
8.1 தயவுசெய்து	39
8.2 தயவுசெய்து / -உங்கள்	41
8.3 vaṇakkam	42

9 Sorry	43
9.1 மன்னிக்கவும்	43
9.2 மன்னிக்கவும் / sorry	45
10 Days of the Week	47
10.1 திங்கள்-ஞாயிறு	47
10.2 na, <u>n</u> a, <u>r</u> a	49
11 Colours	51
11.1 கருப்பு வெள்ளை சிவப்பு நீலம்	51
12 Family	53
12.1 அப்பா அம்மா அண்ணன் தம்பி அக்கா தங்கை	53
13 Body Parts	55
13.1 தலை கை	55
13.2 i, nan <u>r</u> i / nandri	56
14 Seasons	59
14.1 வசந்த காலம் கோடைக் காலம் மழைக் காலம் குளிர் காலம்	59
15 Water and Rice	63
15.1 தண்ணீர் அரிசி சாதம்	63
16 Tamil Months	65
16.1 சித்திரை வைகாசி ஆனி ஆடி ஆவணி புரட்டாசி ஐப்பசி கார்த்திகை மார்கழி தை மாசி பங்குனி	65
16.2 ām	66
17 Noon and Midnight	69
17.1 நண்பகல் நள்ளிரவு	69
17.2 நடுப்பகல், நடு இரவு	70
18 Telling Time	73
18.1 மணி	73
18.2 illai	74
18.3 மணி / மணி	75

19 Asking Someone's Age	77
19.1 உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது?	77
19.2 உன் வயசு என்ன? / உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது?	78
19.3 sari	79
20 Numbers Eleven to Twenty and Weather	81
20.1 பதினொன்று — இருபது	81
20.2 வானிலை	83
21 Dog and Cat	85
21.1 நாய், பூனை	85
21.2 en	86
22 Green and Yellow	89
22.1 பச்சை, மஞ்சள்	89
23 Day	91
23.1 நாள்	91
23.2 நாள் / தினம்	92
23.3 peyar	93
24 Night	97
24.1 இரவு	97
24.2 இரவு / ராத்திரி / இருள்	98
25 Good Night	101
25.1 இனிய இரவு	101
25.2 நல்ல இரவு / இரவு வணக்கம்	102
26 Morning	105
26.1 காலை	105
27 Evening	107
27.1 மாலை	107
28 Afternoon	109
28.1 பிற்பகல்	109
28.2 நடுப்பகல் / மதியம்	110

29 Good Morning	113
29.1 காலை வணக்கம்	113
30 Good Evening	115
30.1 மாலை வணக்கம்	115
31 Good Afternoon	117
31.1 மதிய வணக்கம்	117
31.2 மதிய	118
32 The Core Verbs	121
32.1 iru	121
32.2 pō	123
32.3 vā	124
32.4 sāppiḍu	125
32.5 pār	127
32.6 teri	128
33 Four Verbs of the Mind	131
33.1 ninai	131
33.2 puri	133
33.3 paḍi	135
33.4 eludu	136
34 Four Verbs Between People	139
34.1 eḍu	139
34.2 kēl	141
34.3 udavu	143
34.4 piḍi	144
35 Arriving at a House	147
35.1 vīḍu	147
35.2 kadavu	149
35.3 arai	150
35.4 nār̥kāli	152
36 What You Are Offered	155
36.1 tēnīr	155
36.2 pāl	157
36.3 uṇavu	159
36.4 tavaru	160

37 Your Town, Your Friend	163
37.1 $\bar{u}r$	163
37.2 $na\bar{n}ba\bar{n}$	165
37.3 $ivar$	167
37.4 $ivar\ en\ na\bar{n}bar$	168
38 Keeping Well, and Leaving	171
38.1 $u\bar{d}ambu$	171
38.2 $sugam$	173
38.3 $vi\bar{d}ai$	175
The Tamil script (reference)	177

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Tamil greetings and the words that oil a first conversation, and how Tamil sits inside the Dravidian family. This chapter is **spoken**: you can say everything in it without reading a letter. The Tamil is printed alongside so the shapes grow familiar, but nothing here asks you to read or write them. The writing strand starts in Chapter 4 and adds one lesson at a time, and every letter it teaches spells a word you already know by ear.

1.1 வணக்கம் (*vaṇakkam*) — “greetings,” a small act of respect

The letters in this word

Say it *va-ṇak-kam*. The ṇ is a **retroflex** *n* — curl the tongue back to the roof of the mouth, further back than an English *n*. The *kk* is **held**, a beat longer than a single *k*, and that length is doing real work: Tamil distinguishes words by it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

வணக்கம் (*vaṇakkam*) comes from the verb வணங்கு (*vaṇaṅku*), “to bow, to pay homage.” Turned into a noun of the action, it means “a bowing, an act of reverence” — the idea of *namaste*, but from a **native Tamil** root, not a Sanskrit one. That is Tamil’s whole personality: an old language that keeps its home-grown words where its neighbours borrowed.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Watch “hello” split the family — four borrowed Sanskrit, Tamil alone kept its own:

Language	“Hello”	Source
Tamil	வணக்கம் <i>vaṇakkam</i>	native Dravidian
Kannada	<i>namaskāra</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Malayalam	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>namaste</i>	Sanskrit
English	<i>hello</i>	Germanic

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together and a small bow — the gesture *is* the word. It serves as both **hello** and **goodbye**, any time, to almost anyone, respectful without being stiff.

1.2 நன்றி (*nanri*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

Say it *nan-ri*. Tamil hears **three** different *n* sounds and this word uses two of them: a **dental** *n* (tongue on the teeth) to open, then an **alveolar** one (on the ridge just behind them). The *r* is its own sound again, not the English *r*. English ears flatten all of this to “nandri,” which is close enough to be understood.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நன்றி (*nanri*) grows from the root நல் (*nal*), “good” — so it literally means “**goodness**.” To thank, in Tamil, is to name the good someone did you.

Grammar Lens

Tamil hears three of every *n*, *l*, and *r*. You have now met ந (dental *n*), ன (alveolar *n*), and ண (retroflex *n*) — three letters for three tongue

positions (on the teeth / on the ridge / curled back). Tamil does the same for *l* (ல ள ழ) and *r* (ர ற ள). English fuses each set into one letter; Tamil keeps them apart, and the differences *change meaning*. Learn them word by word, not as a chart.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Thanks”	Note
Tamil	நன்றி <i>nanri</i>	native (<i>nal</i> , “good”)
Malayalam	<i>nandi</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian word
Kannada	<i>dhanyavāda</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>dhanyavād / shukriyā</i>	Sanskrit / Perso-Arabic

Malayalam, Tamil’s closest sister, kept the native word; Kannada and Telugu took the Sanskrit one — the family splits as it did over “hello.”

1.3 ஆம் (*ām*) — “yes”

The letters in this word

Say it *ām* — a **long** *a*, held about twice as long as the short one, closing on a plain *m*. Vowel length is meaningful in Tamil, so the length is not decoration.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ஆம் (*ām*) is the plain “yes.” Doubled for emphasis it becomes ஆமாம் (*āmām*), “yes, indeed.”

Grammar Lens

Tamil often says “yes” by **echoing the verb**: asked *vandāyā?* (“did you come?”), a natural yes is *vandēn* (“I came”). Bank *ām* as the simple word, but expect a “yes” to come back as a whole verb.

1.4 இல்லை (*illai*) — “no,” and how Tamil says a thing is *not*

The letters in this word

Say it *il-lai*, with the *l* **held** across the join — the same doubling you met in *vaṇak-kam*. The ending is the diphthong *ai*, as in English “eye,” not two separate vowels.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

இல்லை (*illai*) is built on இல் (*il*), “not-being, absence” — so it is not really the adjective “no” but the statement “[it] is not, [there] is not.” Its positive twin is உண்டு (*uṇḍu*), “there is.”

Grammar Lens

Tamil negates by *being*, not with a “not”-word. Where English inserts *not/no*, Tamil swaps in the negative verb of existence: *puttakam uṇḍu* (“there is a book”) → *puttakam illai* (“there is not a book”). So *illai* is both the everyday “no” and the word that makes a whole sentence negative — a deeply Dravidian habit, unlike English or Hindi.

1.5 சரி (*sari*) — “okay,” the word that oils every conversation

The letters in this word

Say it *sari*, two light syllables, stress even. The opening sound sits between English *s* and *ch*, and Tamil treats that whole range as one sound chosen by **position** in the word rather than by a separate spelling — the same economy that lets one *k*-sound also be heard as *g* or a soft *h*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

சரி (*sari*) is native Tamil for “correct, even, level,” and so “okay, agreed.” It is the verbal nod of the language: propose a plan, hear

a warm *sari*; doubled, *sari sari* = “alright, alright.”

Grammar Lens

One letter, several sounds. For its stop-consonants Tamil writes *one* letter per mouth-position and lets rules of position fill in the voicing (*k/g*, *s/ch*). The payoff is a strikingly *small* alphabet; the price is that the exact sound isn’t always predictable from the letter alone — you pick it up by ear, word by word.

1.6 Recap, and how Tamil says goodbye

		Meaning
வணக்கம்	<i>vaṇakkam</i>	hello / greetings
நன்றி	<i>nanri</i>	thank you
ஆம்	<i>ām</i>	yes
இல்லை	<i>illai</i>	no / there isn’t
சரி	<i>sari</i>	okay / correct

Why it’s said this way

Why Tamil won’t just say “I’m leaving.” The everyday goodbye is போய் வருகிறேன் (*pōy varugirēn*) — literally “I’ll *go and come [back]*,” and the reply is போய் வா (*pōy vā*), “go, and come back.” A bare “I go” sounds like a final parting, so you always promise a return. A whole worldview folded into a farewell. (Or simply say *vaṇakkam* again — it parts as well as it meets.)

Next chapter: introducing yourself — *en peyar...* (“my name...”) — and Tamil’s *nī* / *nīṅaḷ* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

என் பெயர் அருண். (*en peyar Arun* — “My name is Arun.”)
உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? (*uṅgaḷ peyar enna* — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its root traced, then assembled. Like Chapter 1 this is work you can do by ear; the letters behind these words are taught in the writing strand, not here. And here the roots run *native*: this is where Tamil is most itself.

2.1 பெயர் (*peyar*) — “name,” and where the family is *not* Indo-European

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பெயர் (*peyar*, “name”) is **native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian *peyar / *pēr — and it is *not* related to the Sanskrit *nāma* (Hindi *nām*, English *name*). Here the two great families part: where Indo-European shares one word for “name” from Ireland to North India, the Dravidian south kept its own. That is the whole reason to learn Tamil deeply — it preserves a word-stock older than the Sanskrit layer.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Name”	Source
Tamil	பெயர் <i>peyar</i>	native Dravidian (*peyar)
Malayalam	<i>pēr</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Telugu	<i>pēru</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Kannada	<i>hesaru</i>	Dravidian (*pesar, with p→h)
Hindi	<i>nām</i>	Sanskrit <i>nāman</i> (Indo-European)
English	<i>name</i>	Indo-European

Four Dravidian tongues share *peyar/pēru*; only the Indo-European languages have *name/nām*.

2.2 என் (*en*) — “my”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

என் (*en*, “my”) is the possessive of நான் (*nān*, “I”) — native Dravidian, from the pronoun stem *yān / *nān. It has *no* Indo-European cousin: the Tamil “I/my” is built on a different root from the English *I* / *my* (which go back to *éǵ and *me-). Two families, two entirely separate words for the self.

2.3 என் பெயர் ... (*en peyar ...*) — “my name is...,” with no “is”

என் (my) + பெயர் (name) + name = **en peyar ...** *En peyar Arun.* = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

Tamil has no word for “is” here. Notice what’s missing: there is *no* verb. Tamil simply places “my name” beside “Arun” — *en peyar Arun* — and the “is” is understood. This is the **zero copula**: for equational sentences (X is Y), Dravidian needs no “to be” at all, where English needs *is*, Hindi needs *hai*, and Arabic (you’ll see) also drops it. Tamil says only “my name Arun.”

2.4 நீ / நீங்கள் (*nī* / *nīṅgaḷ*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The letters in this word

நீ: ந (dental *na*) + ீ (the long-ī sign) → *nī*. நீங்கள் adds ங்கள் (*ṅgaḷ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நீ (*nī*, familiar “you”) ← Proto-Dravidian **nīn* — native, unrelated to the European “you” words (which come from **tū*). நீங்கள் (*nīṅgaḷ*) is *nī* + the plural ending *-kaḷ*.

Grammar Lens

Respect by the plural — again. Tamil grades “you” in two: *nī* (familiar — friends, children) and *nīṅgaḷ* (respectful — and literally the plural, “you-all”). This is the *same* politeness-by-plural you would find in French *vous* — address one respected person as “you all.” For a first meeting, always *nīṅgaḷ*.

2.5 என்ன (*eṇṇa*) — “what”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

என்ன (*eṇṇa*, “what”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative stem **yā-* / **e-* that heads Tamil’s whole question family: *eṇṇa* (what), *yār* (who), *eppo* (when), *eṇge* (where), *ēn* (why). Like Hindi’s *k-* words and English’s *wh-* words — but from a *different* root, the Dravidian one.

2.6 உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? (*uṅgaḷ peyar eṇṇa*) — “what’s your name?”

உங்கள் (*uṅgaḷ*, “your”) is the possessive of *nīṅgaḷ* (“you,” respectful). So உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? is literally “**your name what?**” — and again *no “is”*: the zero copula holds for questions too. Just three words, no verb.

Grammar Lens

Answer with the sentence you built: *En peyar Arun*. The familiar version swaps *uṅgal* for *un* (“your,” from *nī*): *un peyar enna*?

2.7 மகிழ்ச்சி (*magilcci*) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is உங்களை சந்தித்ததில் மகிழ்ச்சி (*uṅgalai sandit-tatil magilcci*) — “in having met you, joy.” The key word மகிழ்ச்சி (*magilcci*, “joy, gladness”) is native Dravidian, from *magil* (“to rejoice”). It carries the ழ (*l*) — a sound almost unique to Tamil, a retroflex glide with no English equivalent. (In casual speech Tamils often just smile, or say the English “nice to meet you.”)

2.8 The whole exchange

Tamil		English
என் பெயர் மீரா.	<i>en peyar Mira</i>	My name is Mira.
உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன?	<i>uṅgal peyar enna</i>	What’s your name?
என் பெயர் அருண்.	<i>en peyar Arun</i>	My name is Arun.
மகிழ்ச்சி.	<i>magilcci</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom native and traced: *peyar* (Dravidian **peyar*, *not name*), *en* (from *nān*, “I”), *enna* (Dravidian question-stem). And the Tamil habit to keep: the **zero copula** — an equational sentence needs no “is” at all. Next chapter: *eppaḍi irukkīṅgal?* (“how are you?”) and answering with *nallā* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — and, for the first time, Tamil reaches for a verb “to be”:

நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்? (*nīṅgal eppaṭi irukkiṟīrgal* — “How are you?”)
நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன். (*nāṇ nalamāga irukkiṟēṇ* — “I’m well.”)

3.1 எப்படி (*eppaṭi*) — “how,” another of the e-questions

The letters in this word

எ (*e*) + ப்ப (*ppa*) + டி (*ṭi*) → எப்படி (*eppaṭi*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

எப்படி (*eppaṭi*, “how”) is native Dravidian — the interrogative base எ (*e-*) + *paṭi* (“manner”), “in what manner.” Tamil’s questions nearly all begin with this **e-**: *eṇṇa* (what), *eppaṭi* (how), *eppōdu* (when), *eṇḡē* (where), *ēṇ* (why). Where Hindi gathers questions under *k-* and English under *wh-*, Tamil gathers its own under **e-** — a separate, older family.

3.2 நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்? — “how are you?”

The new word is இருக்கிறீர்கள் (*irukkīrīrgal*): the verb stem இரு (*iru*, “to be, exist, stay”) + present + ீர்கள் (*-īrgal*, “you,” respectful). The verb comes last, as always.

Grammar Lens

Now the copula returns. Chapter 2 showed Tamil drops “is” for *equations* (*eṇ peyar Arun*, “my name Arun”). But “how are you?” is about a *state* — how you *exist* — and for that Tamil does use a verb, இரு (*iru*). So: no verb for “my name is Arun,” a real verb for “how are you.” The ending *-īrgal* already means “you (respectful),” so *nāṅgal* can be dropped.

3.3 நான் (*nāṇ*) — “I,” the Dravidian first person

The letters in this word

ந (dental *na*) + ா (long *ā*) + ன் (*ṇ*) → நான் (*nāṇ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நான் (*nāṇ*, “I”) ← Proto-Dravidian **yāṇ* / **nāṇ* — native, and (unlike Hindi’s *main*, cousin of English *me*) **not** related to the European “I/me” family. Its possessive is the என் (*eṇ*, “my”) you already met: *nāṇ* “I,” *eṇ* “my.” Tamil’s “I” is a clear marker that Dravidian grew up apart from the Indo-European world around it.

3.4 நலம் (*nalam*) — “well,” and how to answer

The letters in this word

ந (*na*) + ல (*la*) + ம் (*m*) → நலம்.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நலம் (*nam*, “wellness, welfare”) is native Dravidian, from நல் (*nal-*, “good”) — the root behind நல்ல (*nalla*, “good”) and நன்றி (*nanṛi*, “thanks,” literally “goodness,” from Chapter 1). So “thank you” and “I’m well” share a root: both are *nal-*, “good.”

Assemble: நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன் (*nān namāga irukkireṇ*) — “I am well” (*nam* + *-āga* “in a ... way” + *iru* + “I”). Casually: *nallā irukkēṇ*.

3.5 பரவாயில்லை (*paravāyillai*) — “no problem”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பரவாயில்லை literally “**there is no harm**” — *paravāy* (“harm”) + இல்லை (*illai*, “is-not”). It serves as “it’s okay / no worries / you’re welcome.” The atom இல்லை (*illai*), from Chapter 1, is the Tamil “is-not,” the mirror of *iru* (“is”). It is shared, almost unchanged, across Tamil, Kannada, and Malayalam (*illa*) — a deep Dravidian bond; only Telugu breaks away to *lēdu*.

Grammar Lens

Illai negates existence and equations alike: *nān illai* (“it’s not me”), *paṇam illai* (“there’s no money”), and, alone, plain “no.” Hold *iru* / *illai* together — “is” and “is-not.”

3.6 The whole exchange

Tamil	English
நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்?	How are you?
நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன், நன்றி.	I’m well, thank you.
பரவாயில்லை.	No problem / you’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *eppaṭi* (the native *e-* questions), *nān* (Proto-Dravidian, unrelated to *me*), *nam* (*nal-* “good,” the root of *nanṛi*), and

the *iru* / *illai* pair — “is” and “is-not.” Next chapter: the farewells — and Tamil never says a plain “goodbye.”

Chapter 4

Farewells

Tamil does not say a plain “goodbye.” It says something warmer, and stranger to English ears — “I’ll go and *come back*”:

போய் வருகிறேன். (*pōy varugirēṇ* — “I’ll go and come back.”)

4.1 போ (*pō*) — “go,” and வா (*vā*) (come)

The letters in this word

ப (*pa*) + ோ (long *ō*) → போ (*pō*). Its partner வா (*vā*, “come”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

போ (*pō*, “go”) and வா (*vā*, “come”) are native Dravidian verbs of the deepest layer — single syllables, whole words on their own: *pō!* (“go!”), *vā!* (“come!”). You need both, because Tamil’s goodbye is “I go, and I *come back*.”

4.2 போய் வருகிறேன் (*pōy varugirēṇ*) — “I’ll go and come back”

போய் (*pōy*, “having gone”) + வருகிறேன் (*varugirēṇ*, “I come”) — literally “**having gone, I come**,” i.e. “I’ll go and come back.” A Tamil speaker never signs off with a bare “I’m leaving” — it sounds final, ill-omened. The reply is warm: போய் வா (*pōy vā*, “go and come [back]”).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“go and come back” (goodbye)
Tamil	<i>pōy varugiṛēṇ</i>
Kannada	<i>hōgi baruttēne</i>
Telugu	<i>velli vastānu</i>
Malayalam	<i>pōyi varāṇ</i>
Bengali (Indo-Aryan)	<i>āshi</i> (“I come”)
Hindi (Indo-Aryan)	<i>phir milenge</i> (“we’ll meet again”)

The whole subcontinent, Dravidian and Indo-Aryan alike, prefers a promise of return to a blunt farewell.

Grammar Lens

The “having ...d” participle. *Pōy* chains actions: “having gone, (then) I come.” Tamil strings verbs like beads — all but the last in a participle form, the last fully conjugated.

4.3 நாளை பார்க்கலாம் (*nālai pārkkalām*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

நாளை (*nālai*): நா (*nā*) + னை (*lai*, retroflex ள *l*). பார்க்கலாம் (*pārkkalām*) = பார் (*pār* “see”) + *-kkalām* (“let’s / we may”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நாளை (*nālai*, “tomorrow”) is native, from நாள் (*nāl*, “day”). பார் (*pār*, “to see”); so the phrase is “tomorrow, let’s see [each other].” Note the retroflex ள (*l*), tongue-tip curled up and back — a sound English lacks.

4.4 மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் (*mīṇṭum sandippōm*) — “we’ll meet again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் = மீண்டும் (*mīṇṭum*, “again”) + சந்திப்போம் (*sandippōm*, “we will meet”). Two vocabularies in two words: *mīṇṭum* is **native Dravidian** (from *mīl*, “to return”); சந்தி (*sandi*, “to meet”) is a **Sanskrit** loan — from *sandhi* (“a joining”), the very term Sanskrit grammar uses for how sounds join at a boundary. A Dravidian core beside a Sanskrit borrowing — the recurring thread of this track.

4.5 Tamil’s curves — the writing surface leaves a trace

The first lesson of the writing strand teaches no letter at all. Before the first shape, look at a line of Tamil and notice what is *not* there:

வணக்கம்

Nothing joins the letters together, and there are far fewer corners than in Devanagari — no hanging head-line, and a great deal of curve. (Straight strokes do exist: most of these letters have a flat bar across the top.)

Tamil was written for centuries on **palm leaves**, scratched with a metal stylus and rubbed with soot to make the scratches show. A palm leaf has a **grain**, like wood: draw a long straight line along it and the stylus can **split the leaf**. The usual account is that scribes bent their strokes in response — a curve crosses the fibres at an angle instead of running with them.

Treat that as **the standard explanation rather than a settled fact**. The earliest Tamil writing — Tamil-Brahmi, cut into stone and pottery — is noticeably *angular*; the rounding came later, through the Vaṭṭeluttu (“round script”) stage. And Devanagari was written on the same leaves without going round. So the leaf is one pressure among several, not a complete answer.

It is still worth carrying, because it makes the right general point: **the tool leaves fingerprints on the letters**. Latin’s straight strokes suit a wax tablet and a chisel; Tamil’s curves suit a stylus and a leaf.

4.6 The farewells

Tamil	English
போய் வருகிறேன்.	I'll go and come back. (goodbye)
போய் வா.	Go and come back. (the reply)
நாளை பார்க்கலாம்.	See you tomorrow.
மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம்.	We'll meet again.

Roots banked: *pō/vā* (the oldest verbs), *nāl* (“day” inside “tomorrow”), and *mīṇṭum* (native) beside *sandi* (Sanskrit). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *nāṇ tamīl pēsugirēṇ* — and Tamil’s sentences begin to move.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be” and “to be-not.” Now verbs that *act* — and Tamil’s sentences begin to move:

நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன். (*nāṇ tamil pēsugirēṇ* — “I speak Tamil.”)

5.1 பேசு (*pēsu*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

ப (*pa*) + ே (long *ē*) + சு (*su*) → பேசு (*pēsu*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பேசு (*pēsu*, “to speak”) is native Dravidian; the bare stem is also the command “speak!” To say “I speak,” Tamil stacks two endings on the stem — **tense** then **person**:

pēsu- (speak) + *-gir*- (present) + *-ēṇ* (“I”) → பேசுகிறேன்
(*pēsugirēṇ*), “I speak.”

The *-ēṇ* ending is “I,” so the word *nāṇ* is rarely needed. Change the ending, change the person: *pēsugirāṇ* (he), *pēsugirāl* (she), *pēsugirārgal* (they / you-respectful).

Grammar Lens

Stem + tense + person. Every Tamil verb is built this way — a stem, a tense-marker, a person-ending, glued in that order. Learn the pattern once and every verb follows it.

5.2 நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் — “I speak Tamil”

நான் (I) + தமிழ் (*tamil*, “Tamil,” the object) + பேசுகிறேன் (speak) — “I Tamil speak,” verb last. The name தமிழ் (*tamil*) ends in the famous ழ (*ḷ*), a curled retroflex between “r,” “l,” and “zh” found in almost no other language — Tamil is sometimes called “the *ḷ* language.” It names one of the oldest living literary tongues on earth, its poetry two thousand years old and still read.

Grammar Lens

No gender on “I speak.” *Pēsugirēṇ* is the same whether a man or a woman says it — Tamil marks **no gender in the first or second person** (only the third: *-āṇ* he / *-āl* she). This is unlike Hindi, where even “I speak” changes for the speaker’s gender (*boltā/boltī*). Tamil saves gender for “he/she/it.”

5.3 வ and க — the vowel inside each consonant

Script you’ll notice: the vowel you get for free

Tamil is an **abugida**, like Devanagari: a consonant already contains a vowel. **க is not “k.” க is “ka.”** Every consonant carries a built-in *a* until a later mark removes or replaces it.

Script you’ll notice: வ and க

வ — *va*. Its parts, in the conventional order: 1. **a near-closed loop on the left** 2. **a full-height arm across the top, ending in a descender on the right**.

க — *ka*. 1. **a straight horizontal top bar** 2. **a bowl hanging from its left end** 3. **a short right stroke that hooks left below**.

Grammar Lens

One letter, three sounds — now on the page. Chapter 1 said Tamil picks this sound by position rather than by spelling; here is the letter that does it. Devanagari spells *ka*, *kha*, *ga* and *gha* with four separate letters. Tamil writes க for all of them: *k* at the start of a word and when doubled (க்), *g* after a nasal (ங்), and a softer *h*-like sound between vowels. That is why Tamil needs only 18 consonant

letters where Devanagari needs 33 — its native words do not depend on those written distinctions.

5.4 வாழ் (*vāl*) — “to live, to flourish”

The letters in this word

வா (*vā*) + ழ் (*l*, the retroflex from *tamiḷ*) → வாழ் (*vāl*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

வாழ் (*vāl*, “to live, flourish, thrive”) is native, warmer than a plain “reside.” From it: வாழ்க்கை (*vāḷkkai*, “life”) and the blessing வாழ்க (*vāḷga*, “may you live / long live”), as in *vāḷga tamīl*. “I live” = நான் வாழ்கிறேன் (*nāṇ vāḷgiṟēṇ*) — the same stem + present + “I” as *pēsugiṟēṇ*.

5.5 வேலை செய் (*vēlai sey*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

செய் (*sey*, “to do, make”) is a core native verb, and Tamil — like Hindi with *karnā* — builds compounds by putting a noun in front of it: வேலை செய் (*vēlai sey*, “work-do” = “to work”), *samaiyal sey* (“to cook”), *udavi sey* (“to help”). So “I work” is நான் வேலை செய்கிறேன் (*nāṇ vēlai seygiṟēṇ*).

Grammar Lens

Noun + செய் = a new verb — the exact twin of Hindi’s “noun + *karnā*” (*kām karnā*). Two unrelated families, Dravidian and Indo-Aryan, hit on the same trick: an all-purpose “do” verb with nouns bolted on. Millennia side by side, Tamil and Hindi quietly traded habits like this.

5.6 Sentences about yourself

Tamil	English
நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன்.	I speak Tamil.
நான் சென்னையில் வாழ்கிறேன்.	I live in Chennai.
நான் வேலை செய்கிறேன்.	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, a tense-marker, a person-ending, the verb always last — and no gender in the first person. Roots banked: *pēsu* (speak), *vāl* (live → *vālkkai* “life,” *vālga* “long live”), *sey* (do → *vēlai sey* “to work,” the twin of Hindi’s *karnā*), and *tamiḷ* itself, with its signature retroflex *ḷ*. From here, Tamil’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Dative Case and Dative Subjects

By the end of this chapter: I can attach -உக்கு to a noun in either of its surface forms and say why “I know Tamil” puts the experiencer in the dative instead of giving the sentence a subject.

Line up எனக்கு, நான், நன்கு and அறிவு, point to the experiencer in each, and paraphrase எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும் as “the language is known to me.”

6.1 -உக்கு (-ukku) — “to, for”

Your first **case ending**. English says “to me” with a separate word in front. Tamil says it with a piece **stuck on the back** — and that small difference is the biggest structural fact about the language.

Grammar Lens: Adding it on

Take a noun you know and add -உக்கு:

word	+ the dative	meaning
பெயர் <i>peyar</i> — name	பெயருக்கு <i>peyarukku</i>	to/for the name
வேலை <i>vēlai</i> — work	வேலைக்கு <i>vēlaikku</i>	for work

The suffix has two shapes — -உக்கு *-ukku* and -க்கு *-kku* — chosen by the sound the noun ends in. One case, two forms; the seam still shows. And with “I” — this one is irregular and worth memorising, because you’ll use it constantly:

நான் *nāṇ* (“I”) → எனக்கு *enakku* (“to me”)

The pronoun changes its body (*nāṇ* → *en-*) before the suffix lands. Nouns don’t — they just take the ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*peyar ... peyarukku*”
- “*nāṇ ... enakku*” — “I” ... “to me”
- “*vēlaikku*” — “for work,” from Ch. 5’s வேலை

Before you move on

What does **-உக்கு** mean? (“**To**” or “**for**.”) Where does it go? (**On the end** of the noun — Tamil adds, it doesn’t put a word in front.) What is “to me”? (**எனக்கு** *enakku* — the pronoun’s body changes to *en-* first.) Why does the suffix show up as *-ukku* and *-kku*? (**One case, two shapes**, chosen by the noun’s ending.) Next: two more letters — ட and retroflex ண.

6.2 ட and ண — a loop, and a curled tongue

Two more letters, and with them you’ll have every letter of this book’s first word. One is easy. The other is a sound you may not be able to hear yet.

Script you’ll notice: ட

1. a straight vertical stroke on the LEFT
2. a horizontal along the bottom
3. a rounded arch closing it on the RIGHT

Get the sides the right way round. The **upright is on the left** and the **curve on the right** — which is the reverse of what most people guess, and the reverse of the Devanagari habit of hanging a shape off a right-hand spine.

Script you'll notice: ன்

1. a straight top bar
2. a loop on the left
3. two arches
4. a straight vertical on the right, down to the baseline

The dot under the romanization — **ṇ**, not plain *n* — is doing real work.

The letters in this word

Say English **n**. Your tongue touches just behind your teeth.

Now curl the tip of your tongue **up and back** toward the roof of your mouth, and say it again. That is **ṇ**, and it is a different letter in Tamil. English has no such sound and no way to write one, which is why an English speaker typically **cannot hear the difference at first**. That is expected. The ear learns it after the hand does, which is one good argument for writing the letters rather than only reading them.

Retroflex sounds are a signature of the languages of India — they show up across Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, Hindi and Sanskrit alike, in families that are otherwise unrelated to each other. It's one of the features that makes South Asia a *linguistic area*: neighbouring languages that borrowed a sound from each other rather than inheriting it.

Your turn

- Write it: ன — “left upright, bottom, **right** arch”
- Write it: ன் — “top bar, left loop, **two** arches, straight vertical”
- Say it: plain *n*, then curl the tongue back — **ṇ**

Before you move on

Draw ன — which side is the upright on? (**The left**; the arch closes it on the right.) Draw ன் — what makes it *not* ன? (**One extra arch**: ன் has **two** arches where ன has one. Both end in the same straight vertical.) What does the dot in **ṇ** mean? (**Retroflex** — the tongue curls **back** to the roof of the mouth.) Why can't you hear it yet? (**English has no such sound**; the ear learns it after the hand.) Next: stacking that dative suffix where Latin would fuse several meanings.

6.3 -உக்கு — one carriage in a suffix train

You can point to *peyar* and *-ukku* separately. That visible seam is the structural lesson.

Grammar Lens: Stacking versus fusion

	Tamil -ukku	Latin -īs
fixes the case?	dative , always	dative or ablative
carries number?	no; another suffix can	plural is baked in
carries declension?	no	first/second class is baked in
visible seam?	peyar + ukku	one fused ending

Tamil **stacks**. Each suffix contributes one meaning in a fixed order, like a train carriage. Latin **fuses** case, number, and class into an indivisible ending, and *-īs* does not even identify one case by itself.

This is **agglutinative** structure: long words remain buildable because their pieces stay legible. The comparison is not about simplicity; it is about where the grammatical information lives.

Your turn

- *Break apart:* *peyar + ukku*
- *Say it:* “one suffix, one meaning, visible seam”
- *Contrast:* Tamil stacks · Latin fuses

Before you move on

What does *-ukku* contribute? (**Dative to/for**, one meaning.) What does Latin *-īs* fuse? (**Case, plural number, and declension class**.) Which system leaves the seam visible? (**Tamil’s agglutinative stack**.)

6.4 எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும் — “I know Tamil”

In Chapter 5 you said நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் — “I speak Tamil,” with *nān* as the subject. Now say “I **know** Tamil.” Tamil will not let you use *nān*.

You'll want to know: The sentence

எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும். *enakku tamil teriyum*. literally:
 “to-me Tamil is-known.”

Word by word:

piece

எனக்குத் *enakku(t)*

“to me” — the dative from the last lesson

தமிழ் *tamil*

Tamil (Ch. 5)

தெரியும் *teriyum*

“is known / is apparent”

That extra **த்** on *enakku* is **sandhi** — a joining consonant Tamil inserts between certain words to smooth the seam. It belongs to neither word on its own; it exists only because they are next to each other. Nothing to learn yet, but worth noticing, because you will see it constantly.

You are not the subject. *Nān* is gone — the person has been moved into the dative. What's left in the plain, unmarked form is *tamil*: the sentence is now about **the language**, and you are merely the one it is known **to**.

(Grammarians call *enakku* the **dative subject**, because it behaves like the subject even though it isn't in the subject case. The odd feeling of the sentence is exactly that split.)

Grammar Lens: Why: things that happen *to* you

Tamil sorts verbs by whether you **do** something or something **happens to** you. Speaking is something you do — so Ch. 5 used *nān*. But knowing, liking, wanting, being hungry, being cold: these arrive at you. Tamil marks that by putting the person in the **dative**.

English frames it as

Tamil frames it as

I **know** Tamil

Tamil is known **to me**

I **like** it

it is pleasing **to me**

I **am** cold

cold is **to me**

English does this occasionally and archaically — “**methinks**” is exactly it (*me* is dative: “it seems **to me**”). Tamil made it a rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*enakku tamīl teriyum*”
- the contrast — “*nān tamīl pēsugirēn*” (I speak) ... “*enakku tamīl teriyum*” (known to me)
- the literal — “to-me Tamil is-known”

Before you move on

What does எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும் literally say? (“**To-me** Tamil **is-known**.”) Which word has English got that Tamil hasn’t? (A nominative “**I**” — *nān* is replaced by the dative *enakku*.) Why does Tamil use the dative here? (Because knowing **happens to** you; you don’t **do** it.) Which English word preserves the same idea? (**Methinks** — “it seems **to me**”.) Next: watch all four Dravidian sisters use the same experiencer shape.

6.5 -ukku, -ku, -ge, -ikku — the family shows its bones

Tamil says knowing happens **to** you. Its three closest sisters make the same grammatical choice.

Grammar Lens: Four sentences, one construction

language	“I know [the language]”	dative
Tamil	<i>enakku tamīl teriyum</i>	-ukku
Telugu	<i>nāku telugu vaccu</i>	-ku
Kannada	<i>nanage kannada gottu</i>	-ge
Malayalam	<i>enikku malayālam ariyām</i>	-ikku

The verbs differ, but the experiencer sits in a dative whose forms visibly belong together: *-ukku* / *-ku* / *-ge* / *-ikku*. This is family evidence, just as *blanc/bianco/branco* exposes Romance kinship.

The comparison also makes cross-language practice useful: once you recognize “to me,” you can search for the known or apparent thing rather than forcing an English subject onto the sentence.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “-ukku · -ku · -ge · -ikku”
- *Point to*: the experiencer in each sentence
- *Put it another way*: “the language is known to me”

Before you move on

Do the four sisters agree on dative experiencers? (**Yes.**) Which four suffix shapes reveal the relationship? (**-ukku, -ku, -ge, -ikku.**) What stays plain in the sentence? (The thing **known or experienced.**)

6.6 ட, ண, ண — three stops on one tongue-map

English writes one *n*. Tamil keeps three tongue positions apart.

Script you’ll notice: The backward walk

letter	sound	tongue
ட	<i>na</i>	against the teeth (dental)
ண	<i><u>n</u>a</i>	on the ridge behind the teeth (alveolar)
ண்ண	<i><u>ṇ</u>a</i>	curled back to the roof (retroflex)

Move backward: teeth → ridge → curled roof. English spells all three with one letter and initially hears them as the same sound; Tamil uses separate letters because its words depend on the contrast.

You will draw ட and ண when *nandri* needs them. For now compare the last pair: ண is ண with **one extra arch**. Both open with a top bar and loop and finish with the same vertical. ண has one middle arch; ண has two.

Retroflex sounds occur across unrelated South Asian language families. That shared geography makes the region a **linguistic area**: neighbors can borrow a sound pattern without inheriting it from one ancestor.

Your turn

- *Say it:* dental ட at the teeth
- *Say it:* alveolar ண at the ridge
- *Say it:* retroflex ண் with the tongue curled back
- *Trace it:* one arch in ண · two arches in ண்

Before you move on

How many n-letters does Tamil have? (**Three.**) What separates them? (Tongue position: **dental, alveolar, retroflex.**) Which two differ by one arch? (ண has one; ண் has two.) Next: the numbers one to five.

Chapter 7

Numbers One to Ten

By the end of this chapter: I can count one to ten in Tamil and say which of those numbers are inherited across the Dravidian family rather than borrowed.

Pair Tamil pattu with Kannada hattu, apply the same $p \rightarrow h$ softening to pāl/hālu, and identify ēlu as one inherited seven.

7.1 ஒன்று, இரண்டு, மூன்று, நான்கு, ஐந்து — one to five

Five words — and the same point *vaṇakkam* made, told again in numbers: Tamil counts with **its own** words, not borrowed ones.

You'll want to know: The five

	numeral	word	said
1	௧	ஒன்று	<i>onru</i>
2	௨	இரண்டு	<i>iraṇṭu</i>
3	௩	மூன்று	<i>mūṇru</i>
4	௪	நான்கு	<i>nāṇku</i>
5	௫	ஐந்து	<i>aintu</i>

Two writing systems sit side by side here: the **word** (spelled out in letters) and the **numeral** (a single symbol — ௧ ௨ ௩ ௪ ௫, Tamil's own digits, as distinct from 1 2 3 4 5 as they are from Roman I II III). You'll meet the digits again whenever a price or a page number is written in Tamil.

If you’re doing the writing track, you can already read pieces of these: **ந** and **ன** (the *n*-family), **ற** the hard *r* inside *mūnru*, and the **pulli** dot that stacks **ன்ற** into the single cluster you hear in **ஒன்று** and **மூன்று**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*onru*, *iraṇṭu*, *mūnru*, *nānku*, *aintu*”
- read the digits aloud — க ௨ ந ஸ ஐ

Before you move on

Count to five in Tamil. (*Onru*, *iraṇṭu*, *mūnru*, *nānku*, *aintu*.) Are Tamil’s numbers borrowed from Sanskrit, like Hindi’s? (**No** — they’re native Dravidian.) Which two writing systems sit side by side? (Spelled-out **words** and Tamil’s own **numerals**.) Next: compare these native forms across the family.

7.2 Two to five — one family in four regional coats

Hindi’s number forms are Sanskrit worn smooth. Tamil’s are native Dravidian, so their sister-language shapes reveal the family directly.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

	Tamil	Kannada	Telugu	Malayalam
2	<i>iraṇṭu</i>	<i>eraḍu</i>	<i>reṇḍu</i>	<i>raṇṭu</i>
3	<i>mū<u>n</u>ru</i>	<i>mūru</i>	<i>mūḍu</i>	<i>mūnnu</i>
4	<i>nā<u>n</u>ku</i>	<i>nālku</i>	<i>nālugu</i>	<i>nālu</i>
5	<i>aintu</i>	<i>aidu</i>	<i>aidu</i>	<i>añcu</i>

Each row is one word in four regional coats. That shared skeleton is why one Dravidian language gives you a running start on another.

One is less tidy: Tamil *onru*, Kannada *ondu*, and Malayalam *onnu* share old *on-*, while Telugu uses the separate formation *okaṭi*. The family agrees more neatly on 2–5 than on 1.

The letters in this word

In *onru* and *mūnru*, ன்ற is alveolar *n* running into hard *r*, almost one knock: *on-ru*, *muun-ru*. Pulli on ன் removes its vowel before the cluster.

Your turn

- Say it: “iraṇṭu · eraḍu · reṇḍu · raṇṭu”
- Say it: *onru* and *mūnru*, holding ன்ற together
- Identify: Telugu *okaṭi* as the different “one”

Before you move on

Are these forms borrowed? (**No**, native Dravidian.) Which numbers stay tidiest across the family? (**Two through five**.) Which language forms “one” differently? (**Telugu**, *okaṭi*.)

7.3 ஆறு, ஏழு, எட்டு, ஒன்பது, பத்து — six to ten

Five more — and one of them is written with the single letter
Tamil is most proud of.

You’ll want to know: The five

	numeral	word	said
6	சு	ஆறு	<i>āru</i>
7	எ	ஏழு	<i>ēlu</i>
8	அ	எட்டு	<i>eṭṭu</i>
9	கூ	ஒன்பது	<i>onpatu</i>
10	ய	பத்து	<i>pattu</i>

You’ll want to know: Seven carries the letter that names the language

Look at ஏழு (*ēlu*, seven). Its middle letter is ழ — the retroflex approximant, the sound English can only clumsily spell *zh*. It is the rarest and most characteristic sound in Tamil, and it sits inside the language’s **own name**: *Tamiḻ* (தமிழ்) ends in this very letter. So *seven* is a free daily rehearsal of

the sound that says who the language is. Curl the tongue back, don't touch, and voice it: *ē-lu*.

(You met its cousin *ற* — the hard *r* — back in *ஆறு* / *āru*, six. Tamil keeps these apart carefully: *ஆறு* *āru* and *ஏழு* *ēlu* end in two different sounds English would both call “r/zh”.)

Grammar Lens: Nine is built from words you already have

ஒன்பது (*onpatu*, nine) is not a fresh word to memorise — it is two you already know, joined:

ஒன் (*on-*, “one,” from last lesson) + பது (*patu*, “ten”) →
ஒன்பது = “one-to-ten” — one short of ten.

And ten itself is பத்து (*pattu*). Say *onpatu* then *pattu* and you can hear nine leaning on ten. That is a common Dravidian habit — nine described as one-away-from-ten rather than named outright.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*āru*, *ēlu*, *eṭṭu*, *onpatu*, *pattu*”
- seven, feeling the *ழ* — “*ē-lu*”, the sound in *Tamil*
- nine taken apart — “*on* + *patu* → *onpatu*”, one short of ten
- read the digits — கூ ஏ அ கூ டி

Before you move on

Count six to ten in Tamil. (*Āru*, *ēlu*, *eṭṭu*, *onpatu*, *pattu*.) Which number is written with *ழ*, and where else does that letter appear? (**Seven**, *ēlu* — the same letter that ends *Tamil*.) How is **nine** built? (*On* “one” + *patu* “ten” → *onpatu*, one short of ten.) Next: the *puḷḷi* — the dot that takes a consonant's built-in vowel away.

7.4 ீ — the dot that leaves both letters visible

Every consonant carries a built-in **a**. So how do you write a consonant with **no** vowel — the *k* in *vaṇakkam*, or the *m* at the

end?

One dot.

Script you'll notice: The pulli

$$\text{க} = ka \rightarrow \text{ஃ} = k$$

புள்ளி (*pulli*) means simply “the dot.” Written above a letter, it removes the inherent vowel. That’s the whole rule.

A standing note for this whole track. These lessons quote real Tamil words and examples, and most of them contain letters the track has not taught you to draw yet — *pulli*’s own name uses ட, ள and the ூ sign, and the comparisons below reach for others again. **Read anything printed here; only draw the letters a lesson has actually broken into strokes.** The data file behind this track covers 11 letters so far and says so (`complete: false`) — it grows as the chapters need it.

Script you'll notice: What Tamil does *not* do

If you have done the Devanagari track, this is the moment to notice a real divergence.

In Devanagari, killing the vowel makes the bare consonant **fuse** with the next one into a squeezed **conjunct** — स् + त becomes स्त, and the first letter loses its spine. The virama usually disappears into the ligature.

Tamil doesn’t do that. The dot stays visible, and both letters keep their full shape:

Devanagari	स् + त → स्त — a new fused shape
Tamil	ஃ + க → ஃக — two letters, dot intact

The consequence is arithmetic. Tamil’s whole set is **247 characters**: 12 vowels + 18 consonants + the 216 consonant-vowel combinations + the **āytam** ஃ. That is genuinely all of them. Devanagari’s conjuncts run to many hundreds of ligature shapes on top of its letters, each to be learned or at least recognised.

(One honest exception: Tamil does have a few **ligatures borrowed with Sanskrit words** — கஷ kṣa and ஸ்ரீ śrī. They sit outside the 18 native consonants and outside the 247.)

Your turn

Write these out:

- க் — “க, then the dot above”
- க்க — two full letters, dot intact, **no fusing**

Before you move on

What does the **pulli** do, and what does the word mean? (Removes the **inherent vowel**; *pulli* is simply “**the dot**”.) What does Devanagari do that Tamil doesn’t? (**Fuses** the letters into a **conjunct** — Tamil keeps both shapes and the dot.) What does Tamil get in exchange? (A **much smaller character set** — 247, with **almost** no ligatures: only the borrowed శ and ஸ்.) Next: six, seven and ten across the family.

7.5 Six to ten — family resemblances and one Kannada shift

The Tamil forms are learned. Now use their sister shapes as evidence for inheritance and regular sound change.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Six and seven remain close: Tamil *āru*, Kannada *āru*, Malayalam *āru*; Tamil *ēlu*, Kannada *ēlu*, Malayalam *ēlu*. Tamil and Malayalam also keep eight and nine nearly identical: *eṭṭu* and *onpatu/onpatu*.

Telugu wanders on eight and nine with *enimidi* and *tommidi*, so those forms are less reliable as family-wide recognition anchors.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil and Malayalam say **pattu**, while Kannada says **hattu**. The initial *p* → *h* is a regular Kannada shift, not a random replacement. Compare Tamil *pāl*, “milk,” with Kannada *hālu*.

A correspondence lets differences prove relationship: repeated *p/h* pairs are stronger evidence than one accidental resemblance.

Your turn

- *Say it:* Tamil *pattu* · Kannada *hattu*
- *Say it:* Tamil *pāl* · Kannada *hālu*
- *Identify:* *ēlu* / *ēḷu* / *ēlu* as one inherited seven

Before you move on

What happens to Tamil *pattu* in Kannada? (*P* regularly softens to ***h***: *hattu*.) Which second pair confirms the pattern? (*Pāl* / *hālu*, “milk.”)
Which language diverges most on eight and nine? (**Telugu**.)

Chapter 8

Please

By the end of this chapter: I can tell an emphatic தயவுசெய்து from the everyday courtesy that lives in the -உங்கள் verb ending, and pick whichever one the moment actually calls for.

Ask for something twice — தயவுசெய்து when the request needs weight, plain உட்காருங்கள் when it does not — and read the join in செய்து.

8.1 தயவுசெய்து (tayavu seytu) — please (do the kindness)

Across a whole band of Asia, the word for *please* is really the word **compassion**, dressed as a small request. Tamil says it most literally of all: “**do** the kindness.”

You’ll want to know: The phrase

தயவுசெய்து = **please**, literally “**do the kindness / grace**.” It is two pieces snapped together:

- தயவு (*tayavu*) = **kindness, compassion, grace** — from Sanskrit **daya** “compassion.”
- செய்து (*seytu*) = “**having done**,” from the verb செய் (*sey*) “to do.”

So *tayavu seytu* is an invitation: *do me the kindness (of...)*. You place it in front of a request the way English puts “please” in front of one.

This is the same instinct as **Arabic** *min faḍlik* (“from your **grace**”) and **Hindi** *kṛpayā* (from *kṛpā*, “**compassion**”). Naming the kindness you hope for is one of the great strategies of politeness — different from French’s “if it **pleases** you,” and from Latin/German’s “I **ask**.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

All four Dravidian cousins build *please* the very same way — **daya** plus a light verb “do / place / become”:

- Tamil தயவுசெய்து *tayavu seytu* — kindness + **do**
- Kannada ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು *dayaviṭṭu* — compassion + **having placed**
- Telugu దయచేసి *dayacēsi* — compassion + **having done**
- Malayalam ദയവായി *dayavāyi* — compassion + **as / having become**

One idea, four scripts. Learn one and you can almost read the others.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tayavu” — the kindness — then “seytu,” having done
- the whole phrase — “tayavu seytu” = please, do the kindness

Before you move on

What is the Tamil phrase for please? (தயவுசெய்து *tayavu seytu*.) What do its two pieces mean? (“**Kindness**” *tayavu* + “**having done**” *seytu* — *do the kindness*.) Which languages ask the same way? (**Kannada**, **Telugu**, **Malayalam** with *daya*, and further off **Arabic** *faḍl* and **Hindi** *kṛpā*.) Next: decide when the standalone phrase is natural and when the verb carries the courtesy.

8.2 தயவுசெய்து or -உங்கள்? — politeness in phrase or verb

Tamil has a phrase meaning “do the kindness,” but everyday courtesy often sits somewhere English speakers do not expect: inside the verb.

Why it’s said this way

A standalone தயவுசெய்து is more emphatic and formal than English “please.” Ordinary polite commands use respectful -உங்கள் (*-uṅgaḷ*):

- உட்காருங்கள் *utkāruṅgaḷ* — please sit
- சொல்லுங்கள் *soḷḷuṅgaḷ* — please tell me

Use *tayavu seytu* to mark “please, do me the kindness” warmly or formally. Let the verb ending carry routine courtesy.

Script you’ll notice: Read the join in செய்து

செ is *ca* with the ெ sign for *e*. ய் is *ya* shut off by *pulli*, a bare *y*, before து *tu*. The same dot that built numbers now makes the consonant seam in *seytu* visible.

Your turn

- *Choose*: emphatic request → தயவுசெய்து
- *Choose*: ordinary “please sit” → உட்காருங்கள்
- *Break apart*: செ + ய் + து → செய்து

Before you move on

What carries everyday “please”? (The respectful verb ending -*uṅgaḷ*.) When is *tayavu seytu* especially useful? (A **markedly polite or emphatic** request.) What silences *y* in ய்? (The **pulli**.)

8.3 வணக்கம் — the first whole written word

You know the four letter bodies and the vowel-killing dot. Assemble them left to right.

Script you'll notice: Build the word

piece

வ	<i>va</i>	Lesson 1
ண	<i>ṇa</i>	Lesson 2
க்	<i>k</i> — க with the dot	last lesson
க	<i>ka</i>	Lesson 1
ம்	<i>m</i> — ம with the dot	this lesson

வ • ண • க் • க • ம் → வணக்கம்

Hear two details. **க்** is a **doubled** consonant: hold it, *vaṇak-kam*, not *vaṇakam*. Tamil distinguishes single from double consonants. Final **ம்** is a bare *m*, so the word closes instead of trailing into *ma*.

That is the first word of this book, written by hand.

Your turn

- Write it: க் — க with the dot
- Write it: க்க — two full letters, dot intact
- Write it: வணக்கம் — five pieces, left to right
- Say it: “vaṇak-kam” — hold the middle

Before you move on

Write வணக்கம். What is special about க்க? (It is **doubled** and held.) Why does the word end in *m*, not *ma*? (Final **ம்** carries a **pulli**.) Next: the formal way to say *please forgive me*.

Chapter 9

Sorry

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise with மன்னிக்கவும் where its register fits, and say plainly where colloquial Tamil varies by region instead of pretending one form is standard.

Say man-ni-kkavum holding both doubled consonants, use it for a considered apology, and qualify the casual alternatives rather than asserting one.

9.1 மன்னிக்கவும் (mannikkavum) — please forgive

You already know தயவுசெய்து, “please.” Tamil’s “sorry” gives you something its Dravidian cousins don’t: a forgiveness-word that’s Tamil through and through, not borrowed from Sanskrit.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மன்னிக்கவும் is built from three pieces:

- மன்னி (*manni*) = “to forgive, excuse, pardon” — and unlike the words Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam reach for, this is Tamil’s **own** native verb, not borrowed from Sanskrit *kṣamā*.
- -க்க (*-kka*) = an infinitive-forming ending.
- -உம் (*-um*) = a formal, written-register particle used to make a soft, general request or permission — the same particle you’d see on a sign asking visitors to வரவும் (“please come” / “you may

come”).

So மன்னிக்கவும் reads as something like “**may [one] forgive**” — a polite, slightly formal way of asking for forgiveness, more at home in writing or a considered apology than tossed off in passing.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Where Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam all reach for the Sanskrit noun **kṣamā** (“patience, forgiveness”) and turn it into a verb, **Tamil uses its own root**:

- Tamil மன்னிக்கவும் *mannikkavum* — from Tamil மன்னி *manni*
- Kannada ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ *kṣamisi* — from Sanskrit **kṣamā**
- Telugu క్షమించండి *kṣamincaṇḍi* — from Sanskrit **kṣamā**
- Malayalam ക്ഷമിക്കണം *kṣamikkaṇam* — from Sanskrit **kṣamā**

Where “please” showed the whole family sharing one Sanskrit-derived idea (*daya*), “sorry” shows the opposite: Tamil kept its own word while its cousins borrowed the same Sanskrit one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “manni” — forgive — the Tamil root, not from Sanskrit
- the whole word — “mannikkavum” = please forgive
- contrast — Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam all use **kṣamā** instead

Before you move on

What does மன்னிக்கவும் mean, and what is it built from? (“**Please forgive**” — *manni* “to forgive” + *-kkavum*, a formal request ending.) What’s different about Tamil’s forgiveness-word compared to Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam? (**It’s Tamil’s own native root** — the other three borrow Sanskrit **kṣamā** instead.) Next:

place the word in its real register and read the doubled alveolar n.

9.2 மன்னிக்கவும் — formal forgiveness and a doubled n

The root is native Tamil. Its everyday conversational fit is less simple than a one-to-one dictionary entry suggests.

Why it's said this way

மன்னிக்கவும் leans formal: a “please forgive” on a notice or in a considered apology. Spoken Tamil may use shorter regional forms or borrow English “sorry.” Colloquial variation is real, so treat formal/written as a reliable center, not a claim that one casual form covers every region.

Script you'll notice: Read ன்னி

In ன்னி, alveolar ன is first silenced by pulli and then repeated before the vowel. The spelling holds the consonant across the syllable boundary:

ன் + னி → ன்னி — *n-ni*

This is the same gemination-by-repetition principle used elsewhere in Tamil; the sound is doubled without inventing a new ligature.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “man-ni-kkavum,” holding both doubled consonants
- *Choose:* considered/formal apology → மன்னிக்கவும்
- *Qualify:* casual alternatives vary by region

Before you move on

What is the reliable register center of *mannikkavum*? (**Formal/written or considered apology.**) Must every region use it casually? (**No.**) How does ன்னி show a doubled *n*? (Pulli stops the first ன், then full னி follows.)

Chapter 10

Days of the Week

By the end of this chapter: I can name the seven weekdays, take each apart as planet plus கிழமை, and say which are Tamil’s own words and which arrived from Sanskrit.

Run the week from thingal to nāyiru, sorting the four native planet-words from the three Sanskrit ones as you go.

10.1 திங்கள்–ஞாயிறு — a home-grown and borrowed week

Hindi’s week is built entirely from Sanskrit deity-names plus वार (vār). Tamil’s week tells a richer story: it uses its **own** word for “day,” and **some** of its planet-names are Tamil’s own too — while others are borrowed, just like Hindi’s.

Grammar Lens: The pattern: [planet] + கிழமை, “day”

Every Tamil weekday ends in கிழமை (kizhamai), “day” — a native Dravidian word, not the Sanskrit வாரம் (vāram) that Hindi, Kannada, and Telugu build on (though Tamil also keeps a more formal, Sanskritic -vāram set alongside this everyday one):

Tamil weekday	planet-word, meaning, and source
திங்கள்கிழமை	<i>thingal</i> , “ Moon ” — Tamil’s own word
செவ்வாய்க்கிழமை	<i>cevvāy</i> , traditionally “ the red one ” — likely Tamil’s own descriptive name
புதன்கிழமை	<i>pudhan</i> , Mercury — borrowed from Sanskrit Budha
வியாழக்கிழமை	<i>viyāzhan</i> , Jupiter — likely from Sanskrit, via a name for Bṛhaspati
வெள்ளிக்கிழமை	<i>velli</i> , traditionally “ silver ” — likely Tamil’s own descriptive name
சனிக்கிழமை	<i>san̥i</i> , Saturn — borrowed from Sanskrit Śani
ஞாயிற்றுக்கிழமை	<i>ñāyiru</i> , “ Sun ” — Tamil’s own word

Why it’s said this way

Notice the pattern: **Moon**, **Mars**, **Venus**, and **Sun** all carry Tamil’s own descriptive or native words, while **Mercury**, **Jupiter**, and **Saturn** carry Sanskrit ones. This isn’t Tamil “failing” to have its own full week — it’s a genuine **blend**, native Dravidian vocabulary standing right alongside Sanskrit loans, in the same list. (Note for the Tamil-speaking reviewer: this lesson spells Monday திங்கள்கிழமை, the common form — the more traditional sandhi-shifted spelling திங்கட்கிழமை may be preferred and should be swapped in on review if so. The *cevvāy* “red one” and *viyāzhan* Jupiter-name derivations in particular are worth treating as the traditional, commonly-given account rather than settled certainty — exact planet-name histories this old are not always fully nailed down.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “thingal” — moon, Tamil’s own word — then “kizhamai,” day
- the borrowed ones — “pudhan, viyāzhan, sanī” — Mercury, Jupiter, Saturn from Sanskrit
- the native ones — “thingal, cevṡāy, velli, nāyiru” — moon, Mars, Venus, sun

Before you move on

What does every Tamil weekday end in, and where does that word come from? (கிழமை *kizhamai*, “day” — Tamil’s **own** word, not Sanskrit *vāra*.) Which four planet-names are Tamil’s own, and which three are Sanskrit borrowings? (**Moon, Mars, Venus, Sun are native; Mercury, Jupiter, Saturn are Sanskrit** — *Budha, Brhaspati, Śani*.)

10.2 ந, ன, ற — the letter bodies inside நன்றி

Lesson 2 showed you that Tamil has **three** n-letters and promised you’d draw the other two when a word needed them. Chapter 1’s *thank you* needs both.

Script you’ll notice: The two remaining n’s

ந — *na*, the **dental** n, tongue against the teeth:

1. a straight top bar 2. a vertical on the left 3. a second vertical in the middle 4. a right stroke that curls below the baseline and sweeps left into a descender

ன — *na*, the **alveolar** n, tongue on the ridge behind the teeth:

1. a straight top bar 2. a loop on the left 3. one arch 4. a straight vertical on the right, down to the baseline

Compare it with Lesson 2’s ண: same top bar, same loop, same closing vertical. ண **simply has a second arch inserted before that vertical**. So ன is ண **minus one arch** — one arch for ன, two for ண. That is the whole contrast, and it is the cheapest way to keep them apart.

With Lesson 2’s ண (retroflex), that completes the set. Same consonant to an English ear; three letters, three tongue positions, in Tamil.

Script you’ll notice: ற — “ra”, the hard r

1. **two arches side by side** — giving it three legs down to the baseline 2. **the right leg keeps going below the baseline**, sweeps **left**, and drops into a long descender

It is the tallest thing you have drawn: most Tamil letters sit on the baseline, and ற hangs well beneath it.

The dot under r marks it as the *hard* or trilled r, distinct from Tamil’s other r. You’ll meet the contrast properly later; for now, learn the shape.

Your turn

Write these out:

- ற — “top bar, **two** verticals, then the curl that sweeps left”
- ஸ — “top bar, left loop, **one** arch, straight vertical”
- ன — “two arches, then the leg that sweeps left and drops”

Before you move on

Name Tamil’s three n-letters and their tongue positions. (ற dental, ஸ alveolar, ண retroflex.) What are a consonant’s three possibilities so far? (Keep the built-in **a** or **remove** it with the pulli.) Which letter hangs below the baseline? (ற, the hard r.) Next: the colours — black, white, red and blue.

Chapter 11

Colours

By the end of this chapter: I can name black, white, red, and blue in Tamil and say which three are native and which one is the Sanskrit loan.

Say karuppu, vellai and sivappu as the native three, nīlam as the borrowed one, and hear vellai echo velli from last chapter.

11.1 கருப்பு, வெள்ளை, சிவப்பு, நீலம் — three of Tamil’s own, one borrowed

You’ve already seen Tamil mix native and Sanskrit words in its day-names. Colors tell a **cleaner** version of the same story: three colors are Tamil’s own, and the fourth is the one color that keeps showing up borrowed, in language after language.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- கருப்பு (*karuppu*) = “**black**” — native Tamil/Dravidian.
- வெள்ளை (*vellai*) = “**white**” — native Tamil/Dravidian, and built on the very same வெள் (*vel-*, “bright, silvery”) root you already met in வெள்ளி (*veli*), “Venus/silver,” from the days-of-the-week lesson.
- சிவப்பு (*sivappu*) = “**red**” — native Tamil/Dravidian.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நீலம் (*nīlam*) = “blue” — from **Sanskrit** नील (*nīla*), “dark blue,” the very same root behind Hindi’s नीला (*nīlā*). This *nīla* is also the name of the indigo plant and its dye — part of why blue dye is so historically linked to India — but be careful: the English word **indigo** itself is a *separate*, Greek-derived word (describing where the dye was imported *from*, not descended from *nīla* by sound change; see the Hindi color lesson for that careful distinction).

Why it’s said this way

This isn’t random. “**Blue**” is, across many of the world’s languages, one of the **last** basic colors to settle into its own fixed word — often arriving late, or borrowed, compared to black, white, and red. Tamil’s colors look like exactly this pattern in miniature: three old, native words, and one — blue — reaching outside the language for a Sanskrit loan. (Note for the Tamil-speaking reviewer: please confirm *karuppu*, *vellai*, *sivappu*, *nīlam* are the forms you’d teach first — regional/colloquial Tamil may prefer different everyday variants, and this lesson would benefit from your check the way the day-names lesson did.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three native ones — “karuppu, vellai, sivappu” — black, white, red
- the borrowed one — “nīlam” — blue, from Sanskrit
- the echo — “vellai” and “velli” share the same *vel-* root

Before you move on

Which three Tamil colors are native, and which one is borrowed? (**Karuppu, vellai, sivappu** (black/white/red) are native; **nīlam** (blue) is a **Sanskrit** loan.) What root does *vellai* share with a word you already know? (**Vel-** “bright/silvery” — the same root as *velli*, “Venus/silver.”) Why might blue be the one borrowed color? (**Blue is often one of the last basic colors** to settle into a fixed word across many languages — the same pattern Latin’s *caeruleus* showed.)

Chapter 12

Family

By the end of this chapter: I can use Tamil’s four sibling words correctly, settling relative age before gender — the question English never makes you answer.

Name *appā* and *ammā*, then place *aṇṇan*, *tambi*, *akkā* and *tangai* by asking “older, or younger?” before you can say “brother” at all.

12.1 அப்பா, அம்மா, and four sibling words

You’ve learned Spanish *hermano* and *hermana*, plus French *frère* and *sœur* — one word each for “brother” and “sister.” Tamil asks a question those languages never do: **is this sibling older or younger than you?**

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- அப்பா (*appā*) = “**father**”
- அம்மா (*ammā*) = “**mother**”

Both are native Dravidian words, of the same simple, worldwide “baby-talk” shape (a repeated consonant plus a vowel) found across unrelated language families everywhere — not borrowed from Sanskrit, not a coincidence with any one language in particular, just how small children’s mouths tend to form their first words for parents.

You’ll want to know: Siblings — split by age, not just gender

Here’s the real lesson: Tamil doesn’t have one word for “brother” and one for “sister.” It has **four**:

Tamil	meaning
அண்ணன் (<i>aṇṇan</i>)	older brother
தம்பி (<i>tambi</i>)	younger brother
அக்கா (<i>akkā</i>)	older sister
தங்கை (<i>tangai</i>)	younger sister

There is no single Tamil word that just means “brother” the way Spanish *hermano* does — you’re expected to know, and say, **whether they’re older or younger than you** every time you refer to a sibling. This isn’t a small detail: it reflects how central **relative age and seniority** are in South Asian family structure and address — the same instinct that makes “older sibling” versus “younger sibling” a live, spoken distinction, not just something you *could* mention if you wanted to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “appā, ammā” — father, mother
- the four siblings — “aṇṇan, tambi” (older/younger brother), “akkā, tangai” (older/younger sister)
- the key question — “older, or younger?” — before you can even say “brother” or “sister” in Tamil

Before you move on

How many Tamil words mean “brother” or “sister,” and why? (**Four** — அண்ணன்/தம்பி for older/younger brother, அக்கா/தங்கை for older/younger sister — Tamil requires knowing the sibling’s **age relative to you**.) Are அப்பா and அம்மா borrowed from Sanskrit? (**No** — native Dravidian baby-talk-type words, of a shape found across unrelated languages worldwide.)

Chapter 13

Body Parts

By the end of this chapter: I can say head and hand in Tamil, account for why both stayed native here where Hindi's pair came from Sanskrit, and write நன்றி from its pieces.

Say talai and kai, then state the contrast with Hindi's Sanskrit-descended pair.

13.1 தலை, கை — head and hand, both Tamil's own

You've seen Hindi's *sir* and *hāth* trace all the way back to Sanskrit. Tamil's words for the same two body parts tell a simpler story: **both are native**.

You'll want to know: The words

- தலை (*talai*) = “**head**” — native Dravidian.
- கை (*kai*) = “**hand**” — native Dravidian.

Neither is borrowed from Sanskrit, unlike Hindi's *sir* (< Sanskrit *śiras*) or *hāth* (< Sanskrit *hasta*). Tamil simply kept its own words for two of the most basic parts of the body.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “talai” — head

- “kai” — hand
- the contrast — Hindi borrowed these from Sanskrit; Tamil didn’t

Before you move on

What are Tamil’s words for head and hand? (தலை *talai*, கை *kai*.)
Are either of these Sanskrit loans? (**No** — both native Dravidian,
unlike Hindi’s Sanskrit-descended *sir* and *hāth*.)

13.2 ி and நன்றி — replace the vowel, then hear *ndr*

A consonant can keep *a* or lose it under a pulli. The third option is to replace it with a vowel sign.

Script you’ll notice: The first vowel sign

ற = ra → றி = ri

ி is a hook above and to the right. The consonant keeps its shape; the sign hangs from it. Later, ை (ai) will appear before its consonant on the page but after it in speech, the same eye/ear trap as Devanagari ि.

Script you’ll notice: Assemble நன்றி

ந · ன் · றி → நன்றி

piece

ந	<i>na</i> — dental	last lesson
ன்	<u><i>n</i></u> — alveolar, with pulli	Lessons 3–4
றி	<u><i>ri</i></u> — ற plus the i-sign	this lesson

The letters in this word

ன் + ற is pronounced close to **ndr**. This follows a broader Tamil rule:
a **nasal voices the stop after it**.

ந் + த	<i>nd</i>	வந்து <i>vandu</i>
ண் + ட	<i>ṇḍ</i>	retroflex pair
ன் + ற	<i>ndr</i>	நன்றி

Each n-letter creates its own cluster. That payoff explains both the three spellings and the common English romanization **nandri**, whose *d* is heard but not separately written.

Your turn

- Write it: றி — ற plus the hook above right
- Write it: நன்றி — three pieces
- Say it: “ன் + ற = ndr”

Before you move on

What are a consonant's three vowel choices? (Keep inherent **a**, **re-move** it with pulli, or **replace** it with a vowel sign.) Where does ி attach? (**Above and right**.) Why is *nanri* often written *nandri*? (ன் + ற is pronounced *ndr* because a nasal voices the following stop.)

Chapter 14

Seasons

By the end of this chapter: I can name the four seasons in Tamil and say honestly which one is locally central instead of repeating a Western four-way split.

Build kodai/mazhai/kulir onto kaalam, name mazhai kaalam as the season that actually organises the year, and flag vasantha as the one loanword.

14.1 வசந்த காலம், கோடை, மழை, குளிர் — the four words, and the real season underneath

Tamil has words that line up with Spanish’s four seasons — but, just like Hindi’s ऋतु, forcing them into a clean four-way split hides what actually matters on the ground.

You’ll want to know: The four words

Tamil	meaning	source
வசந்த காலம் (<i>vasantha kaalam</i>)	“spring”	<i>vasantham</i> is a Sanskrit loan
கோடைக் காலம் (<i>kodai kaalam</i>)	“summer”	கோடை <i>kodai</i> is native Tamil for “heat”
மழைக் காலம் (<i>mazhai kaalam</i>)	“rainy season”	மழை <i>mazhai</i> , native Tamil for “rain”
குளிர் காலம் (<i>kulir kaalam</i>)	“winter/cold season”	குளிர் <i>kulir</i> , native Tamil for “cold”

Every one of these is built the same way: a word for the **feel** of the season (heat, rain, cold — or the borrowed *vasantham*) plus காலம் (*kaalam*), “**time/season**.” Be honest about *kaalam* itself, too: it’s ultimately from Sanskrit काल (*kāla*, “time”) — but it was assimilated into Tamil so long ago and so thoroughly that it functions as completely ordinary vocabulary today, quite unlike a fresh, still-foreign-feeling loan like *vasantham*.

Why it’s said this way

Just as Hindi’s traditional calendar makes the monsoon (*varṣā*) its own central season rather than a footnote, Tamil Nadu’s actual climate is shaped far more by மழைக்காலம் (*mazhai kaalam*, “the rains”) than by any crisp four-way Western split. There’s no dramatic autumn leaf-fall in a tropical climate, and “spring” as a distinct, keenly-felt season is a much weaker idea here than in temperate Europe. The four words above are real and used — but the rains, not a European four-season year, are what actually organizes agricultural and everyday life across much of Tamil Nadu.

(Note for the Tamil-speaking reviewer: please check whether these are the words and register you’d teach first, and whether there’s more to say about how Tamil Nadu’s own seasonal year is actually divided in practice.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kodai” — heat/summer, native — then “kaalam,” time/season
- “mazhai kaalam” — the rains, the real central season
- “kulir kaalam” — the cold season
- the one loanword — “vasantha kaalam,” spring, from Sanskrit

Before you move on

Which of the four season-words is a Sanskrit loan, and which are native Tamil? (வசந்தம் *vasantham* is Sanskrit; கோடை, மழை, குளிர் are all native.) What season actually shapes life in Tamil Nadu the most, and why doesn’t the four-season frame capture that? (மழைக்காலம், the **rains** — Tamil Nadu’s tropical climate doesn’t

14.1. வசந்த காலம் கோடைக் காலம் மழைக் காலம் குளிர் காலம்⁶¹

have a sharp four-way split the way temperate Europe does.)

Chapter 15

Water and Rice

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for water and keep raw அரிசி apart from cooked சாதம், and state how far the arisi-to-“rice” claim can honestly be pushed.

Assemble taṇ plus n̄r into taṇṇ̄r, switch between arisi and sātam by whether it is cooked, and label the English “rice” link as contested.

15.1 தண்ணீர், அரிசி, சாதம் — water, and rice, the real staple

European languages teach “bread” as the staple food. Here, that would be **dishonest** — bread isn’t the everyday staple in Tamil food culture. **Rice** is, and it comes with one of the most famous (if contested) etymological journeys of any food-word.

You’ll want to know: தண்ணீர் — water, literally “cool water”

தண்ணீர் (*taṇṇ̄r*) = “**water**” — built from தண் (*taṇ*, “cool”) + நீர் (*n̄r*, “**water**”). Everyday Tamil doesn’t just say “water” — it says, quite literally, “cool water.”

You’ll want to know: அரிசி and சாதம் — rice, raw and cooked

Tamil, like most of South India, distinguishes the **uncooked grain** from the **cooked dish** with two separate words, not one:

- அரிசி (*arisi*) = “**rice**” (the raw, husked grain) — native Dravidian.
- சாதம் (*sātam*) = “**cooked rice**” (the meal itself, what’s actually eaten) — likely Sanskrit-influenced. Tamil also keeps a native word for the same idea, சோறு (*cōru*) — the two sit side by side as everyday near-synonyms.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the exciting part, held with appropriate care: many etymologists connect அரிசி (*arisi*) to the **English word “rice” itself** — the proposed chain runs Dravidian *arisi* → **Greek** *óryza* → Latin *oryza* → Old French *ris* → English **rice**. If true, English speakers have been saying a Dravidian word for centuries without knowing it. But be honest: standard etymological dictionaries mark Greek *óryza*’s origin as **genuinely uncertain** — a Dravidian source is one widely cited hypothesis among others (an Indo-Aryan *vr̥hi*-related source is also proposed), not a settled, universally agreed fact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “taṇ” — cool — then “nīr,” water — then “taṇṇīr,” cool water
- “arisi” — raw rice — then “sātam,” cooked rice
- the famous (contested) link — “arisi” → possibly English “rice”

Before you move on

What does தண்ணீர் literally mean? (“**Cool water**” — taṇ “cool” + nīr “water.”) What two words does Tamil use for rice, and why two? (அரிசி *arisi*, raw grain; சாதம் *sātam*, cooked rice — the raw grain and the cooked meal get separate words.) Is it certain that English “rice” comes from Tamil *arisi*? (**Not certain** — it’s a widely cited hypothesis via Greek *óryza*, but that Greek word’s origin is genuinely disputed among etymologists.)

Chapter 16

Tamil Months

By the end of this chapter: I can name the twelve months of the Tamil solar calendar and place Tamil New Year and Pongal inside it.

Recite Chithirai through Panguni, then date Tamil New Year to Chithirai 1 and Pongal to Thai 1.

16.1 சித்திரை to பங்குனி — Tamil’s own solar calendar

By now you’ve seen Arabic and Hindi each juggle two calendars. Tamil adds a **third distinct system** to the mix — one still actively used for Tamil New Year and Pongal, not a historical curiosity.

You’ll want to know: The twelve Tamil months

சித்திரை, வைகாசி, ஆனி, ஆடி, ஆவணி, புரட்டாசி, ஐப்பசி, கார்த்திகை, மார்கழி, தை, மாசி, பங்குனி (*Chithirai, Vaikāsi, Āni, Ādi, Āvaṇi, Purattāsi, Aippasi, Kārthigai, Mārgazhi, Thai, Māsi, Panguni*).

This is the **Tamil solar calendar** — a real, independent civil calendar, distinct from both the Gregorian calendar and the Hindu lunisolar (Vikram Samvat-style) calendar. Its months are traditionally tied to **nakshatras** (the 27 lunar-mansion star groups): each month is named for the nakshatra the **moon** sits near on the **full-moon (pournami) day** that falls within that month — the moon’s position, not the sun’s, and tied to that month’s full moon specifically, not simply the month’s start.

Why it's said this way

You've now met three genuinely separate calendar traditions: the Gregorian solar calendar (borrowed names, everyday civil use in most of the world), the pan-Indian Hindu lunisolar calendar (Chaitra, Vaishākh... tied to the six *ṛtu*), and now Tamil's **own** solar calendar, following neither. சித்திரை 1 (the 1st of Chithirai) is **Tamil New Year**;தை 1 (the 1st of Thai) is **Pongal**, one of Tamil Nadu's most important harvest festivals. These dates are fixed by the Tamil solar calendar, and only shift slightly against the Gregorian calendar (rather than drifting widely, the way lunar/lunisolar festival dates do) because it's solar too — just a different solar calendar, starting its year at a different point and naming its months differently.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “Chithirai, Vaikāsi, Āṇi, Āḍi, Āvaṇi, Purattāsi, Aippasi, Kārthigai, Mārgazhi, Thai, Māsi, Panguni”
- “Chithirai 1” — Tamil New Year
- “Thai 1” — Pongal

Before you move on

What kind of calendar is the Tamil month system — solar, lunar, or lunisolar? (**Solar** — a genuinely separate calendar from both Gregorian and Hindu lunisolar.) What are the twelve months traditionally named for? (**Nakshatras**, lunar-mansion star groups.) What two important occasions are dated by this calendar? (**Tamil New Year** (Chithirai 1) and **Pongal** (Thai 1).)

16.2 ஆம் — writing a word that starts with a vowel

Every vowel *sign* so far has hooked onto a consonant — the ி on ற. This word has no consonant to hook onto.

Script you'll notice: a vowel standing alone

Tamil writes a vowel two ways, and which one you use depends on **where it sits**:

inside a word, after a consonant	a small sign — ி in றி
starting a word, with nothing before it	a full independent letter

ஆ is the independent letter for long $\bar{a}$. It is not a sign and never hangs off anything; it is a letter in its own right.

Long $\bar{a}$ is short அ plus a tail, so அ is where it starts — and you have not been shown that one yet. Its parts, then the tail:

1. **a curl at the upper left** 2. **a long horizontal stroke** 3. **a straight vertical on the right** — that is அ 4. **a tail added on the right** — and now it is ஆ

Those are the parts in writing order. Where the pen lifts is not settled: Tamil handwriting varies by region and by school, and this book only claims a pen path where it has a sourced one.

That is a rule, not a special case: any Tamil word that opens on a vowel opens with a full vowel letter.

Script you'll notice: build the word

piece

ஆ	$\bar{a}$	this lesson — independent
ம்	m — ம with the pulli	the dot you already know

ஆ · ம் → ஆம்

Two pieces only. The pulli on ம closes the word on a bare m , exactly as it did at the end of வணக்கம்.

Your turn

Write these out:

- அ — curl, horizontal, right vertical

- ஆ — the same three parts, then the right-hand tail
- ம் — ம with the dot
- ஆம் — two pieces, left to right

Before you move on

Write ஆம். When does a Tamil vowel get a full letter instead of a sign? (**When it starts a word** — nothing precedes it to hook onto.) What closes the word? (ம் — the pulli on ம.) Next: noon and midnight.

Chapter 17

Noon and Midnight

By the end of this chapter: I can use both the fused and the transparent Tamil words for noon and midnight, and point to the நடு “middle” that makes one pair readable on sight.

Say naṇpakal beside naṭuppakal and naḷḷiravu beside naṭu iravu, pointing at naṭu as the everyday “middle” still visible in the second of each pair.

17.1 நண்பகல், நள்ளிரவு — one old “middle” root, two survival stories

You’ve just watched Kannada and Telugu each reach for Sanskrit’s *madhya* to name noon. Tamil doesn’t reach for Sanskrit at all here — it reaches into its own, much older layer of vocabulary instead.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Both of today’s words trace back to the same root: நள் (*naḷ*), a **Proto-Dravidian** word for “**middle, centre**” — a genuine synonym of the everyday நடு (*naṭu*, “middle”) you already know, just from an older layer of the vocabulary. நள் didn’t disappear from Tamil; it survives today mainly in **literary/poetic** compounds — நள்ளிருள் (*naḷḷirul*, “thick darkness”) and நள்ளென் கங்குல் (*naḷḷen kaṅkul*, “deep night”) — rather than in everyday colloquial speech.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நள்ளிரவு (*nalliravu*) = “**midnight**” = நள் (*nal*, “middle”) + இரவு (*iravu*, “**night**,” a word every Tamil speaker still uses on its own) — நள் shows up here exactly as you’d expect. நண்பகல் (*nanpakal*) = “**noon, midday**” traces to the **same** நள் root, fused with பகல் (*pakal*, “**daytime**”) — but here it surfaces as நண்- rather than நள்-, a sandhi-driven surface change before the following ப. Same root, two different faces, depending on what it’s fused to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “naḷ” — an old word for “middle” — then “naḷiravu,” midnight
- “nanpakal” — noon, the same naḷ root, resurfacing as naṇ-

Before you move on

What old Proto-Dravidian root do நண்பகல் and நள்ளிரவு both trace back to, and what does it mean? (நள் *naḷ*, “middle” — surviving mainly in literary compounds like *nallirul*, “thick darkness.”) Why does it surface as **naṇ-** in *nanpakal*? (A sandhi change before following **p**.) Does Tamil reach for Sanskrit here? (**No**.) Next: meet the transparent *naṭu* synonyms Tamil kept beside these older compounds.

17.2 நடுப்பகல் and நடு இரவு — the transparent twins

Nanpakal and *nalliravu* preserve an older middle-root in fused forms. Tamil also kept versions whose pieces remain obvious today.

You’ll want to know: The living synonyms

- நடுப்பகல் (*naṭuppakal*) — “middle-daytime,” a dictionary synonym of *nanpakal*
- நடு இரவு (*naṭu iravu*) — “middle night,” the transparent synonym of *nalliravu*

Both use நடு (*naṭu*, “middle”), the everyday word still heard in *naṭuvē*, “in the middle.”

Latin daughter languages often inherit one fate for an old compound: eroded or transparent. Tamil kept **both fates inside one language**—old fused forms and fresh transparent synonyms side by side.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “naṇpakal · naṭuppakal” — two noon forms
- *Say it*: “naḷḷiravu · naṭu iravu” — two midnight forms
- *Point to*: *naṭu* as the visible everyday “middle”

Before you move on

Which everyday word builds the transparent forms? (நடு, *naṭu*, “middle.”) What did Tamil keep simultaneously? (**Older fused compounds and transparent synonyms.**) Are any pieces Sanskrit loans? (**No.**)

Chapter 18

Telling Time

By the end of this chapter: I can tell the time on the hour in Tamil and keep the hour-word மணி apart from the unrelated Sanskrit gem-word spelled exactly the same way.

Say oru maṇi and iraṇṭu maṇi for one and two o'clock, then choose hour or gem by the context the word sits in.

18.1 மணி — Tamil’s native “bell,” and a real homophone trap

You’ve just watched Kannada and Telugu both borrow Sanskrit’s “bell” word for “hour,” matching Hindi exactly. Tamil goes its own way again here — with a genuinely tricky twist along the way.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மணி (*maṇi*) = “hour, o’clock” — and it also means “bell, gong,” the same double duty you’ve now seen several times. Wiktionary’s Tamil entry gives this *maṇi* its **own etymology**, separate from a Sanskrit-loan entry of the same spelling — most likely a **native Dravidian** word, not the Sanskrit घण्टा (*ghaṇṭā*) behind Kannada’s *gaṇṭe*, Telugu’s *gaṇṭa*, and Hindi’s *ghaṇṭā*. On this account, Tamil underwent the **same** “a bell announces the hour, so the bell-word becomes the hour-word” shift on its own, from a different starting point — though even the comparative Dravidian dictionary (DEDR) flags a possible Sanskrit connection for this whole word-family as unresolved, so hold “native” as the best current account rather than a settled fact.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “maṇi” — hour, also “bell” — native, NOT from Sanskrit ghaṇṭā

Before you move on

Is Tamil’s மணி (“hour”) from the same Sanskrit root as Kan-nada/Telugu/Hindi’s hour-words? (**Most likely no** — it’s treated as a native Dravidian “bell” word that independently reached “hour” the same way, though even DEDR flags this as not fully settled.) What semantic path links the meanings? (A **bell announces the hour.**) Next: writing இல்லை — a second independent vowel, ல, and the ai sign.

18.2 இல்லை — a vowel in front, a vowel sign behind

Last lesson gave you the rule: a word opening on a vowel opens with a full letter. Here is the same rule with a different vowel, plus one new sign.

Script you’ll notice: இ and ல

இ is the independent letter for short *i* — the same job ஆ did, one vowel over. Its parts, in writing order:

1. **a crossing spiral on the left**
2. **a tall straight vertical on the right**

ல is *la*, with its built-in *a* like every consonant:

1. **a curl that turns back on itself**
 2. **a stroke rising to the right**
- Put the pulli on it and you get ல், a bare *l*.

The new mark is ை, the sign for *ai*, and it does something ி did not.

It is written to the LEFT of its consonant, but pronounced after it.

ல + ை → லை, and on the page the hook stands *before* the ல — yet you say *lai*, not *ail*.

Your eye meets the vowel first and your mouth says it second. Devanagari does the same thing with ि, and it catches everyone once.

Tamil keeps **three** *l*-letters (ல ள ழ) and **two** *r*-letters (ர ற), the same way it keeps three *n*'s. This is the first of the *l*'s.

Script you'll notice: build the word

piece

இ	<i>i</i>	independent — the word opens on a vowel
ல்	<i>l</i> — ல with the pulli	bare consonant
லை	<i>lai</i> — ல with the ai sign	this lesson

இ · ல் · லை → இல்லை

The ல் + லை is a doubled *l*, held like the க் of *vaṇakkam*: *il-lai*, not *ilai*.

Your turn

- Write it: இ — spiral, then the right-hand vertical
- Write it: ல — curl, then rising stroke
- Write it: லை — the ai hook goes on the LEFT
- Write it: இல்லை — three pieces
- Say it: “il-lai” — hold the doubled *l*

Before you move on

Write இல்லை. Why does it open with இ rather than a sign? (**The word starts on a vowel.**) Which side of its consonant does ை sit on? (**The left** — written first, spoken second.) Next: the gem-word homophone, and telling clock time.

18.3 மணி — hour or jewel? Context decides

The likely native bell/hour word shares its spelling and sound with a clear Sanskrit loan meaning something entirely different.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil dictionaries list a second மணி from Sanskrit मणि (*maṇi*), “gem, jewel.” On that analysis, bell/hour and gem are **homophones**: one likely native, one borrowed, identical on the page. Context separates clock time from a jewel or personal name.

Malayalam dictionaries analyze their cognate differently, treating bell/hour and gem as one Sanskrit-derived word. Closely related languages do not always settle the same etymological question in the same way.

Grammar Lens: Tell the time

ஒரு மணி. — one o’clock, literally “one hour/bell”

>

இரண்டு மணி. — two o’clock

The number comes first; *maṇi* supplies the clock unit.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “oru maṇi” — one o’clock
- *Say it*: “iraṇṭu maṇi” — two o’clock
- *Choose by context*: clock → hour · jewelry/name → gem

Before you move on

What is the homophone trap? (A likely separate Sanskrit-borrowed மணி means **gem**.) Does Malayalam analyze the same forms identically? (**No**.) How do you say two o’clock? (இரண்டு மணி, *iraṇṭu maṇi*.)

Chapter 19

Asking Someone's Age

By the end of this chapter: I can ask someone's age in both the casual possessive shape and the formal dative-plus-become shape, and answer with my own.

Ask “un vayasu enna?” casually, ask “unakku ettanai vayathu aakirathu?” formally, and answer “enakku irupathu vayathu aakirathu.”

19.1 உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது? — Tamil actually has BOTH shapes

Same Sanskrit word one more time — but be careful here: Tamil isn't locked into just one of the two grammatical shapes you've now seen. It has both, in different registers.

You'll want to know: வயது — the same Sanskrit “vigor/age” word, a fourth time

வயது (*vayathu*) = “age” — the same Sanskrit वयस् (*vayas*, “age, vigor,” PIE cousin of Latin *vīs*) you've now met four times across Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam, and Tamil. All four Dravidian languages borrowed this exact Sanskrit word for “age” — none of them built a native alternative for this particular concept, the way they did for so many others.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “vayathu” — age
- *Connect:* Sanskrit *vayas* · Tamil *vayathu* · Latin *vīs*

Before you move on

Is Tamil's வயது the same Sanskrit word borrowed by all four Dravidian languages here? (**Yes** — none built a native alternative for this concept.) What did *vayas* originally include besides age? (**Vigor**.) Next: choose between Tamil's casual possessive and formal dative-plus-become shapes.

19.2 Your age what? / To you how many years becomes?

Tamil did not choose one age construction. Register selects between two shapes already visible elsewhere in the family.

Grammar Lens: Casual possessive

உன் வயசு என்ன? — “your age what?”

Casual speech uses a plain possessive with no dative and no verb, like Kannada and Telugu.

Grammar Lens: Formal dative plus “become”

உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது? — “to you how many years is becoming?”

>

எனக்கு இருபது வயது ஆகிறது. — “to me twenty years is becoming.”

Formal/written Tamil uses the dative experiencer plus ஆகிறது (*aakirathu*, “is becoming,” from *aaku*). Malayalam uses a similar dative shape but chooses “exists” instead.

Do not compress these into “Tamil’s one grammar.” Both live in the language; setting and register choose between them.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “un vayas enna?” — casual

- *Say it*: “unakku ettanai vayathu aakirathu?” — formal
- *Answer*: “enakku irupathu vayathu aakirathu”

Before you move on

Which shape is casual? (**Possessive**: “your age what?”) Which is formal? (**Dative** + **aakirathu**, “become.”) Does Malayalam use the same verb? (**No** — it uses “exists.”)

19.3 ஈரி — one letter, several sounds

You have seen ஈ cover *k*, *g* and a soft *h* depending on where it sits. Here is the same economy on a second letter.

Script you’ll notice: ஈ and ர

ஈ is written once and does the work English splits between **s**, **ch** and **j**. Position picks which:

where	sound
starting a word	<i>s</i> or <i>ch</i>
between vowels	softened
after a nasal, as in ஈர	<i>j</i>

That is exactly the pattern ஈ showed — *k* at the start, *g* after a nasal, a soft *h* between vowels. One letter per position of the mouth, and context fills in the rest.

ர is *ra*, with its built-in *a*. It is the other of Tamil’s **two** *r*-letters, alongside the ர you met in நன்றி.

Read both letters here; do not draw them yet. This book gives a stroke order only where it has a sourced one, and ஈ and ர do not have one yet.

Script you’ll notice: build the word

piece		
ஈ	<i>sa</i> here	this lesson
ரி	<i>ri</i> — ர with the ி sign	the sign from நன்றி

ச • ரி → சரி

Two pieces, and both parts are things you already hold: a consonant, and the vowel sign you first hooked onto ற.

Your turn

- *Read it:* ச — then சரி
- *Say it:* “sari”
- *Contrast:* ரி and லை — the ி sign follows its letter, the ை sign precedes it
- *Write it:* ஆம் and இல்லை again, from memory — yes and no, the two you will reach for most

Before you move on

Read சரி. Which English sounds does ச cover on its own? (*s* or *ch* at the start, softened between vowels, *j* after a nasal.) How many *r*-letters does Tamil keep? (**Two** — ர and ற.) In லை, which side of the ல does the ai sign sit on? (**The left.**) And why does இல்லை open with இ rather than a sign? (**It starts on a vowel.**) Next: the numbers eleven to twenty.

Chapter 20

Numbers Eleven to Twenty and Weather

By the end of this chapter: I can count eleven to twenty as the transparent compounds they are, and say what the weather is doing.

Take vāṇilai apart into vāṇam plus ṇilai, then report the weather with mazhai peykiRathu.

20.1 பதினொன்று-இருபது — shared Dravidian patterns

Here’s how this arc closes: four completely different approaches to “twenty” across Sanskrit, Latin, Arabic — and then all four Dravidian languages quietly agreeing on the exact same compositional idea.

You’ll want to know: பதினொன்று-பத்தொன்பது — “ten” + digit

Tamil’s teens echo பத்து (*pathu*, “ten”) plus each digit — பதினொன்று (*patinondru*, 11), பன்னிரண்டு (*pannirandu*, 12), and onward through பத்தொன்பது (*pattonbatu*, 19) — the same digit-plus- ten-echo compounding you’ve now seen across Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam.

You’ll want to know: இருபது — transparently “two-tens”

இருபது (*irupathu*, “twenty”) = இரு (*iru*, an older word for “two,” alongside the everyday இரண்டு *irandu*) + பத்து (*pathu*, “ten”) — fully trans-

parent as “**two-tens**,” matching **Malayalam**’s own *irupathu* almost letter-for-letter.

Why it’s said this way

This closes the numbers arc with a genuinely clean pattern. All four major Dravidian languages build “twenty” the **same** compositional way — some (Tamil, Malayalam) keeping it fully transparent on the surface today, some (Kannada) with the same compositional origin but no longer visibly matching the modern standalone words for “two” and “ten,” some (Telugu) worn down further but most likely from the same root. Compare that to the other three families you’ve met: Sanskrit’s *विंशति* (*vimshati*), Latin’s *vīgintī*, and Arabic’s *عشرون* (*‘ishrūn*) are each their **own** special, non-compositional word for twenty — none built transparently from “two” and “ten” the way Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, and Malayalam all do.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “patinondru, panniranḍu” — 11, 12
- “iru” — an older word for two, “pathu” — ten
- “irupathu” — twenty, “two-tens,” transparent

Before you move on

What two pieces build இருபது (twenty)? (இரு “two” + பத்து “ten” — “**two-tens**.”) Do all four major Dravidian languages build “twenty” the same compositional way? (**Yes** — Tamil and Malayalam keep it fully transparent today; Kannada shares the same compositional origin but its modern “two”/“ten” words no longer visibly match; Telugu’s is worn down further but most likely the same root.) Do Sanskrit, Latin, or Arabic build their word for twenty this way? (**No** — each has its own special, non-compositional standalone word instead.)

20.2 வானிலை — “the standing of the sky,” most likely all native

You’ve now seen a Persian+Sanskrit hybrid (Kannada), a pure Sanskrit compound (Telugu), and a Sanskrit compound echoing “time” (Malayalam). Tamil most likely breaks the pattern one more time — with a word built entirely from native pieces.

You’ll want to know: வானிலை — vaanam + nilai

வானிலை (*vāṇilai*) = “**weather**” — built from:

- வானம் (*vāṇam*, “**sky**”) — most likely a **native Dravidian** word, with confirmed cognates in **Kannada** ಬಾಸು (*bānu*, “sky”) and **Telugu** వాన (*vāna*, “rain,” from the same sky/rain-cloud root) — distinct from the Sanskrit sky word *ākāśa* that those same two languages use elsewhere.
- நிலை (*ṇilai*, “**state, standing, condition**”) — from நில் (*ṇil*, “**to stand**”), one of Tamil’s most basic native verb roots.

So *vāṇilai* literally means “**the standing of the sky**” or “**the sky’s state**” — and unlike its three Dravidian cousins, neither piece here is a Sanskrit or Persian/Arabic loan. (Treat “native” as the best current account rather than a fully settled fact, the same hedge every native-word claim here deserves — but both pieces are independently well-attested as old, native Dravidian vocabulary.)

You’ll want to know: மழை பெய்கிறது — “rain is falling”

மழை பெய்கிறது. — “It’s raining.” — literally “**rain is falling**.” (*mazhai peykiRathu* — from பெய் *pey*, “to fall/pour,” specifically used for rain.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vāṇilai” — weather, “the standing of the sky”
- “vāṇam” — sky, “ṇilai” — state, from “ṇil,” to stand
- “mazhai peykiRathu” — it’s raining, “rain is falling”

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of வானிலை, and what does the whole word literally mean? (வானம், “sky,” + நிலை, “state/standing” — “**the standing of the sky**.”) Is either piece a Sanskrit or Persian/Arabic loan, unlike Kannada, Telugu, or Malayalam’s weather words? (**Most likely not** — both pieces are native Dravidian.) What Tamil word does Malayalam’s *mazha* match for “rain”? (மழை, *mazhai*.)

Chapter 21

Dog and Cat

***By the end of this chapter:** I can say dog and cat in Tamil and say which of the two rests on an undisputed Dravidian root and which sits inside a three-way family split.*

*Say *nāy* and *pūnai*, then place Kannada’s *bekku* and Telugu’s *pilli* as two other roots entirely rather than variants of the same word.*

21.1 நாய், பூனை — solid ground to close the arc, and an honest three-way split

This whole ANIMALS arc kept finding mystery dog-words — Spanish’s *perro*, English’s *dog*, Hindi’s *kuttā*, each one an unsolved puzzle displacing an older, expected word. Tamil’s dog-word closes the arc on the complete opposite footing: total, undisputed solid ground.

You’ll want to know: நாய் — no mystery, anywhere

நாய் (*nāy*, “**dog**”) is a solid, native **Proto-Dravidian** root — the exact same one behind Kannada’s ನಾಯಿ (*nāyi*) and Malayalam’s നായ (*nāya*). There is no debate about its origin, no substrate mystery, nothing like the *perro/dog/kuttā* pattern that ran through Spanish, English, and Hindi. Three unrelated language families each lost their expected word for “dog” to an unexplained newcomer — and right here, in the Dravidian family, the expected word simply **survived**, plainly and solidly, across (at least) three of its languages.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பூனை (*pūnai*, “cat”) is Tamil’s own everyday word, matching Malayalam’s பூച്ച (*pūcha*) closely — but be honest that “cat” splits Dravidian in a way “dog” doesn’t. Kannada’s everyday word, ಬೆಕ್ಕು (*bekku*), comes from a **different** ancient root (related to the word for “wildcat”); Telugu’s, పిల్లి (*pilli*), comes from yet **another** separate Proto-Dravidian root, most likely the very source behind Sanskrit’s *biḍāla* and Hindi’s *billi*. Tamil itself even keeps **rarer, alternate** cat-words — பில்லி and வெருகு — cognate with Telugu’s and Kannada’s everyday choices respectively, showing that all three roots were once available across the family; each language just settled on a different one as its everyday word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāy” — dog, solid native Dravidian, no mystery anywhere
- “pūnai” — cat, Tamil’s everyday word, matching Malayalam
- the honest split — Kannada’s *bekku* and Telugu’s *pilli* come from two other, separate ancient roots

Before you move on

Is நாய் a mystery word, like Spanish’s *perro*, English’s *dog*, or Hindi’s *kuttā*? (**No** — a solid, undisputed native Dravidian root, shared with Kannada and Malayalam.) Does பூனை share a root with Kannada’s *bekku* or Telugu’s *pilli*? (**No** — all three are genuinely separate ancient Dravidian roots; Tamil even keeps rarer alternate cat-words, *pilli* and *veruku*, echoing both of them.) Which Dravidian cat-word is most likely the source of Sanskrit’s *biḍāla* and Hindi’s *billi*? (**Telugu’s pilli.**)

21.2 என் — the third vowel that opens a word

You know the rule already: a Tamil word that opens on a vowel opens with a **full vowel letter**, never a sign. You have seen it twice — ஆ in *ām*, இ in *illai*. Here is the third, in a word you have been saying since chapter 2.

Script you’ll notice: எ

எ is the independent letter for short *e*. Same job as ஆ and இ, one more vowel along.

ஆ	opens <i>ām</i>
இ	opens <i>illai</i>
எ	opens <i>eṇ</i>

Three words, three different vowels, one rule doing the work each time. That is what makes the rule worth having: you did not need to be told about எ separately, only that word-initial vowels get a full letter.

Read எ; do not draw it yet. This book gives a stroke order only where it has a sourced one, and எ does not have one yet.

Script you’ll notice: build the word

piece

எ	<i>e</i>	independent — the word opens on a vowel
என்	bare <i>n</i> — ன under a pulli	the alveolar <i>n</i> , from நன்றி

எ • என் → என்

Two pieces, and you have met both halves before: the alveolar ன is the middle one of Tamil’s three *n*’s, and the dot on top is the same pulli that closes வணக்கம்.

Your turn

- *Read it:* எ — then என்
- *Say it:* “eṇ” — “my”
- *Contrast:* ஆம் • இல்லை • என் — three words, three opening vowels

Before you move on

Read என். Why does it open with a full எ rather than a sign? (**The word starts on a vowel** — there is no consonant to hook onto.) Which vowel opens இல்லை? (இ.) What is the dot doing on ன்? (**Removing the built-in a**, leaving a bare n.) Next: green and yellow, and a colour word the whole Dravidian family shares.

Chapter 22

Green and Yellow

By the end of this chapter: I can say green and yellow in Tamil, recognise பச்சை as a rarer doublet, and keep the pan-Dravidian root separate from the independent one.

Say பச்சை as the pan-Dravidian green, மஞ்சள் as a separate native yellow, and பச்சை as the rarer doublet beside them.

22.1 பச்சை, மஞ்சள் — closing the Dravidian arc, holding both patterns at once

You’ve now seen three different Dravidian answers to “how do green and yellow relate”: Kannada split them apart, Telugu fused them into one root, Malayalam kept them as two separate native words. Tamil, it turns out, quietly contains a trace of **both** of the last two patterns.

You’ll want to know: பச்சை — the familiar pan-Dravidian green

பச்சை (paccai, “green”) ← Proto-Dravidian **pac-* — the same root you’ve now met four times: Kannada’s *hasiru*, Telugu’s *pacca*, Malayalam’s *paccha*, and now Tamil’s own *paccai*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மஞ்சள் (mañçal, “yellow, turmeric”) is Tamil’s actual, everyday word for yellow — and it comes from a **completely separate** native Dravidian root, matching Malayalam’s മഞ്ഞ/മഞ്ഞൾ

(*mañña/maññaḷ*) closely. Like Malayalam’s pair, this root has no Sanskrit involvement — it sits alongside *paccai*, not descended from it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The **Tamil Lexicon** also records பசுப்பு (*pacuppu*, “greenish yellow”) — a genuine **doublet** of *paccai* itself, from the same **pac-* root, matching Telugu’s *pasupu* closely. Unlike Telugu, though, this doublet is **not** Tamil’s everyday word for yellow — that job belongs to *mañcaḷ*; *pacuppu* survives mainly as a dictionary-recorded shade word. So Tamil alone holds a trace of **both** patterns at once: a *pac-* doublet sitting quietly in the dictionary (Telugu’s pattern), next to a separate, dominant root doing the everyday work (Malayalam’s pattern).

(Note for the Tamil-speaking reviewer: *pacuppu*’s everyday currency is the part I’m least certain of — please confirm whether it’s a word you’d recognize as “greenish yellow,” or whether it reads as archaic/purely literary in the Tamil you’d teach first.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “பச்சை” — green, the pan-Dravidian *pac-* word
- “மஞ்சள்” — yellow, Tamil’s real everyday word, a separate root
- “பசுப்பு” — a rarer doublet of *paccai*, echoing Telugu’s pattern

Before you move on

What is Tamil’s everyday word for yellow, and is it related to **paccai**? (மஞ்சள், *mañcaḷ* — **no**, a completely separate native root, matching Malayalam’s *mañña/maññaḷ*.) What rarer Tamil word **IS** a doublet of *paccai*, from the same *pac-* root? (பசுப்பு, *pacuppu*, “greenish yellow” — echoing Telugu’s *pacca/pasupu* pattern.) Does any one pattern hold across all four major Dravidian languages? (**No** — Kannada splits native/loan, Telugu fuses one root, Malayalam keeps two separate roots, and Tamil turns out to hold traces of both Telugu’s and Malayalam’s patterns at once.)

Chapter 23

Day

By the end of this chapter: I can use நாள் as the everyday word for day and keep தினம் for the formal compounds where it actually belongs.

Say mūnru nāl for three days and sutantira tiṇam for Independence Day, classifying each as everyday-native or formal-Sanskrit.

23.1 நாள் (nāl) — “day,” the one this arc’s Dravidian languages didn’t lose

You’ve now seen three Dravidian languages reach for a loanword — Sanskrit, twice, and Persian once — to name their everyday word for “day.” Tamil doesn’t. This lesson is about the one that didn’t.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நாள் (nāl) — “day” — is native **Dravidian**, from **Proto-Dravidian** *nāl. You’ve already met it, hiding inside நாளை (nālai, “tomorrow,” Chapter 4). But here’s the honest headline of this lesson: நாள் isn’t a survivor clinging to one narrow sense the way some native Dravidian words are — it is simply Tamil’s **plain, everyday, unmarked** word for counting a day, as ordinary as மூன்று நாள் (mūnru nāl, “three days”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāl” — “day,” native Dravidian, already met inside “tomorrow”
- “mūnru nāl” — three days

Before you move on

Where did you already meet நாள் before this lesson? (Inside நாளை, *nālai*, “tomorrow,” Chapter 4.) Is Tamil’s everyday day-word a loanword? (No — நாள் is native Dravidian.) Is it marginal or literary? (No — it is the plain everyday counting word.) Next: compare the other sisters’ borrowed day-words and Tamil’s formal *tiṇam*.

23.2 நாள் and தினம் — everyday native, formal borrowed

Nāl is plainly native and everyday. Put that lexical choice beside the other Dravidian tracks.

You’ll want to know: Four everyday day-words

- Kannada **dina** — Sanskrit tatsama
- Telugu **rōju** — Persian loan
- Malayalam **divasam** — Sanskrit tatsama
- Tamil **nāl** — native Dravidian

Tamil is the only one here whose unmarked everyday counting word remains native.

You’ll want to know: Tamil still has தினம்

தினம் (*tiṇam*) is the same Sanskrit *dina* as Kannada/Malayalam, ultimately from PIE *dyew-*, “shine,” also behind Latin *diēs*. Tamil assigns it formal and compound work: சுதந்திர தினம், “Independence Day,” and தினசரி, “daily.” Casual counting remains *nāl*.

The language did not reject the loan; it gave native and borrowed forms different jobs.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “mūnru nāl̥” — three days
- *Say it*: “sutantira tinam” — Independence Day
- *Sort*: everyday native · formal/compound Sanskrit

Before you move on

Which track alone keeps a native everyday day-word? (**Tamil**.)
Where does *tīnam* appear? (**Formal compounds**.) Is it unrelated to Kannada *dīna*? (**No** — it is the same Sanskrit tatsama.)

23.3 ಂಘಞ — a sign that waits on the left

One vowel sign you have met does something strange: ೆ stands to the **left** of its consonant and is spoken **after** it. That was not a one-off. Here is a second sign with the same habit.

Script you’ll notice: ್ and ೃ

Two consonants, each carrying its built-in *a* like every other:

ೞ	<i>pa</i>
ೞ	<i>ya</i>

Read both; do not draw them yet. Neither has a sourced stroke order in this book’s script data, so neither gets one here.

Script you’ll notice: the ೆ sign

ೆ is the sign for *e*, and **it is written to the LEFT of its consonant and pronounced after it** — exactly what ೆ does.

ೞ + ೆ → ೆೞ, and on the page the hook stands *before* the ೞ
— yet you say *pe*, not *ep*.

So the left-standing signs are a family, not an exception you have to remember one member at a time. Compare the three vowel signs you now hold:

sign	sound	where it sits
ி	<i>i</i>	above and to the right
ை	<i>ai</i>	to the left , spoken after
ெ	<i>e</i>	to the left , spoken after

Be clear about how well attested each half of that is. The sourced description covers ை — “a double hook written *BEFORE* (to the left of) the consonant, though pronounced *after it*.” There is no such entry for ெ yet, so the claim that ெ sits on the left is stated from the pattern the two signs share, not from a source for ெ itself. It is reliable — this is ordinary Tamil orthography — but it is one step further from the page than the ை rule is.

Script you’ll notice: build the word

piece		
பெ	<i>pe</i> — ப with the ெ sign on its left	this lesson
ய	<i>ya</i>	this lesson
ர்	bare <i>r</i> — ர under a pulli	ர from சரி

பெ · ய · ர் → பெயர்

Three pieces for a word you have used since chapter 2 without once needing to read it. That is the point of the order: the word came first, and the letters are catching up to a word you already own.

Your turn

- *Read it:* ப · ய — then பெ — then பெயர்
- *Say it:* “peyar” — “name”
- *Read it:* என் பெயர் — “my name,” both words, straight off the page
- *Contrast:* றி and பெ — the ி sign follows, the ெ sign precedes

Before you move on

Read பெயர். Which side of its consonant does ெ sit on, and when is it spoken? (**The left**, and **after** — like ை.) Name the other left-standing sign you know. (ஐ, as in இல்லை.) Read என் பெயர் and say what it means. (“**My name**” — எ opens on a vowel, ர் closes on a bare *r*.) Next: the word for night.

Chapter 24

Night

By the end of this chapter: I can use இரவு for night and இருள் for darkness without collapsing the two, and treat the claim that ராத்திரி is the more colloquial word as a claim still to be tested.

State the source’s rāttiri claim with its hedge intact, set it against native regional usage, and hold iravu and iruḷ apart.

24.1 இரவு (iravu) — “night,” and a register question worth a native speaker’s ear

Last lesson, Tamil’s native day-word had no real competition. This lesson’s honest twist, hedged carefully, is that “night” may not tell the same story — and this is exactly the kind of claim worth checking against your own ear, not just a dictionary’s.

You’ll want to know: இரவு — already standing on its own, inside “midnight”

இரவு (iravu) — “night” — is native **Dravidian**, from **Proto-Dravidian** **cira* (“darkness”). You’ve technically already met it standing fully on its own: Chapter 17, while explaining நள்ளிரவு (*nalliravu*, “midnight,” நள் + இரவு), noted directly that இரவு itself is a word every Tamil speaker still uses on its own. This lesson gives it its own full chapter.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil also keeps ராத்திரி (*rāttiri*), a Sanskrit **tatsama** from रात्रि (*rātri*) — the same word that surfaces, as a tatsama, in Kannada’s

ratri and Telugu’s *ratri*. It traces to **Proto-Indo-European** **h₁reh₁-* (“to rest”), a **completely different** root from Latin *nox*’s **nók^wts* — the same specific comparison already drawn for Hindi’s *raat* and Malayalam’s *rāthri*, now a third confirmation, same false-cognate pattern, same honest non-relationship to *nox*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “iravu” — “night,” native, already met inside *nalliravu*
- “rāttiri” — Sanskrit loan, same PIE *h₁reh₁-* already drawn for Hindi and Malayalam, *NOT* related to Latin *nox*

Before you move on

Where did you already meet இரவு before this lesson? (Inside நள்ளிரவு, *nalliravu*, “midnight,” Chapter 17.) Does ராத்திரி’s PIE root match Latin *nox*’s? (No — **h₁reh₁-* “to rest,” the same false-cognate pattern already drawn for Hindi and Malayalam.) Next: treat the proposed register split as a hypothesis and keep “darkness” separate from “night.”

24.2 Night words — a register hypothesis and a semantic boundary

Iravu is native and *rāttiri* borrowed. That alone does not tell you which one conversational Tamil prefers.

Why it’s said this way

At least one dictionary says ராத்திரி is more common colloquially, implying native இரவு may lean literary/written. If accurate, this reverses the day story, where native *nāl* is uncontested everyday speech. But the evidence is limited and dictionary-level. Treat this as a prompt for a native speaker’s ear, not settled fact. Register judgments require real usage, region, and setting—not a purity assumption about native versus borrowed words.

You'll want to know: Darkness is a different word

இருள் (*irul*) means **darkness**, from Proto-Dravidian *cirVl* and cognate with Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam forms. It is not *iravu* “night as a time period” and comes from a different reconstructed root despite the similar sound.

Your turn

- *Qualify*: “one source says *rāttiri* is more colloquial”
- *Ask*: compare that claim with native regional usage
- *Contrast*: *iravu* night · *irul* darkness

Before you move on

Is the *rāttiri* register claim settled? (**No** — limited sourcing, worth checking against native usage.) Is இருள் interchangeable with இரவு? (**No** — darkness versus a time period, from different roots.)

Chapter 25

Good Night

By the end of this chapter: I can say good night in Tamil out of roots I already own, and trace every one of those forms back to நல்.

Say nalla iravu and iravu vaṇakkam, then run nal- forward into nalam, nanri and nalla.

25.1 இனிய இரவு (iniya iravu) — “good night,” and Tamil breaking the pattern one more time

Hindi, Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam all reached for the same Sanskrit phrase to say “good night.” This lesson closes the arc with the one that didn’t — and it’s a pattern you’ve actually seen from Tamil before, all the way back in Chapter 1.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

இனிய இரவு (iniya iravu) — “good night” — literally “sweet, pleasant night.” இனிய (iniya, “sweet, pleasant, dear”) is native Dravidian, from Proto-Dravidian **in-* (“sweet”) — the same root behind இனிப்பு (inippu, “sweet, dessert”). Paired with இரவு (iravu, “night,” already met last lesson), the whole phrase is built from Tamil’s own word-stock, start to finish.

Why it’s said this way

Tamil’s Dravidian sisters and Hindi all reached for the **same** Sanskrit phrase: Hindi’s शुभ रात्रि, Kannada’s ಶುಭ ರಾತ್ರಿ, Telugu’s శుభ రాత్రి, Malay-

alam’s ശുഭ രാത്രി — all four built from the identical tatsama pair, **śubh** (“to be beautiful”) + **rātri** (“night”). Tamil’s standard phrase reaches for **none** of that — no śubha-descended “good night” turned up as a commonly used Tamil form in the phrasebook sources checked for this lesson. Instead, Tamil built its own phrase from its own vocabulary.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*inīya iravu*” — “good night,” literally “sweet night,” fully native
- the pattern it breaks — every other language this arc shares one Sanskrit śubh(a) rātri phrase; Tamil doesn’t

Before you move on

What does இனிய இரவு literally mean, and what root does இனிய come from? (“**Sweet/pleasant night**” — Proto-Dravidian *in-*, “sweet.”) Does Tamil’s “good night” share the same Sanskrit śubha rātri phrase as Hindi, Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam? (**No** — no such form turned up in the sources checked for this lesson; Tamil’s standard phrase is fully native, breaking the pattern shared by all four other languages.) Next: connect that choice back to Chapter 1 and build two native alternatives.

25.2 நல்ல இரவு and இரவு வணக்கம் — old roots recombined

Tamil’s native “sweet night” repeats the lexical choice that opened this book: build greetings from its own roots rather than the shared Sanskrit formula.

You’ll want to know: The Chapter 1 echo

வணக்கம் comes from native *vaṇaṅku*, “bow,” while neighboring greetings use Sanskrit *namas-*. At the other end of the day, இனிய இரவு is native while the same neighbors share Sanskrit *śubha rātri*.

Tamil also keeps two transparent alternatives:

- நல்ல இரவு — “good night,” using *nalla*, from the **nal-** “good” root already inside *na^lam* and *naⁿri*
- இரவு வணக்கம் — “night greetings,” especially for close friends/family, recombining two fully known words

The learner does not memorize isolated formulas; known roots generate options.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “nalla iravu” — good night
- *Say it:* “iravu vaṇakkam” — night greetings
- *Trace it:* *nal-* → *na^lam* / *naⁿri* / *nalla*

Before you move on

Which root builds நல்ல? (**Nal-**, good.) What two known words make இரவு வணக்கம்? (**Night + greetings**.) What lexical pattern connects Chapter 1 and this chapter? (**Tamil keeps native greeting roots where neighbors share Sanskrit formulas**.)

Chapter 26

Morning

By the end of this chapter: I can say காலை for morning and state accurately that its origin is uncertain, rather than asserting a Sanskrit source the dictionary itself only hedges at.

Say k̄alai, repeat the source’s own “possibly” instead of dropping it, and read atikaalai as a transparent ati- plus k̄alai compound.

26.1 காலை (k̄alai) — “morning,” an honestly uncertain etymology

Tamil’s neighbours each had a confidently-sourced story for their “morning” word — Sanskrit, or clearly native. Tamil’s own word for morning is different: even Wiktionary itself isn’t sure where it comes from.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

காலை (k̄alai) — “**morning**” — has an etymology that Wiktionary itself only hedges at: “**possibly** from Sanskrit काल्य (k̄alya).” That’s a real hedge from the source itself, not one this lesson is adding for caution’s sake. Complicating things further: the related word கால் (kāl) carries **six** entirely distinct etymologies in Tamil — “leg/foot,” “irrigation channel,” “forest,” “wind,” a Sanskrit-derived “time” sense, and a conjunction meaning “if, when” — and காலை may be an accusative-type form built on the “time” sense specifically, or may not be. Be honest: this is genuinely **less settled** than Kannada’s confidently-native morning word or Telugu’s confidently-Sanskrit one. Don’t manufacture certainty the primary source itself doesn’t have.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Wiktionary does confirm one solid fact: பகல் (already met, Chapter 17, “daytime”) is listed as காலை’s **coordinate term** — the two words sit side by side in the same semantic field, whatever காலை’s deeper root turns out to be. And அதிகாலை (“early dawn”) is confirmed, per the Tamil Lexicon, as a fully transparent compound: **ati-** (“excessive, very”) + காலை, glossed simply as “early dawn” by the Tamil Lexicon.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kālai” — “morning,” an honestly uncertain etymology
- the hedge itself — Wiktionary says “possibly” Sanskrit kālya, not a confident claim
- “atikaalai” — “early dawn,” a transparent ati- + kālai compound

Before you move on

Is காலை’s etymology as confidently sourced as Kannada’s or Telugu’s morning words? (**No** — Wiktionary itself only says “possibly” Sanskrit kālya; genuinely uncertain, not settled.) What coordinate term does Wiktionary list alongside காலை? (பகல், “daytime,” already met in Chapter 17.) What does அதிகாலை literally build on? (**ati-** (“very”) + காலை — a transparent compound for “early dawn.”)

Chapter 27

Evening

By the end of this chapter: I can say மாலை for evening and keep it apart from the identically spelled garland word, which is a separate etymology rather than a second sense.

Say mālai for evening, name the garland mālai as a distinct homonym, and mark the “darkness” link as plausible but not spelled out.

27.1 மாலை (mālai) — “evening,” and a garland that only looks like the same word

Last lesson’s morning word had an uncertain origin. This evening word is different — confidently native — but it comes with its own honest twist: it looks exactly like a completely unrelated word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மாலை (mālai) — “evening” — happens to be spelled identically to another, completely **unrelated** Tamil word: மாலை meaning “garland, wreath, necklace.” Wiktionary treats these as **two separate etymologies**, not one word with two senses. The garland sense traces to Old Tamil and is compared to Sanskrit माला (mālā) — with a genuinely interesting note: it’s “**probably borrowed FROM Dravidian languages**” into Sanskrit, not the other way around. A rare reverse-direction loan, worth noticing against this whole project’s usual Sanskrit-into-Dravidian pattern.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The **evening** sense of மாலை is a **separate** Old Tamil word entirely, compared instead to மால் (*māl*) — which Wiktionary traces to **Proto-Dravidian** **mā/*māl*, with senses including “கருமை” (“**blackness, darkness**”), plus archaic senses of “illusion, confusion” and, as a proper noun, the Hindu deity **Vishnu**. Be honest about the exact mechanism here: Wiktionary’s own etymology for “evening” only says “**compare māl**” — it does **not** explicitly state that “evening” derives specifically from the **darkness** sense rather than some other sense of this multi-meaning root. The connection (evening = the time it grows dark) is natural and plausible, but not nailed down with full certainty by the source itself. What **IS** certain: this is confidently **native** Dravidian vocabulary, a genuine contrast with TA-C26’s uncertain காலை.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mālai” — “evening,” confidently native Dravidian vocabulary
- the homonym twist — a completely separate word, mālai, means “garland,” probably borrowed INTO Sanskrit from Dravidian
- the honest hedge — “evening” plausibly connects to māl’s “darkness” sense, but Wiktionary doesn’t spell out that exact link

Before you move on

Are evening-mālai and garland-mālai the same word with two meanings? (**No** — Wiktionary treats them as two entirely separate etymologies; a genuine homonym, not one word stretched.) Which direction did the garland sense’s Sanskrit connection likely travel? (**Dravidian into Sanskrit** — a reverse-direction loan, per Wiktionary’s own “probably borrowed from Dravidian languages” note.) Is it fully certain that “evening” derives from māl’s “darkness” sense specifically? (**No** — plausible and natural, but Wiktionary only says “compare māl,” without spelling out that exact mechanism.)

Chapter 28

Afternoon

By the end of this chapter: I can say பிற்பகல் for afternoon, read it as “after” plus “daytime,” and name exactly where the dictionary’s own noon and afternoon labels overlap.

Show natuppakal straddling noon and afternoon, place matiyam as a Sanskrit noon-word, and label the unsourced moon claim unsupported.

28.1 பிற்பகல் (pirpakal) — “afternoon,” a similar sandhi trick to நண்பகல்

You already met a sandhi-driven surface change in Chapter 17 — நள் resurfacing as நண். This lesson’s afternoon word does a similar kind of trick, with a different word — though be honest that the two changes aren’t identical.

You’ll want to know: பிற்பகல் — பின் (after) + பகல் (daytime), a similar sandhi story

பிற்பகல் (pirpakal) — “afternoon” — is a transparent compound: பின் (pin, “after”) plus பகல் (pakal, “daytime,” already met inside நண்பகல், TA-C17 — though be aware the பிற்பகல் Wiktionary page itself glosses பகல் as “noon” in its own etymology line, a small inconsistency across Wiktionary’s own entries, not something this lesson introduces). Here’s the familiar pattern: பின் doesn’t stay பின் in this compound — it surfaces as பிற்ப- before the following ப — a **similar** kind of consonant sandhi to the one already taught in Chapter 17, where நள் became நண் before its own following ப. Be honest, though: Wiktionary’s

own etymology for பிற்பகல் doesn't discuss this mechanism at all, and the two changes move in different phonetic directions (nasal→stop here, lateral→nasal there) — this is the lesson's own observation, not a sourced equivalence. Wiktionary labels this word **formal register**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*pirpakal*” — “afternoon,” *pin* (“after”) + *pakal* (“daytime”)
- the sandhi echo — *pin* surfaces as *pir-*, a similar kind of change to TA-C17's *naḷ*→*naṇ*, though not phonetically identical

Before you move on

What does பிற்பகல் literally build from, and what sandhi change happens to the first piece? (*பின்* “after” + *பகல்* “daytime” — *பின்* surfaces as *பிற்-*, a similar kind of sandhi to TA-C17's *naḷ*→*naṇ*, though the two changes move in different phonetic directions, not identical mechanisms.) What register does the fetched page label? (**Formal**.) Next: inspect the real noon/afternoon boundary blur and the separate *matiyam* root.

28.2 Noon or afternoon? — let the sources keep their blur

Pirpakal transparently says after-daytime. Dictionaries still do not draw a perfectly hard semantic boundary around its synonyms.

You'll want to know: நடுப்பகல் overlaps

Wiktionary's *pirpakal* page lists நடுப்பகல் as an afternoon synonym, while the earlier noon lesson documents the same word as a synonym of நண்பகல், “noon.” This is genuine noon/afternoon boundary blur, not an inconsistency to erase. Time-period categories can widen differently across speakers and sources.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மதியம் (*matiyam*) is a Sanskrit tatsama from *madhya*, “middle,” the same root used by Kannada and Telugu. The fetched entry gives it **noon**, a synonym of *naṇpakal*, not a dedicated afternoon meaning. An initial search summary claimed *matiyam* once meant “moon,” but that claim is absent from the actual fetched page. It is therefore **not asserted**. Source inspection outranks a search snippet.

Your turn

- *Say it*: *naṇupakal* can overlap noon and afternoon
- *Say it*: *matiyam* — Sanskrit *madhya*, “middle,” listed as noon
- *Label*: the moon claim unsupported

Before you move on

Does the source draw a hard noon/afternoon line? (**No.**) What is *matiyam*’s sourced root and sense? (Sanskrit *madhya*, “middle,” and **noon**.) Is “originally moon” confirmed? (**No.**)

Chapter 29

Good Morning

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone with காலை வணக்கம் before mid-morning and see it as காலை plus the வணக்கம் I already had, with no borrowed blessing-word in it.

Greet with k̄alai vaṇakkam from sunrise to about 11, naming its two known pieces and the borrowed word that is absent.

29.1 காலை வணக்கம் — “morning greetings”

Tamil’s neighbours each built “good morning” on a word meaning “good” or “auspicious.” Tamil does something completely different: it just puts its everyday greeting word after its word for “morning.”

You’ll want to know: காலை வணக்கம் — literally, “morning greetings”

காலை வணக்கம் (k̄alai vaṇakkam) — “good morning” — is confirmed, by two independently-fetched sources, as Tamil’s standard greeting for this time of day, used “**from sunrise until around 11 AM.**” It’s built from two words you already have: காலை (already met, Chapter 26, “morning”) plus வணக்கம் (already met, Chapter 1, “reverence, homage” — Tamil’s everyday word for “hello”). Literally: “morning salutations.”

Why it's said this way

Here's the honest structural surprise: Hindi, Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam each build their morning greeting on a **śubha**-equivalent word (“good, auspicious”) plus a time-word. Tamil does something genuinely **different** — there's no “good/auspicious” word here at all. It's simply **வணக்கம்**, Tamil's own general greeting, specified with **காலை** in front of it to mean “morning” greetings specifically. Also be honest about a claim that didn't hold up: an initial search summary suggested a Sanskrit-borrowed word, “suprabhatham,” serves as a casual alternative — but that claim appears on **neither** of the two pages actually fetched, so it's deliberately **not** asserted here.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “kālai vaṇakkam” — “good morning,” literally “morning greetings”
- [YOU SAY: the honest structural surprise — no śubha-equivalent word here at all, unlike Tamil's
neighbours]
- *Say it*: the two pieces you already know — kālai (Chapter 26) + vaṇakkam (Chapter 1)

Before you move on

- What two known words build **காலை வணக்கம்**? (**காலை**, “morning” + **வணக்கம்**, “reverence/hello.”)
- Does it follow the śubha-equivalent + time-word pattern used by Hindi, Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam? (**No** — **காலை** simply specifies Tamil's own general greeting, **வணக்கம்**.)
- Is “suprabhatham” confirmed as a casual alternative? (**No** — neither fetched source supports that claim, so this lesson does not assert it.)

Chapter 30

Good Evening

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone with மாலை வணக்கம் from late afternoon through nightfall, built on the same two-piece pattern as the morning greeting.

Greet with mālai vaṇakkam, assembling mālai plus vaṇakkam, and note the pattern was re-checked rather than assumed to carry over.

30.1 மாலை வணக்கம் — “evening greetings”

Last chapter’s morning greeting followed its own pattern. This lesson checks whether the evening greeting follows the same one — rather than assuming it automatically does.

You’ll want to know: மாலை வணக்கம் — the same compositional pattern, independently confirmed

மாலை வணக்கம் (mālai vaṇakkam) — “good evening” — is confirmed, by two independently-fetched sources, as a real, standard Tamil evening greeting, used roughly from **afternoon through nightfall** (the two sources give slightly different exact windows — “after noon through evening” versus “late afternoon until nightfall” — a small, unsurprising looseness, matching the noon/afternoon boundary-blur already seen in TA-C28). It’s built exactly the same way as TA-C29’s morning greeting: மாலை (already met, Chapter 27, “evening”) plus வணக்கம் (already met, Chapter 1, Tamil’s general greeting). Literally: “evening salutations.”

Why it's said this way

Here's the honest methodological point: just because TA-C29's morning greeting followed the “time-word + vaṇakkam” pattern doesn't mean this evening greeting was assumed to follow it automatically. This arc has repeatedly found that greeting formation doesn't reliably generalize, even within the very same language — Malayalam's own morning greeting broke from the śubha+time-word pattern its afternoon and evening greetings both share, so “the pattern probably repeats” was never a safe assumption on its own. So this greeting was independently verified via direct fetch before confirming the pattern really does repeat here — and it does, cleanly: no śubha-equivalent word appears in Tamil's evening greeting either, same as the morning one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mālai vaṇakkam” — “good evening,” literally “evening greetings”
- the two pieces you already know — mālai (Chapter 27) + vaṇakkam (Chapter 1)
- the honest methodological point — this pattern was re-verified, not assumed to carry over automatically

Before you move on

What two already-known words does மாலை வணக்கம் build from? (மாலை, “evening” + வணக்கம், “greetings.”) Was it assumed that the evening greeting would follow the same pattern as the morning one, or was it independently checked? (**Independently checked** — via direct fetch, not assumed, since this arc has learned that greeting patterns don't reliably generalize.) Does மாலை வணக்கம் use a śubha-equivalent word, like Hindi/Kannada/Telugu/Malayalam's evening greetings do? (**No** — same as Tamil's morning greeting, no śubha-equivalent word appears here either.)

Chapter 31

Good Afternoon

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone with மதிய வணக்கம் around midday and say which word the மதிய inside it actually comes from — noon, not afternoon.

Greet with matiya vaṇakkam, trace matiyam back to madhya “middle,” and keep pirpakal as the separate after-plus-daytime word.

31.1 மதிய வணக்கம் (matiya vaṇakkam) — a sourced afternoon greeting

You already know that Tamil’s noon and afternoon boundaries can blur. Now learn one afternoon greeting without pretending that all speakers or teaching sources divide the day in exactly the same way.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மதிய வணக்கம் (matiya vaṇakkam) — “good afternoon” — is confirmed, by two independently-fetched sources, as Tamil’s afternoon greeting, used roughly “**noon to around 4 PM.**” A third source, already used for the morning and evening greetings, doesn’t list a distinct afternoon greeting at all — it only covers “before noon” and “after noon through evening,” implicitly treating those two as bookending the whole day. This is an honest extension of TA-C28’s own noon/afternoon boundary-blur into the greeting layer, not a new problem to worry about. Use மதிய வணக்கம் when that afternoon slot fits the people and setting around you. Treat “noon to 4” as a useful learning window, not as a universal clock rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “matiya vaṇakkam” — “good afternoon,” confirmed real, used roughly noon to 4 PM
- the honest qualification — one source does not teach a separate afternoon greeting at all

Before you move on

What is one sourced Tamil greeting for “good afternoon”? (மதிய வணக்கம், **matiya vaṇakkam**.) Do all three fetched sources agree on a distinct “afternoon” greeting slot? (No — two confirm மதிய வணக்கம் directly; a third doesn’t list a separate afternoon greeting at all, treating morning and evening as bookending the day.) What clock window is a useful guide rather than a universal rule? (Roughly noon to 4 PM.)

31.2 மதிய — the greeting takes a different root

You can now say மதிய வணக்கம். This final step explains why its first word is not the ordinary afternoon word பிற்பகல்.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The greeting begins with மதிய (**matiya**). It is the adjectival form of மதியம் (**matiyam**), “noon.” That noun entered Tamil from Sanskrit **madhya**, “middle”: noon is the middle of the day.

The adjective மதிய can be glossed “of or pertaining to afternoon.” That lets Tamil build மதிய வணக்கம் even though the dedicated word you learned for “afternoon” was பிற்பகல், the native compound from **pin** (after) + **pakal** (daytime).

Keep the two paths separate:

- பிற்பகல்: after + daytime → afternoon
- மதிய வணக்கம்: middle/noon adjective + greeting → good afternoon

The time word and the greeting do not have to share a root. That is

one more reason not to manufacture a greeting by translating its pieces from another language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- matiyam — “noon,” ultimately from Sanskrit madhya, “middle”
- pirpakal — “afternoon,” built from “after” + “daytime”
- matiya vaṇakkam — the afternoon greeting, built on matiya

Before you move on

Does மதிய வணக்கம் begin with பிற்பகல்? (No.) What noun is மதிய related to? (மதியம், “noon.”) What older root lies behind it? (Sanskrit madhya, “middle.”) Why should you learn the whole greeting rather than construct it from the time word? (Tamil uses a different root in the greeting.)

Chapter 32

The Core Verbs

By the end of this chapter: I can build a Tamil verb as stem plus tense plus person, swap the tense bead for past or future, tell a strong verb from a weak one by its doubled consonant, and say why தெரியும் carries no person at all.

Say எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும், name the three slots that built irukkīrēn, pōgīrēn and pārkīrēn, and explain which slot தெரியும் leaves empty and where its person went instead.

32.1 இரு (iru) — “to be,” and the machine inside every Tamil verb

Thirty-one chapters of words. Now the engine room. Tamil builds a verb the way you thread beads on a string, and this first verb carries the whole string.

You’ll want to know: இரு

இரு — *iru* — to be, to exist, to stay

It is native Dravidian, from an old root meaning “be, remain, stay put.” Kannada kept the very same word, ಇರು (*iru*), and Malayalam has ഇരിക്കുക (*irikkuka*); Telugu went its own way with ఉండు (*undu*).

Iru is about **existing** or **being somewhere**, not about linking two nouns. Tamil says “I am at home” with *iru*, and says “I am a teacher” with no verb at all, just the two words side by side.

Its everyday first-person form is இருக்கிறேன் (*irukkīrēn*), “I am.” You have already heard it: the question *eppadi irukkīrēgal?* — “how are you?” — is this verb wearing a different ending.

The letters in this word

இ (the standing vowel *i*) + ரு (*ru*) → இரு. Both shapes turned up in இரவு (*iravu*, “night”).

In *irukkirēn* the க் is held long — *i-ruk-ki*, with a catch in the middle. That length is not decoration; a later lesson turns it into a rule.

Grammar Lens: stem, then tense, then person

English changes a verb by putting words **around** it: *I am, I was, I will be*. Tamil changes it by gluing pieces **onto the end** of it, always in the same order:

இரு + க்கிற் + ஏன் → இருக்கிறேன்

>

iru (be) + *-kkir-* (happening now) + *-ēn* (I) → *irukkirēn*

Left to right, the word says **be** — **present** — **I**. Three slots, filled in that order, welded into one word. Languages built this way are called **agglutinative**, from Latin *glutinare*, “to glue.”

Two payoffs arrive at once. The last piece already means “I,” so *nān* is optional. And nothing here belongs to *iru* alone: every verb in this chapter is the same three slots with a new first bead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “iru” — be, exist, stay
- “irukkirēn” — I am
- the three beads in order — “iru ... kkir ... ēn”

Before you move on

What are the three pieces of *irukkirēn*, in order? (**Stem, tense, person** — *iru*, *-kkir-*, *-ēn*.) Which piece carries “I”? (**The last one**, *-ēn* — which is why *nān* can be dropped.) Which sister language kept

the same verb? (**Kannada**, *iru.*) Next: the same machine, with the tense bead swapped.

32.2 പോ ($p\bar{o}$) — “to go,” and the bead that carries time

You have the three slots — stem, tense, person. Keep the first and last beads still, and swap only the middle one. That is the whole of Tamil tense.

You’ll want to know: പോ

പോ — $p\bar{o}$ — to go

Two letters, പ (pa) with the long- $\bar{o}$ sign, and a word so old it has barely moved. It is native Dravidian: Telugu పోవు ($p\bar{o}vu$) and Malayalam പോകുക ($p\bar{o}kuka$) are the same verb.

Kannada’s everyday word for “go” is ಹೋಗು ($h\bar{o}gu$) — and that h is not a different root. It is the same softening of an old p that turned Tamil *pattu* (“ten”) into Kannada *hattu*. One sound-law, met once with numbers, now paying off with a verb.

You met the bare stem in the farewell chapter, where $p\bar{o}!$ is already a whole command: “go!”

Grammar Lens: past, present, future — one bead each

Hold the stem $p\bar{o}$ - and the person-ending $-\bar{e}n$ (“I”) fixed, and let the middle piece do the work:

when	Tamil	the middle bead
now	$p\bar{o}g\bar{i}r\bar{e}n$	$-g\bar{i}r-$
already	$p\bar{o}n\bar{e}n$	$-n-$
not yet	$p\bar{o}v\bar{e}n$	$-v-$

“I go,” “I went,” “I will go” — one syllable of difference, sitting between two pieces that never moved. English needs a new word (*will*) or a whole new shape (*went*); Tamil needs one bead.

The tense bead voices to $-g\bar{i}r-$ after a vowel, which is why it sounds like $p\bar{o}-gi-r\bar{e}n$ here but *iruk-ki-r $\bar{e}n$* after the doubled k of *iru*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pō” — go
- the three times — “pōgīrēn ... pōnēn ... pōvēn”
- the pair that shares one sound-law — “pattu ... hattu”, “pō ... hōgu”
- “irukkirēn” and “pōgīrēn” — one machine, two stems

Before you move on

Which of the three beads changes for tense? (**The middle one.**)
 Say “I will go.” (*Pōvēn.*) Is Kannada’s *hōgu* a different root from *pō*?
 (**No** — the same old *p* softened to *h*, exactly as in *pattu* and *hattu*.)
 Next: a verb whose stem refuses to sit still.

32.3 ವಾ (vā) — “to come,” and a stem with two shapes

Pō threads its beads on without a fuss. Its partner *vā* does not — and the farewell you learned long ago has been hiding the reason.

You’ll want to know: ವಾ

ವಾ — *vā* — to come

ವ (va) with the long-*ā* sign, and, like *pō*, a whole command on its own: *vā!*, “come!” Native Dravidian, and the family keeps it: Malayalam വരുക (*varuka*), Kannada ಬಾ (*bā*), Telugu రా (*rā*). Kannada’s *b* and Telugu’s *r* are two regular reshapings of the same old word, not three separate verbs.

Grammar Lens: the word you say it by is not the word you build on

Thread the beads onto *vā-* and you get nothing a Tamil speaker says. The suffixes attach to வரு- (*varu-*) instead:

varu- + *-gīr-* + *-ēn* → வருகிறேன் (*varugirēn*), “I come.”

Past: வந்தேன் (*vantēn*), “I came.” Future: வருவேன் (*varuvēn*).

So a Tamil verb has a form you **call** it by — the bare command, the form a dictionary lists — and a form the beads actually **attach** to. For most verbs those are the same shape. For a handful of very common ones, of which *vā* is the commonest, they are not, and the pair simply has to be learned together: *vā*, *varu-*.

You have said this word already. The farewell போய் வருகிறேன் (*pōy varugirēn*) — “I go and come back” — is *pō* and *varu-* standing side by side, and that *varugirēn* is the very form above.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the command — “*vā*!”
- the pair that must be learned together — “*vā* ... *varu-*”
- “*varugirēn* ... *vantēn* ... *varuvēn*”
- the farewell you now understand — “*pōy varugirēn*”

Before you move on

What shape do the beads attach to for “come”? (வரு-, *varu-*, not *vā-*.) Say “I come.” (*Varugirēn*.) Which two verbs are standing in *pōy varugirēn*? (போ and வா — go, and come back.) Are Kannada *bā* and Telugu *rā* different verbs? (**No** — the same Dravidian word, reshaped.) Next: a verb Tamil built for itself.

32.4 சாப்பிடு (*sāppiḍu*) — “to eat,” a verb built out of two words

Iru, *pō*, *vā* — three single syllables inherited whole from the oldest layer of Dravidian. The everyday word for “eat” is nothing of the kind. It was assembled.

You'll want to know: சாப்பிடு

சாப்பிடு — *sāppiḍu* — to eat

Four beats: *sāp-pi-ḍu*, with the ப் held long, the same doubling you heard in *irukkīrēn*. Threaded up, it is சாப்பிடுகிறேன் (*sāppiḍugirēn*), “I eat” — stem, then *-gir-*, then *-ēn*, with no surprises. Past: சாப்பிட்டேன் (*sāppiṭṭēn*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The word comes apart cleanly into two Tamil words:

- சாப்பு (*sāppu*) — food, a meal; the everyday சாப்பாடு (*sāppāḍu*, “a meal”) is built from it.
- இடு (*iḍu*) — to put, to place.

Put food. That is all *sāppiḍu* literally says. இடு is what grammarians call a **light verb**: a plain, hard-working verb that lends its endings to a noun so the pair can act as one verb. Tamil builds a great many verbs this way, so *iḍu* is worth knowing on its own. (Where *sāppu* itself came from is not settled; treat the compound as transparent and the deeper root as open.)

Then the honest part. The inherited Dravidian word for eating is **tin-*, and it is thriving next door: Telugu తిను (*tinu*), Kannada ತಿನ್ನು (*tinnu*), Malayalam തിന്നുക (*tinnuka*). Tamil kept it too, as தின் (*tin*) — now narrowed to chewing and snacking — and kept the old literary உண் (*uṇ*), Malayalam’s ഉണ്ണുക (*uṇṇuka*), besides. So Tamil did not lose the ancient eat-verbs. It built a new one and let them keep their smaller jobs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*sāppiḍu*” — eat
- “*sāppiḍugirēn*” — I eat — then “*sāppiṭṭēn*”, I ate
- the two halves — “*sāppu*” (food) + “*iḍu*” (put)
- the inherited root next door — “*tinu* ... *tinnu* ... *tinnuka*”

Before you move on

What two words is *sāppiḍu* made of? (சாப்பிடு, food, and இடு, to put.) What is a light verb doing there? (**Lending its endings** to a noun so the pair works as one verb.) Did Tamil lose the inherited eat-root? (**No** — *tin* narrowed to chewing, *uṇ* stayed literary, and the cousins kept *tinu*, *tinnu*, *tinnuka*.) Next: the verb that splits Tamil’s verbs into two classes.

32.5 பார் (pār) — “to see,” and Tamil’s two kinds of verb

Four verbs in, one small thing has been inconsistent. *Pōgīrēṇ* has a single *k*. *Irukkīrēṇ* has a doubled one. That is not sloppiness — it is a sorting rule, and this verb is where it gets a name.

You’ll want to know: பார்

பார் — *pār* — to see, to watch

ப with the long-*ā* sign, then ர̣ with a pulli to strip its vowel: *pār*, one syllable ending on the *r*. From it comes the noun பார்வை (*pārvai*), “sight, vision.”

Each Dravidian sister settled on a different everyday word for seeing — Kannada ನೋಡು (*nōḍu*), Telugu చూడు (*cūḍu*), Malayalam കാണുക (*kāṇuka*) — so *pār* is Tamil’s own choice, not the family’s. But the family’s shared root is here too: Tamil keeps காண் (*kāṇ*), “to see,” for formal and literary use, and that is the same word as Malayalam’s *kāṇuka* and Kannada’s ಕಾಣು (*kāṇu*). Four sisters, one inherited root, four everyday preferences.

Grammar Lens: strong verbs and weak verbs

Every Tamil verb belongs to one of two camps, and the tense bead tells you which:

camp	present	past
weak — <i>pō</i>	<i>pōgīrēṇ</i>	<i>pōṇēṇ</i>
strong — <i>pār</i>	<i>pārkkīrēṇ</i>	<i>pārttēṇ</i>

Weak verbs take the tense bead lightly: a single *k*, softened to *g*.

Strong verbs double it — *-kkir-*, held long — and take a doubled *t* in the past. *Iru* is strong, which is why “I am” was *irukkīrēn* and never *irugīrēn*. *Sāppiḍu* is weak, like *pō*.

There is no rule you can hear in the bare stem that tells you which camp a verb is in, so it is learned with the verb, the way a noun’s gender is learned in other languages. Two camps, though — not twenty. Meet a verb once in its present form and it is settled forever.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pār” — see, watch
- the contrast, holding the long *kk* — “pōgīrēn ... pārkīrēn”
- the past pair — “pōnēn ... pārttēn”
- which camp each verb sits in — “*iru* strong, *pō* weak, *sāppiḍu* weak, *pār* strong”

Before you move on

What separates a strong verb from a weak one? (**The doubled consonant** in the tense bead — *pārkīrēn* against *pōgīrēn*.) Which camp is *iru* in, and how do you know? (**Strong** — *irukkīrēn* holds the *kk*.) Which Tamil verb for “see” is shared with Malayalam and Kannada? (காண், *kāṇ* — kept for formal use beside everyday *pār*.) Next: a verb with no person on the end at all.

32.6 தெரி (teri) — “to know,” the verb that drops the person

Five verbs, and every one ended on *-ēn*, the bead that means “I.” The last verb of the chapter refuses that bead — and Chapter 6 already gave you the sentence it makes.

You’ll want to know: தெரி

தெரி — *teri* — to know; to be apparent, to be visible

த (ta) with the short-*e* sign, then ரி (ri). Its base sense is not “know” but “**show up, be clear**” — a thing *teri*-s to you the way a shape resolves out of fog. The everyday form is தெரியும் (*teriyum*): “it is known,” “it is apparent.”

Tamil keeps a second know-verb, அறி (*ari*), for knowing by learning — the same word as Kannada ಅರಿ (*ari*) and Malayalam അറിയുക (*ariyuka*). *Teri* has an exact cousin too: Telugu’s తెలుసు (*telusu*), from తెలియ (*teliyu*).

Grammar Lens: no person on the verb, so the person moves

எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும். — *enakkut tamil teriyum* —
“I know Tamil.”

Chapter 6 gave you that sentence whole; here is the verb inside it. தெரியும் has no person bead, and stays the same shape no matter who knows:

- *enakku teriyum* — it is known **to me**
- *unakku teriyum* — it is known **to you**
- *avanukku teriyum* — it is known **to him**

Only the little dative word in front changes. Tamil treats knowing as something that **happens to** you rather than something you **do**, so the knower is not the subject and cannot climb into the verb’s last slot. That is the chapter’s closing symmetry. Five verbs carried the person in the ending, and *nān* could be dropped. Here the ending carries no person, so the dative word is the one thing you cannot drop. Telugu builds it identically: నాకు తెలుసు (*nāku telusu*), “to me it is known.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “teri” — be apparent — then “teriyum”, it is known
- “enakkut tamil teriyum” — I know Tamil
- the three knowers, one verb — “enakku ... unakku ... avanukku teriyum”

- the five that carried the person — “irukkireṇ, pōgireṇ, varugireṇ, sāppiḍugireṇ, pārkkiṇ”

Before you move on

What does *teri* mean underneath “know”? (**To be apparent, to show up.**) Which bead is missing from *teriyum*? (**The person** — so the knower sits in the dative word instead.) Say “I know Tamil.” (*Enakkut tamīl teriyum.*) Name the three slots one last time, with a strong verb in them. (**Stem, tense, person** — *pār* + *-kkir-* + *-ēṇ.*) Which sister builds the knowing-sentence the same way? (**Telugu**, *nāku telusu.*)

Chapter 33

Four Verbs of the Mind

By the end of this chapter: I can say I think, I understand, I read and I write in Tamil with the same three slots, tell a strong verb from a weak one by its held consonant, explain why எனக்குப் புரிகிறது has no I in it, and make the ழ in எழுது.

Say நான் தமிழ் எழுதுகிறேன், run the chapter's four verbs in the present and sort them into strong and weak, produce ழ without letting the tongue touch, and name the one word here whose origin is unsettled.

33.1 நினை (ninai) — “to think,” which is also “to remember”

Teri refused to carry a person: *enakku teriyum*, “it is known to me.” Say *enakkut tamil teriyum* once. This verb takes the person back.

You’ll want to know: நினை

நினை — *ninai* — to think; to think of, to remember

Two light beats, *ni-nai*. Threaded up: நினைக்கிறேன் (*ninaikkirēn*), “I think” — stem, tense, person, with nothing new in the machine.

The letters in this word

நி is the dental ந with the *i* sign ி; னை is the alveolar ன with the *ai* sign ை. Two of Tamil’s three n-letters in one word, and not interchangeable: the first sits on the teeth, the second on the ridge behind them. Chapter 1 mapped all three — ந, ன, ண.

Grammar Lens: it doubles, so it is strong

The **k** in *ninaikkirēn* is held long — *ninaik-ki* — as it was in *irukkirēn* and *pārrkirēn*, and not as it was in *pōgirēn*. So **நினை** is **strong**, and its past is **நினைத்தேன்** (*ninaittēn*), with the strong verb’s doubled *t*. One held consonant answers a question you would otherwise ask of every new verb. You are not learning a machine per verb: you learn which of two camps a stem sits in, then reuse the same three slots forever.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நினை is native Dravidian and does two English jobs at once: *ninaikkirēn* is “I think” and equally “I remember.” The noun says so — **நினைவு** (*ninaivu*) is **memory**. Kannada agrees with **ನೆನೆ** (*nene*), “remember,” and **ನೆನಪು** (*nenapu*), “memory”; Malayalam has **നിനയ്ക്കുക** (*ninaykkuka*).

One honest note for this chapter and the next: English took real words from Tamil — *catamaran*, *mango*, *curry*, *pariah* — but **none from these verbs**. Inventing a cousin would be worse than having none.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ninai*” — think, remember — then “*ninaikkirēn*”
- the strong pair — “*irukkirēn* ... *ninaikkirēn*”
- the noun — “*ninaivu*”, memory — then Kannada “*nenapu*”
- the two shapes — “*enakku teriyum* ... *nān ninaikkirēn*”

Before you move on

What two English verbs does *ninai* cover, and which camp is it in? (**Think** and **remember**; **strong**, from the held *kk*.) What is *ninaivu*, and which sister keeps the root? (**Memory**; **Kannada**, *nene* / *nenapu*.) Which two *n*’s does *ninai* use, in order? (**Dental** ந, then **alveolar** ன.) And why does *teriyum* carry no *-ēn*? (**Knowing happens to you** — its person sits in the dative instead.)

33.2 புரி (puri) — “to become clear,” and who it becomes clear to

Two shapes. *Nān ninaikkirēn* — I do the thinking. *Enakku teriyum* — the knowing happens to me. Say both.

You’ll want to know: புரி

புரி — *puri* — to be understood; to become clear

The everyday form is பரிகிறது (*purigiradu*):

எனக்குத் தமிழ் பரிகிறது. — *enakku tamil purigiradu* —
“I understand Tamil.”

Word for word, “to me Tamil is becoming clear.” The verb is weak: the softened *-gir-* of *pōgīrēn*, not the long *-kkir-* of *ninaikkirēn*.

The letters in this word

பு is ப carrying the *u* sign, which fuses into the letter’s shape rather than hanging off it; ரி is ர with the *i* sign ி.

Grammar Lens: the last slot can say “it”

Teriyum had no person slot at all. *Purigiradu* fills it, with -அது (*-adu*), “it.”

புரி + கிற் + அது → பரிகிறது

So the thing becoming clear is *it*, and the understander is pushed out of the verb into the dative word எனக்கு (*enakku*) that Chapter 6 built for this job. Change the understander and only that word moves:

- *enakku purigiradu* — I understand
- *unakku purigiradu* — you understand
- *avanukku purigiradu* — he understands

Two verbs, two mechanisms, one result: **the experiencer sits in the dative.** Not an exception — the ordinary way to report what happens inside a person.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil's dictionaries keep more than one புரி: an old literary one, “to do, to perform,” and this everyday one. Whether they are one root is **not settled**. Certain is the verbal noun in -தல்: புரிதல் (*puridal*), “understanding.”

The family evidence is stronger. Each sister chose a different verb, and every one puts the understander in the dative:

- Kannada ನನಗೆ ಅರ್ಥವಾಯಿತು — *nanage arthavāyitu*
- Telugu నాకు అర్థమైంది — *nāku arthamaindi*
- Malayalam എനിക്ക് മനസ്സിലായി — *enikku manassilāyi*, “it entered my mind”

Different words, one grammar. Chapter 6 showed the four dative endings were cousins; here they do the same job in the same sentence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “enakkut tamil purigiradu” — I understand Tamil
- three understanders, one verb — “enakku ... unakku ... avanukku purigiradu”
- the pair that share a shape — “enakku teriyum ... enakku purigiradu”
- the sisters' datives — “enakku ... nanage ... nāku ... enikku”

Before you move on

What does *puri* mean underneath “understand,” and what fills its person slot? (**To become clear**; -அது, “it”.) So where does the understander go? (**Into the dative** — *enakku*.) Name the other verb that puts you there. (**Teri** — *enakku teriyum*.) And which verb from this chapter keeps the person on the ending? (**Ninai** — *nān ninaikkirēn*.)

33.3 படி (paḍi) — “to read,” and the letter that is two sounds

Say *enakkut tamil purigiradu* — Tamil becomes clear to me. Now the verb for the work that gets you there.

You’ll want to know: படி

படி — *paḍi* — to read; to study, to learn

படிக்கிறேன் (*paḍikkirēn*), “I read, I study.” The *kk* is held, so படி is strong, like *ninai* and *pār*; its past is படித்தேன் (*paḍittēn*).

நான் தமிழ் படிக்கிறேன். — *nān tamil paḍikkirēn* — “I study Tamil.”

Tamil does not split reading from studying: படிப்பு (*paḍippu*) is both “reading” and “an education.”

The letters in this word

ப (*pa*) + டி, which is ட wearing the *i* sign ி.

Now a mystery worth clearing up. The letter is ட, named *ṭa*, yet the word is written here *paḍi*, with a **d**. Nothing is inconsistent: **Tamil marks no voicing**. One letter covers both sounds and **position decides** — hard word-initially or doubled, soft between vowels. That is Chapter 1’s rule for க, which spells *k*, *g* and a soft *h* without changing shape.

So ட is soft between the vowels of *paḍi* and hard in the doubled ட்ட of *paḍittēn*. It is why *pō* becomes *pōgirēn*, why *sāppiḍu* has a *ḍ*, and why every romanization here softens where a speaker softens.

ட is also **retroflex**, made where ண is: tongue tip curled back to the roof of the mouth. That curl matters more than the *d*-versus-*ṭ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil’s own dictionaries list படி as native. Others connect it to Sanskrit पठ् (*paṭh*), “to recite, to read aloud” — not a silly idea, because **Tamil has no aspirated consonants**, so a borrowed *paṭh* would arrive as *paṭi* automatically, with no letter to carry the puff of breath.

Next door the evidence is split. Malayalam says പഠിക്കുക (*paṭhikkuka*) and **keeps the aspirate**, in the Sanskrit-series letter ഓ; Kannada and

Telugu use ఓదు (*ōdu*) and చదువు (*caduvu*), unrelated to either candidate.

Carry away the certain part: **an aspirate cannot survive into Tamil**, so a stripped-down look-alike is never by itself proof of borrowing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāṇ tamil paḍikkirēṇ” — I study Tamil
- the soft and the hard ᳚ — “paḍi ... paḍittēṇ”
- the strong three — “ninaikkirēṇ, paḍikkirēṇ, pārkkirēṇ”
- the weak one beside them — “purigiradu”

Before you move on

Why is ᳚ written one way and heard two ways, and where is it made? (Tamil marks **no voicing** — position decides, as with ᳚; and it is **retroflex**, made where ண is.) Is *paḍi* borrowed from Sanskrit *paṭh*, and what can Tamil never keep from a Sanskrit word? (**Unsettled; the aspiration.**) Say “I study Tamil.” (*Nāṇ tamil paḍikkirēṇ.*)

33.4 எழுது (*eludu*) — “to write,” and the sound Tamil is named for

Ninaikkirēṇ, purigiradu, paḍikkirēṇ — think, understand, read.
Say all three. The fourth is reading’s other half.

You’ll want to know: எழுது

எழுது — *eludu* — to write; to draw

எழுதுகிறேன் (*eludugirēṇ*), “I write.” The tense bead is the **single softened -gir-**, so எழுது is **weak**, like *pō* and *sāppiḍu*.

நான் தமிழ் எழுதுகிறேன். — *nāṇ tamil eludugirēṇ* — “I write Tamil.”

The letters in this word

எ is the standing vowel *e*; ழு is ழ with the *u* sign and து is த with the same sign.

The dot returns in the noun எழுத்து (*eluttu*), “a letter of the alphabet,” spelled எ ழு த் து: a **pulli** strips the vowel from the first த் and the second து stands whole beside it. Two full letters and a visible dot, never a fused shape: Chapter 1’s bargain.

The letters in this word

ழ — written *l* — is the sound in தமிழ் (*tamiḷ*) itself and in வாழ் (*vāḷ*), “to live,” and is reputed to be the language’s hardest.

Curl the tongue tip back as for ழ or ண, then **do not let it touch**. Leave a gap and voice through it: what comes out sits between an American *r* and an *l*, and it is a **glide**, not a stop.

Two honest notes. Many fluent speakers merge ழு with ள and are understood everywhere. And the family already voted — Chapter 7 gave you Tamil **ēḷu** against Kannada **ēḷu**. Kannada and Telugu each had a letter for it and let it go; **Tamil and Malayalam kept it**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The Dravidian etymological dictionary files எழுது under எழு (*ēḷu*), “to rise” — a written line being a mark raised onto a surface. Standard rather than proven, but native, unlike the open question *paḍi* left you with. Beside it sits எழுத்தாளர் (*eluttāḷar*), a writer.

The cousin is exact: Malayalam എഴുതുക (*elutuka*), same verb, same **ḷ**. Kannada and Telugu, having dropped the sound, dropped the verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three ழு words — “tamiḷ ... vāḷ ... eludu”
- “nāṇ tamiḷ eludugirēṇ” — I write Tamil
- the chapter — “ninaikkirēṇ, purigiradu, paḍikkirēṇ, eludugirēṇ”
- the split — “Tamil ēḷu ... Kannada ēḷu”

Before you move on

Say the chapter's four verbs and name the two weak ones. (*Ni-naikkirēn*, *purigiradu*, *paḍikkirēn*, *eludugirēn*; ***puri*** and ***eludu***.) How is ్ made, and who kept it? (**Curled back, not touching**; Malayalam did, **Kannada** and **Telugu** dropped it.) What keeps the two ్s of *eluttu* apart, and which word here has an unsettled origin? (**The pulli**; ***paḍi***.)

Chapter 34

Four Verbs Between People

By the end of this chapter: I can say I take, I ask, I help and I like in Tamil, hear கேள் doing the work of both asking and hearing, choose between பிடிக்கும் and விரும்பு, and say எனக்குப் பிடிக்கும் knowing why the liker sits in the dative exactly as with தெரியும்.

Say எனக்குத் தமிழ் பிடிக்கும் and unpack it as “to me, Tamil catches”; name the three dative-experiencer verbs தெரியும் / புரிகிறது / பிடிக்கும், contrast விரும்பு’s ordinary subject, and place Kannada ಹಿಡಿ on the $p \rightarrow h$ shift met in Chapter 7.

34.1 எடு (eḍu) — “to take,” beside the “put” you already own

The last chapter’s verbs happened inside your head. These four happen between you and somebody else. Say *paḍikkirēn* and *eludugirēn* once more, then put your hands back in the world.

You’ll want to know: எடு

எடு — *eḍu* — to take; to pick up, to lift, to remove

எடுக்கிறேன் (*eḍukkirēn*), “I take.” The *kk* is held, so எடு is strong; past எடுத்தேன் (*eḍuttēn*). Two sentences you can already build in full:

நான் தண்ணீர் எடுக்கிறேன். — *nān taṇṇīr eḍukkirēn* —
“I take water.”

>

நான் அரிசி எடுக்கிறேன். — *nāṇ arisi eḍukkirēṇ* — “I take rice.”

The letters in this word

எ is the standing vowel *e*, from எழுது; டு is ூ with the *u* sign, and ூ came apart in படி. Nothing here is new — the first time in this book that has been true of a whole headword. The *ḍ* you hear is the same positional softening: ூ goes soft between vowels and hard when doubled, as in *eḍuttēṇ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

You have met this verb’s near-twin already, hiding inside a meal. சாப்பிடு (*sāppiḍu*), “to eat,” is *sāppu* (food) plus இடு (*iḍu*), “to put” — the light verb that lends its endings to a noun.

verb	what it does
இடு <i>iḍu</i>	put it down
எடு <i>eḍu</i>	pick it up

One standing vowel apart — இ against எ — pointing opposite ways. That is a gift to your memory and **not** an etymology: Tamil’s dictionaries keep them as **separate roots**, and a tidy pair of opposites is exactly the resemblance that fools people. Use it to remember; never as evidence.

What *is* inherited is *eḍu* itself. Malayalam has എടുക്കുക (*eṭukkuka*), the same verb; Kannada and Telugu say ఎత్తు / ఎత్తు (*ettu*), “to lift,” from the same old root with a doubled *t* where Tamil keeps its retroflex.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the opposed pair — “iḍu, put ... eḍu, take”
- “nāṇ taṇṇir eḍukkirēṇ” — I take water
- “nāṇ arisi eḍukkirēṇ” — I take rice
- the cousins lifting — “eṭukkuka ... ettu ... ettu”

Before you move on

What does *eḍu* mean, and which camp is it in? (**To take; strong** — *eḍukkīrēn* holds the *kk*.) Which verb is one vowel away, and where did you meet it? (இடு, “to put” — inside சாப்பிடு.) Is that pair related? (**No** — the dictionaries keep them apart; it is a memory hook, not evidence.) Say “I take water,” then “I take rice.” (*Nān taṇṇīr eḍukkīrēn; nān arisi eḍukkīrēn.*)

34.2 கேள் (kēḻ) — one verb for asking and for hearing

Eḍukkīrēn — I take. Name the verb it is one vowel away from.
Now a verb doing two English jobs at once.

You’ll want to know: கேள்

கேள் — *kēḻ* — to ask; to hear, to listen

One syllable, ending on retroflex ள். The everyday form surprises:

நான் கேட்கிறேன். — *nān kēṭkīrēn* — “I ask.” (Also: “I hear.”)

The ள் has hardened to ḻ — வா’s trick a second time: you say it *vā*, but the endings attach to *varu-*. Here they attach to கேட்- (*kēṭ-*), and the past is கேட்டேன் (*kēṭṭēn*), a strong verb’s doubled consonant. Two verbs with two stems apiece.

The letters in this word

கே is க with the long-*ē* sign ே; ள் is retroflex ள shut off by a **pulli** — the dot Chapter 8 pointed at inside செய்து. In கேட்கிறேன் the seam is ட்க.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

English keeps *ask* and *hear* apart. Tamil does not, and neither does its noun: கேள்வி (*kēḻvi*) is “a question” and also “a hearing.” The family splits down the middle:

- Kannada ಕೇಳು (*kēlu*) does **both** jobs, as Tamil does.
- Malayalam கேൾക്കുക (*kēlkkuka*) kept only “hear.”
- Telugu splits them: విను (*vinu*), hear; అడుగు (*aḍugu*), ask.

The verb is inherited, but four languages cannot settle which arrangement came first; treat the fusion as Tamil’s and Kannada’s shared habit alone.

Why it’s said this way

Tamil is **diglossic**: its literary variety and the variety people speak have drifted far apart. This verb makes that impossible to ignore.

- கேள் is the dictionary and literary form.
- கேட்கிறேன் is standard spoken Tamil — **the register these lessons teach**, as every lesson’s variety line has said.
- Relaxed speech says கேக்கிறேன் (*kēkkirēn*) and கேக்க (*kēkka*). Recognise them; you need not say them.

For a polite request use Chapter 8’s respectful ending: கேளுங்கள் (*kēlungaḷ*), “please ask.” Keep தயவுசெய்து for emphasis.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two shifting stems — “vā ... varugirēn” then “kēl ... kēṭkirēn”
- “kēḷvi” — a question — then the polite “kēḷungaḷ”
- the family split — “Kannada kēḷu, both ... Telugu vinu and aḍugu, two”

Before you move on

What two English verbs is *kēḷ*, and what happens to its ள் before an ending? (**Ask** and **hear**; it hardens to ழ.) Which verb taught you to expect a second stem, and what is *kēḷvi*? (வா, built on *varu-*; **a question**.) Which register do these lessons teach, and how do you

ask politely? (Standard spoken *kēṭkirēn*; *kēḷungaḷ*.)

34.3 உதவு (udavu) — “to help,” and a word Tamil did not borrow

Kēṭkirēn — I ask. *Kēḷungaḷ* — please ask. Say both, and keep that polite ending in your ear; it is about to arrive on a second verb unchanged.

You’ll want to know: உதவு

உதவு — *udavu* — to help; to be of use

உதவுகிறேன் (*udavugirēn*), “I help.” The single softened *-gir-* puts உதவு in the weak camp with *pō* and *eludu*, and the noun is one step away: உதவி (*udavi*), “help.”

நான் உங்களுக்கு உதவுகிறேன். — *nān ungaḷukku udavugirēn* — “I help you.”

The person helped takes the dative -உக்கு from Chapter 6, and the polite form needs nothing new: உதவுங்கள் (*udavungaḷ*), “please help” — the same respectful -உங்கள் you just put on *kēḷ*.

The letters in this word

உ is the standing vowel *u*, used when a word begins with it; then த and வு, which is வ with the *u* sign. The *d* you hear is த between two vowels, softening exactly as ட did in *paḍi* and க does in *pōgirēn*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil turns verbs into nouns with a small ending, and you have collected three without being told to: புரி → புரிதல் (*puridal*), understanding; கேள் → கேள்வி (*kēḷvi*), a question; உதவு → உதவி (*udavi*), help. Now the part worth keeping. For “help,” the neighbours nearly all reach for Sanskrit सहाय (*sahāya*): Telugu సహాయం, Kannada ಸಹಾಯ, Malayalam സഹായം, Hindi सहायता. Tamil’s everyday word is உதவி, its own.

Hold that against Chapter 8, where *please* went the other way: **all four** sisters built it on Sanskrit दया (*daya*) plus a light verb — *tayavuseytu*, *dayaviṭṭu*, *dayacēsi*, *dayavāyi*. Same four languages, opposite outcome. So the rule is not “Tamil refuses to borrow”; it is that **borrowing happens word by word**, and the only way to know is to check each one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*nān ungaḷukku udavugirēn*” — I help you
- the two polite forms — “*kēḷungaḷ ... udavungaḷ*”
- the three nouns — “*puridal ... kēḷvi ... udavi*”
- the borrowed one and the kept one — “*tayavuseytu ... udavi*”

Before you move on

Which camp is *udavu* in, and what is *udavi*? (**Weak**, by the single softened bead; **help**, the noun.) Say “I help you,” then “please help.” (*Nān ungaḷukku udavugirēn*; *udavungaḷ*.) Which word do the neighbours borrow from Sanskrit where Tamil keeps its own? (**Help** — *sahāya* against *udavi*.) And which word did all four sisters borrow together? (**Please** — *daya* plus a light verb.)

34.4 பிடி (piḍi) — “to catch,” and therefore “to like”

Say this chapter’s three verbs — *eḍukkirēn*, *kēṭkirēn*, *udavugirēn* — then the two sentences with no *nān*: *enakku teriyum*, *enakku purigiradu*.

You’ll want to know: பிடி

பிடி — *piḍi* — to catch, to seize, to hold

பிடிக்கிறேன் (*piḍikkirēn*) is “I catch, I hold,” and the held *kk* puts it in the **strong** camp with *ninai*, *paḍi* and *eḍu*.

Grammar Lens: எனக்குப் பிடிக்கும்

எனக்குத் தமிழ் பிடிக்கும். — *enakkut tamīl piḍikkum* —
“I like Tamil.”

Word for word: “**to me**, Tamil catches.” The Tamil does the catching; you are caught. பிடிக்கும் carries **no person at all** — the person-less ending of தெரியும் — so only the dative word changes: *enakku piḍikkum*, *unakku piḍikkum*, *avanukku piḍikkum*.

That makes three: தெரியும், புரிகிறது, பிடிக்கும் — knowing, understanding, liking. Three endings; each puts the experiencer in the dative and the thing in the subject. Chapter 6’s **dative subject** was never an exception.

You’ll want to know: விரும்பு

விரும்பு — *virumbu* — **to want, to like, to love**

An ordinary verb with an ordinary subject: நான் விரும்புகிறேன் (*nān virumbugirēn*), “I want.” Weak; its noun is விருப்பம் (*viruppam*), a wish. Not a synonym: பிடிக்கும் is taste, which you had no say in; விரும்பு is choice.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The grasp-verb is old and shared: Malayalam പിടിക്കുക (*piṭikkuka*) and Telugu పట్టు (*paṭṭu*) both mean “catch, hold.” Kannada’s is ಹಿಡಿ (*hiḍi*) — not a different word: Old Kannada wrote *piḍi*, and the **p** → **h** shift behind *paṭṭu* / *hattu* and *pāl* / *hālu* turned it into *hiḍi*. A third instance of a rule you have already met.

The wider point: Spanish says *me gusta*, Italian *mi piace*, Hindi *mujhe pasand hai* — each putting the liker in the dative and the liked thing in the subject, exactly as *enakkut tamīl piḍikkum* does, and none of them related to Tamil. **Two unrelated families reached the same design independently.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three dative sentences — “*enakku teriyum ... purigiradu ... piḍikkum*”

- the other design — “nān virumbugirēn”, I want
- the chapter — “eḍukkirēn, kēṭkirēn, udavugirēn, piḍikkum”
- the Kannada shift — “piḍi ... hiḍi”, as “pattu ... hattu”

Before you move on

Say “I like Tamil” and name its subject. (*Enakkut tamil piḍikkum*, “to me, Tamil catches”; the subject is **Tamil**.) Name the three verbs built that way, and what *virumbu* does differently. (*Teriyum, purigiradu, piḍikkum*; *virumbu* takes an **ordinary subject**.) Why is Kannada’s *hiḍi* the same word as *piḍi*, and which unrelated language builds “I like” this way? (**The p → h shift**; **Spanish** *me gusta*.)

Chapter 35

Arriving at a House

By the end of this chapter: I can name a Tamil house, its door, a room and a chair, take நாற்காலி apart into 'four' and 'leg', place வீடு against Kannada ಬೀಡು on the v-to-b shift, and say why கதவு stayed everyday while Sanskrit-derived கபாடம் stayed in books.

Walk a guest from வீடு through கதவு into அறை and offer a நாற்காலி; split the chair into நால் and கால் and hear ல் harden to ற் at the join; hold the hard ற at the ridge rather than the roof; and name what the pulli does at ற்கா and what Tamil refuses to do there.

35.1 வீடு (vīḍu) — “house,” and the place the greeting happens

Three verbs from the chapter you have just finished: *pidi*, “to like”; *uḍavu*, “to help”; *kēḷ*, “to ask.” Say them. Now a noun, and the one a conversation usually starts inside.

You'll want to know: வீடு

வீடு — *vīḍu* — house; home

One word covers both. Tamil does not split the building from the belonging: என் வீடு (*en vīḍu*) is “my house” and “my home” at once, and choosing between them is the translator's problem.

With the dative you already own:

வீட்டுக்கு — *vīṭṭukku* — to the house

The soft *ḍ* hardens and doubles to *ṭṭ* — the படி / படித்தேன் rule.

The letters in this word

வீ is வ, the first letter you learned, wearing the long $\bar{i}$ sign ீ. Then டு: ட with the u sign.

You are at a door about to say வணக்கம், so read that word while you are here: வ + ண + க் + க + ம். The வ that opens *vaṇakkam* is the வ that opens *viḍu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

வீடு is inherited, not borrowed:

the cousin	language and sense
വീട് <i>vīḍ</i>	Malayalam, “house”
వీడు <i>vīḍu</i>	Telugu, “town, camp”
ಬೀಡು <i>bīḍu</i>	Kannada, “abode, encampment”

Kannada has changed the front of the word: Tamil says **v**, Kannada says **b**. Not a slip — Kannada alone among its neighbours turned inherited word-initial *v*- into *b*-, and the inscriptions show it from about the seventh century. Store the correspondence — it keeps paying.

The **sense** has drifted where the form has not: Telugu’s *vīḍu* is a town, Kannada’s *bīḍu* an encampment. Tamil and Malayalam kept it on the dwelling.

One more thing, not a coincidence to explain away. Tamil has a second வீடு meaning “**release, deliverance**,” as in வீடுபேறு. The Dravidian dictionary files house and release under **one entry**, headed by விடு (*viḍu*), “to let go.” A house is where you are let go.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vīḍu” — house and home in one word
- “en vīḍu,” then the hardening — “vīṭṭukku”
- the cousins, ending on the front-swap — “vīḍ ... vīḍu ... bīḍu”
- the root under the house — “viḍu, to let go”

Before you move on

Why does one Tamil word do two English jobs here, and which letter opens both *vīḍu* and *vaṇakkam*? (**House** and **home** are not split; and வ.) What does Kannada put at the front instead of *v*, and is it a one-off? (**b** — *bīḍu*; **regular**, from the seventh century on.) Is the Tamil word for “release” the same root as the house? (**Yes** — both under விடு, “to let go.”)

35.2 கதவு (kadavu) — “door,” and a word Tamil never gave up

Vīḍu — house. Say the cousin that swaps the front letter. (*Bīḍu*, Kannada.) Now the part of the house you actually stand at.

You’ll want to know: கதவு

கதவு — *kadavu* — door

The leaf that swings, and the thing somebody opens when you arrive.

வீட்டுக் கதவு — *vīṭṭuk kadavu* — the house door

Two nouns in a row, the first leaning on the second. Tamil builds a great deal this way, and you have seen it inside a single word: தண்ணீர் is *taṇ* plus *nīr*, “cool” plus “water.”

The letters in this word

க + த + வு. The first letter is the one that taught you Tamil marks no voicing: க spells a hard *k*, a soft *g* and even an *h*, and **position decides**. Here it opens the word, so it is hard — *ka*, not *ga*.

The same rule then lands on the second letter. த is named *ta*, but it sits between two vowels, so it softens. That is why this book writes *kadavu* and not *katavu*. One rule, two letters, one word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

கதவு is inherited Dravidian. Kannada’s ಕದ (kada) is the same word with less on the end; Malayalam’s കതവ് (*katavu*) matches Tamil

closely.

Tamil also owns a second word for a door-leaf: கபாடம் (*kabāḍam*), taken from Sanskrit कपाट (*kapāṭa*). It exists, it is correct, and almost nobody says it. It lives in poetry and temple description; கதவு lives in the house.

That split is this language’s habit. Where a neighbour borrowed a Sanskrit word and let the inherited one fade, Tamil often kept both and gave them different jobs — the inherited word for the everyday thing, the borrowed one for the elevated register. Do not turn that into a rule that Tamil never borrows. It borrows; it rarely evicts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kadavu” — door
- “vīṭṭuk kadavu” — the house door
- the hard one and the soft one in one word — “ka ... da”
- the everyday word, then the bookish one — “kadavu ... kabāḍam”

Before you move on

Say “the house door,” then explain why the க is hard and the த soft when neither changed shape. (*Vīṭṭuk kadavu*; **Tamil marks no voicing** — position decides.) Which of *kadavu* and *kabāḍam* would you hear at somebody’s house, and where did the other come from? (**Kadavu**; *kabāḍam* is **Sanskrit**, and stays literary.) Does keeping both mean Tamil refuses to borrow? (**No** — it borrows without evicting.)

35.3 அறை (arai) — “room,” and Tamil’s second r

Vīḍu, house. *Kadavu*, door — the everyday word Tamil kept while the Sanskrit one stayed in books. Open that door and you are in this word.

You'll want to know: அறை

அறை — *arai* — room

Any room: in a house, in a hotel, a cell. Put it behind *vīdu* the way you put *kadavu* there:

வீட்டு அறை — *vīttu arai* — a room of the house

And with the dative, அறைக்கு (*arai*kku), “to the room.”

The letters in this word

அ is the standing vowel *a* — a letter in its own right, not a sign hung on a consonant. Then ற, then the *ai* sign ை, which wraps around the front of its consonant: ற + ை → றை.

ற is the hard *r* you first met inside நன்றி. It is not ர. Tamil keeps two r-letters and uses both.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

அறை is inherited. Malayalam's അറ (*ara*) is the same word, used for a chamber or an inner store-room, and it keeps the same hard *r*. So this is *kadavu*'s situation over: an everyday inherited word with a Sanskrit-derived alternative sitting unused in the higher register.

The letters in this word

Say the English word *hurry* and stop on the middle sound. That flick of the tongue against the ridge behind your teeth is close to Tamil ர (*ra*). Now make it stronger and longer, with real contact: that is ற (*ra*). Two cautions. **Do not curl your tongue back** — retroflex belongs to ண and ட; ற is made at the ridge. And **do not soften it into the English r of red**, which is the wrong shape for both Tamil letters. Many Tamil speakers merge ர and ற in casual speech, so you will be understood either way. Learn the difference anyway: the **spelling** depends on it, and a word written with the wrong *r* is simply misspelled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*arai*” — room, on the hard *r*

- the two r’s apart — “ra ... ra”
- “vīṭṭu arai” — a room of the house
- the three so far — “vīḍu, kadavu, arai”

Before you move on

Say “a room of the house,” and name which of Tamil’s two r-letters is in *arai* and where else you have read it. (*Vīṭṭu arai*; ற, the hard one, in நன்றி.) Where is ற made, and what must your tongue not do? (At the **ridge** behind the teeth — **do not curl it back**.) If many speakers merge the two r’s, why bother? (Because the **spelling** does not merge.)

35.4 நாற்காலி (nārkaḷi) — “chair,” counted out in legs

Three words in the order you meet them arriving: *vīḍu*, *kadavu*, *arai*. Hold the hard r in *arai* at the ridge, not the roof. Now the one thing in that room a guest is always pointed at.

You’ll want to know: நாற்காலி

நாற்காலி — *nārkaḷi* — chair

Five syllables for a chair, which sounds extravagant until you find out what it is made of.

நான் நாற்காலி எடுக்கிறேன். — *nān nārkaḷi eḍukkireṇ* —
I take a chair.

The letters in this word

நா + ற் + கா + லி. Every piece is one you have handled.

ந is the dental *n*, first of Tamil’s three n-letters, wearing the long *ā* sign ா. ற் is the hard r of *arai* under a **pulli**, the dot that switches off the built-in vowel. கா is க with that same long *ā*. லி is ல with the *i* sign ி, the first vowel sign you learned, on the way to spelling நன்றி.

Now what does **not** happen at ற்கா. Two consonants meet, and Tamil keeps them as two letters with a dot between, rather than fusing them into

a stacked shape as the scripts to the north do. That refusal is why a word this long stays readable one piece at a time.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The word is a compound, and both halves are yours:

the piece

what it is

நால் *nāl*

“four” — the form four takes in compounds

கால் *kāl*

“leg, foot; a support”

Four plus leg: a chair is a four-legged thing, said out loud. English cannot do that with *chair*, which travels through French and Latin to a Greek word for “seat” without ever showing a leg.

The seam is audible. நான்கு (*nāṅku*) is the counting word; in a compound four appears as நால், and before க that ல hardens to ற். Hence நாற்காலி, and hence நாற்பது (*nārpadu*), “forty.” Malayalam builds the chair from the same two pieces: നാൽക്കാലി.

Both halves are inherited Dravidian. Nothing in this chapter was borrowed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the seam — “nāṅku ... nāl ... kāl ... nār̥kāli”
- “nān nār̥kāli eḍukkireṇ” — I take a chair
- the arrival, in order — “vīḍu, kadavu, arai, nār̥kāli”
- the Kannada front-swap on the first of them — “vīḍu ... bīḍu”

Before you move on

Take *nār̥kāli* apart, then walk somebody into your house four nouns deep. (நால், “four,” plus கால், “leg”; *vīḍu*, *kadavu*, *arai*, *nār̥kāli*.) What does the dot in ற் do, and what does Tamil refuse to do at that join? (**Switches off the built-in vowel**; Tamil **does not stack** the two consonants.) Which of this chapter’s words was borrowed? (**None.**)

Chapter 36

What You Are Offered

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for தேநீர், பால் or உணவு in Tamil, say என் தவறு with no verb in it, find நீர் inside both தண்ணீர் and தேநீர், and state which of this chapter’s words was borrowed and which the dictionaries cannot account for.

Repair a wrong order — மன்னிக்கவும், என் தவறு — and account for the chapter honestly: பால் and உண் inherited, தேநீர் half a loan through a Malay port, சாப்பிடு with no entry in the Dravidian dictionary at all, and மன்னி native where the neighbours took Sanskrit kṣamā.

36.1 தேநீர் (tēnīr) — “tea,” half of it already yours

Nārkaḷi, and what its halves mean. (Four, and leg.) You are in the *arai* with the chair, and the next thing in a Tamil house is this.

You’ll want to know: தேநீர்

தேநீர் — tēnīr — tea

The second half is yours from the water lesson: நீர் (*nīr*), “water,” the plain older word inside தண்ணீர் (*taṇṇīr*) — *taṇ*, “cool,” plus *nīr*. So தேநீர் is, literally, **tea water**.

தேநீர், தயவுசெய்து. — tēnīr, *tayavuseytu* — **Tea, please.**

In speech you will also hear plain டீ (*tī*), straight from English *tea*. தேநீர் is the fuller word — a sign, a menu, a formal host.

The letters in this word

தே is த with the $\bar{e}$ sign ே, which stands in front of its consonant. நீ is ந with the long $\bar{i}$ sign; ர் is ர shut by a pulli — the soft r, not the hard ற.

Two words beside it are worth reading. நன்றி is ந + ன் + றி, what you say when the tea arrives. In தயவுசெய்து, செய் is *ce* plus ய் shut by that same dot before து.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நீர் is inherited and very old. தே is not Tamil at all: it is the combining form of தேய் (*tēy*), borrowed from Malay *teh*, which took it from the Hokkien of the southern Chinese coast, where the leaf is *tê*.

The world's words for tea come in two shapes, decided by **how the tea reached each language**. The southern Chinese coast carried *te*: Dutch *thee*, and through Dutch, English *tea* and French *thé* — and by the Malay ports, Tamil's தே. The overland routes carried *cha*: Persian and Hindi *chāy*, Russian *chay*. Portuguese says **chá** despite being a sea power, because its traders worked out of Macau. Where the ship docked decided the word.

Tamil then did what the European *te*-languages did not: rather than take the loan whole, it welded it to நீர் — a word that has travelled outward as well, since English **mulligatawny** is Tamil மிளகுத்தண்ணீர், “pepper water.”

Weigh that against the rice word. அரிசி *may* stand behind English *rice* through Greek, and the dictionaries hedge. The tea routes are documented. **Different histories, different confidence.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the shared half — “nīr ... taṇṇīr ... tēnīr”
- “tēnīr, tayavuseytu” — tea, please
- the two routes — “te ... cha”
- the pepper water in an English soup — “miḷagut taṇṇīr”

Before you move on

Name the second half of *tēnīr* and the word that shares it, then ask for tea politely. (நீர், inside தண்ணீர்; *tēnīr*, *tayavuseytu*.) Why do some languages say *te* and others *cha*, and which is better established — the tea split or *arisi*-to-*rice*? (**The route the tea travelled; and the tea split.**)

36.2 பால் (pāl) — “milk,” and a p that becomes an h next door

Tēnīr. Which half is borrowed, and which is the old Tamil word for water? (*Tē* is the traveller; *nīr* is Tamil’s own.) Here is what goes into it.

You’ll want to know: பால்

பால் — *pāl* — milk

One syllable, one long *ā*, a final ல் with no vowel after it. Say it short and closed: *pāl*, never *pāla*.

பால் தேநீர் — *pāl tēnīr* — milk tea

With தண்ணீர் (*taṇṇīr*, cool water) already in hand, you can now name what a Tamil household is likely to put in front of a guest.

The letters in this word

பா is ப with the long *ā* sign ா. Then ல்: ல with the **pulli**, the dot that removes the built-in *a* and leaves a bare consonant.

That dot is the whole reason the word ends where it does. Without it, பால் would be *pāla*, two syllables. A single dot carries the difference between a word and a non-word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பால் is inherited Dravidian, and its relatives are close:

the cousin	language
പാൽ <i>pāl</i>	Malayalam
పాలు <i>pālu</i>	Telugu
ಹಾಲು <i>hālu</i>	Kannada, modern

Kannada has changed the front of the word once more, this time **p** into **h** — the textbook example of the best-known sound change in the family. **Old Kannada said *pālu***, exactly as Tamil does; the *p*- began turning into *h*- around the tenth century and the change had run through the whole vocabulary by the fourteenth.

Put it beside the change you met at the house. Tamil **v**, Kannada **b**, in *vīḍu* / *bīḍu*. Tamil **p**, Kannada **h**, in *pāl* / *hālu*. Both are regular correspondences at the front of a word, and between them they let you recognise a Kannada word as a relative rather than a stranger. Telugu and Malayalam did neither: they keep the *p*, as Tamil does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pāl” — stopped by the dot, not *pāla*
- “pāl tēnīr” — milk tea
- the two front-swaps together — “vīḍu, bīḍu ... pāl, hālu”
- what you can be offered — “taṇṇīr, tēnīr, pāl”

Before you move on

Say “milk tea,” then say what the dot on **ḷ** is doing and what the word would be without it. (*Pāl tēnīr*; it **removes the built-in vowel**, and without it, *pāla*.) What does Kannada put at the front instead of *p*, and is it a one-off? (**h** — *hālu*; **regular**, from the tenth century to the fourteenth.) Name the other Kannada front-swap. (**v** to **b** — *vīḍu*, *bīḍu*.)

36.3 உணவு (uṇavu) — “food,” from the verb underneath it

Pāl — milk — and the Kannada shape of it. (*Hālu*.) Drink is settled. Now the word for everything else on the plate.

You’ll want to know: உணவு

உணவு — *uṇavu* — food

The general word: food as a category, not a dish. It covers the rice words you have — அரிசி (*arisi*), the raw grain, and சாதம் (*sātam*), the cooked meal — and all that is served beside them.

உணவு, தயவுசெய்து. — *uṇavu, tayavuseytu* — Food, please.

Note the register. உணவு is the careful, written word — a menu, a sign. Around a family table people say சாப்பாடு (*sāppāḍu*).

The letters in this word

உ is a standing vowel — a full letter, not a sign. Then ண, then வு, which is வ with the *u* sign underneath. ண is the retroflex *n* you first wrote alongside ட, and the letter inside தண்ணீர்.

The letters in this word

Curl the tip of your tongue **back** to the roof of your mouth and release into the vowel. That is ண, and *uṇavu* gives it a clean run because the letter sits between two vowels. Contrast the ன of நன்றி and the ந of நீர், both made near the teeth.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

உணவு is உண் (*uṇ*), “to eat,” with a noun-forming ending. Food is literally *the eating*. Tamil has two eating verbs, of different ages:

the verb	where it lives
உண் <i>uṇ</i>	old, inherited, literary now
சாப்பிடு <i>sāppiḍu</i>	the everyday spoken verb

உண் is a bare inherited root, and the Dravidian dictionary lists *uṇavu* inside its entry.

சாப்பிடு is where the ground softens, so hold Chapter 32’s earlier account loosely. You were shown *sāppu*, “food,” plus இடு (*iḍu*), “to put.” The இடு is visible in the spelling; the first half is the problem. The great Tamil lexicon records no plain word *sāppu* meaning “food,” and the Dravidian etymological dictionary has **no entry for this verb at all**. It is not Sanskrit — Telugu and Malayalam have their own forms — but its origin is open. The word you would use at a table has the weaker paperwork.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the root and the noun — “uṇ ... uṇavu”
- the retroflex, tongue curled back — “uṇavu”
- the documented one, then the everyday one — “uṇ ... sāppiḍu”
- raw grain, then cooked meal — “arisi ... sātam”

Before you move on

What verb is *uṇavu* built on, and where does your tongue go for ண்? (உண்; **curled back**.) Which eating verb would you use at a table, and how sure is anyone where it came from? (சாப்பிடு — **not at all**: the Dravidian dictionary has no entry.) Give the raw grain and the cooked meal. (*Arisi; sātam*.)

36.4 தவறு (tavaru) — “a mistake,” and the rest of the apology

The chapter back: *tēnīr*, *pāl*, *uṇavu*. Suppose one arrives and it is not what you asked for. You have “sorry,” but not the word for what went wrong.

You'll want to know: தவறு

தவறு — *tavaru* — a mistake, an error, a fault

With என் (*en*), “my,” and no verb — Tamil needs none:

மன்னிக்கவும், என் தவறு. பால் இல்லை, தேநீர்.

>

mannikkavum, en tavaru. pāl illai, tēnīr.

>

Sorry, my mistake. Not milk — tea.

மன்னிக்கவும் is the careful, written-leaning apology; in speech many Tamil speakers simply say *sorry*, in English. என் தவறு suits either.

The letters in this word

த + வ + று. The last piece is ற, the hard r of *arai*, with the *u* sign — made at the ridge behind the teeth, tongue flat, not curled.

The apology in front of it does something this word does not. மன்னிக்கவும் has ன்னி: the alveolar ன switched off by a dot, then written a second time with the *i* sign. Tamil doubles a consonant by **repeating the letter with a dot on the first**, never by inventing a joined shape — the க்க of வணக்கம் over.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

தவறு is inherited Dravidian, a verb and a noun in one shape: “to slip, to fail,” and “a slip, a mistake.” The dictionary files it beside தப்பு (*tappu*); its cousins are everywhere.

Now the chapter in a line. மன்னிக்கவும் was the showpiece: Tamil kept its own மன்னி where Kannada, Telugu and Malayalam reached for Sanskrit *kṣamā*. தவறு is inherited too, and so is உண் inside *uṇavu*, and பால். But தேநீர் is half a loan from a Malay port, and சாதம் was flagged as Sanskrit-influenced when you met it.

So the honest statement is not “Tamil does not borrow.” It is that **Tamil borrows without evicting**: the inherited word stays, and the loan takes a different job or register.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “en tavaru” — my mistake, with no verb in it
- the whole repair — “mannikkavum, en tavaru”
- the two words for a mistake — “tavaru ... tappu”
- the borrowed one among this chapter’s words — “tēnīr”

Before you move on

Apologise, name the fault, and say why there is no word for “is” in it. (*Mannikkavum, en tavaru; **Tamil needs none.**) How does Tamil write a doubled consonant, as in ன்னி and க்ஃ? (**The letter a second time**, dot on the first.) Which apology verb is native where the neighbours took Sanskrit, and does that make Tamil a language that never borrows? (மன்னி, against *kṣamā*; **no** — it **borrows without evicting.**)*

Chapter 37

Your Town, Your Friend

By the end of this chapter: I can ask உங்கள் ஊர் என்ன? and introduce someone with இவர் என் நண்பர், choose between நண்பன், நண்பி and நண்பர், run Tamil's இ / அ / எ pointing series, and hear ண் voice the ட that follows it.

Say இவர் என் நண்பர் with no verb in it, pick the ending by respect rather than by habit, name the -ūr inside Tanjore and Bengalūru, and state what Tamil forces you to decide for a sibling that it does not force for a friend.

37.1 ஊர் (ūr) — “town,” and the question Tamil asks early

En tavaru — my mistake, a word that is a verb and a noun at once. Then the general word for food. (*Uṇavu.*) Now back to meeting somebody.

You'll want to know: ஊர்

ஊர் — ūr — town, village; the place you are from

That last sense matters most. உங்கள் ஊர் is your **native place**, where your family is from, which may be somewhere you have never lived.

உங்கள் ஊர் என்ன — ungal ūr enna — What is your town

It lands early in a Tamil conversation and is not nosiness — the slot English fills with “what do you do.

The letters in this word

உன் is a standing vowel — long $\bar{u}$, partner of the உ that opens *unavu*. ற் is ர, the soft r, shut by a pulli. Hold the vowel: $\bar{u}r$, not *ur*. Vowel length is part of a word’s identity here.

Grammar Lens: the two registers, side by side

You met this choice on the age question:

the question	who you say it to
உன் ஊர் என்ன <i>un ūr enna</i>	a friend, a child, a peer
உங்கள் ஊர் என்ன <i>uṅgaḷ ūr enna</i>	a stranger, an elder, anyone senior

Both are possessive plus noun plus question word, with **no verb** — the shape you learned for உன் வயசு என்ன. Only the possessive changes, and with it the social temperature. When unsure, use உங்கள்.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ஊர் is inherited Dravidian, and welded into city names you know in English:

the English name	what it is
Tanjore	Tamil தஞ்சாவூர் <i>Taṅjāvūr</i>
Vellore	Tamil வேலூர் <i>Vēlūr</i>
Bangalore	Kannada ಬೆಂಗಳೂರು <i>Bengalūru</i>

Every one of those *-ore* endings is this word: the British ear turned $-\bar{u}r$ into *-ore*, and the cities have taken their own names back.

Two exactnesses. Bangalore is a **Kannada** town, so its $-\bar{u}ru$ is Kannada’s form of the inherited word — the family’s, not Tamil’s alone. And the *first* halves are not all settled; *Vēl-* in Vellore is argued over. The ending is the certain part.

Weigh that against the rice word. அரிசி *may* stand behind English *rice* through Greek, and the dictionaries hedge. Nobody hedges about $-\bar{u}r$.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the long vowel — “ $\bar{u}r$,” not “*ur*”
- to a stranger — “*uṅgaḷ ūr enna*”

- to a friend — “un ūr enna”
- the ending inside the map — “Taṇjāvūr ... Vēlūr ... Bengalūru”

Before you move on

Ask a stranger where they are from, then a friend, and say what ஊர் means beyond “town.” (*Uṇḡaḷ ūr enna*; *un ūr enna*; **your native place.**) Which earlier question has this shape, and is *-ore* in Tanjore really this word? (உன் வயசு என்ன; **yes.**) How sure are we there, next to *arisi* and *rice*? (**Much surer.**)

37.2 நண்பன் (naṇban) — “friend,” with the ending doing the work

A stranger’s native place, then the ending inside Tanjore. (*Uṇḡaḷ ūr enna*; *-ūr.*) Now the person you would introduce.

You’ll want to know: நண்பன்

நண்பன் — *naṇban* — **friend** (a man)

Tamil will not let you say a bare “friend” any more than a bare “brother.” The stem is நண்ப-; the ending decides.

the form	who it is
நண்பன் <i>naṇban</i>	a male friend
நண்பி <i>naṇbi</i>	a female friend
நண்பர் <i>naṇbar</i>	a friend spoken of with respect

The -அர் is the respectful plural that turns நீ into நீங்கள், applied to a person.

This is a different axis from the family words. அண்ணன் and தம்பி split brothers by **age**; the friend words split by **sex**, நண்பர் by **respect**.

The letters in this word

ந + ண் + ப + ன் — **every one of Tamil’s n-letters inside one word.** ந opens it, dental, at the teeth. ண் is retroflex, tongue curled back, closed by a pulli. ன் ends it, the alveolar n from நன்றி. The writing lesson gave them to you one at a time; here they arrive together.

The letters in this word

The letter after ண் is ப, named *pa*. This book writes *naṇbaṇ* because of the நன்றி rule: a nasal in front of a stop **voices it**. A Tamil reader supplies the voicing, as an English reader supplies the *sh* in *sugar*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Behind நண்பன் is நண்பு (*naṇbu*), “friendship, closeness,” which belongs to the root family of நண்ணு (*naṇṇu*), “**to draw near**.” A friend, in Tamil’s own accounting, is someone who came close.

Be precise. The Dravidian dictionary files *naṇbu* and *naṇbaṇ* in the same entry as *naṇṇu*; the Tamil lexicon prefers நள்-, making them siblings rather than parent and child. They differ on the line of descent, not on the household.

Set it beside அப்பா and அம்மா, not built out of anything — the repeated-syllable shape children produce for parents worldwide. நண்பன் is assembled, from a root you can point at.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three endings — “naṇbaṇ, naṇbi, naṇbar”
- the voicing after the nasal — “naṇri ... naṇbaṇ”
- the root it came from — “naṇṇu, to draw near”
- the family words that split on age instead — “aṇṇan, tambi”

Before you move on

Give the friend-word for a woman, a man, and someone you respect. (*Naṇbi; naṇbaṇ; naṇbar*.) Which axis do the friend words split on, and which do the brother words? (**Sex and respect; age**.) Why is ப heard as *b*, and are அப்பா and அம்மா built from a root the way *naṇbaṇ* is? (**A nasal voices the stop after it; no**.)

37.3 இவர் (ivar) — “this person,” and Tamil’s pointing system

Nanban, nanbi, nanbar — and the root behind them. (*Nannu*, to draw near.) You have the word for a friend, but cannot point at one.

You’ll want to know: இவர்

இவர் — *ivar* — **this person** (near me, spoken of respectfully)

Not “he” and not “she”: இவர் is what you say about a person standing here whom you are treating with respect, and it does not commit you to their sex. It is built on இவன் (*ivan*) and இவள் (*ival*), with the same -அர் that gave you நண்பர்.

One caution about speech: இவர் is heard mostly of men, and இவங்க (*ivanga*) does the same respectful job for a woman.

The letters in this word

இ + வ + ர். இ is the standing vowel *i* — the letter, not the ி sign that hangs on a consonant. வ is the *va* opening வணக்கம் and வீடு. ர் is the soft *r* with a pulli.

A word this short is almost all arc, which is the moment to recall the usual explanation for that roundness: Tamil was scratched into palm leaf, and a straight stroke along the grain can split the leaf. Hold it as the writing lesson asked — **the standard account, not a settled fact**, since the earliest Tamil writing was cut into stone and is angular. What survives is the useful part: **the tool leaves fingerprints on the letters**.

Grammar Lens: near, far, and which

இவர் is one cell of a system, and the system is a single letter at the front:

the front letter	what it does
இ-	points near — this one, here
அ-	points away — that one, there
எ-	asks — which one

So இவர் is “this person,” அவர் (*avar*) “that person,” எவர் (*avar*) “which person.” You have been using one front already: என்ன (*enna*),

“what,” is the எ- of asking.

Two honest notes. எ- is the **question**, not a third distance. And Old Tamil had a genuine third distance, உ-, for something visible but far off; modern Tamil has retired it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three fronts — “i- ... a- ... e-”
- the row they build — “ivar, avar, evar”
- the question word you already had — “enna”
- the respectful ending on both — “naṇbar ... ivar”

Before you move on

What do இ-, அ- and எ- do at the front of a word, and which question word you already knew is built on எ-? (**Near; away; asks** — and என்ன.) Does இவர் tell you whether the person is a man or a woman? (**No** — it marks **respect**; spoken Tamil leans இவங்க for a woman.) How firmly should you hold the palm-leaf explanation for the curves? (**As the standard account, not a settled fact.**)

37.4 இவர் என் நண்பர் — “this is my friend”

Ivar, avar, evar — near, away, the question. Then *naṇban, naṇbi, naṇbar*. Everything this lesson needs is in your mouth; what is left is the order.

You’ll want to know: the introduction

இவர் என் நண்பர். — *ivar en naṇbar* — **This is my friend.**

Three words, and **not one of them is a verb**. Tamil links two nouns by setting them beside each other, as in என் பெயர் ... and என் தவறு.

The pieces in order: இவர், the person here; என், my; நண்பர், friend-with-respect. Then stop.

The whole meeting:

— வணக்கம். இவர் என் நண்பர்.

>

— வணக்கம். உங்கள் ஊர் என்ன.

Every word in it is yours.

The letters in this word

என் is எ with ன், the alveolar n dotted shut. நண்பர் opens on dental ந, turns on retroflex ண், closes on ர். So one line makes you produce ன் and ண் within a breath of each other — one at the ridge, the other with the tongue curled back. Hear that difference and the three-way n is no longer theory.

Why it's said this way

நண்பர் rather than நண்பன் is a decision, not a default.

- இவர் என் நண்பன். — a male friend, plainly stated; warm among peers.
- இவர் என் நண்பி. — a female friend, the matching plain form.
- இவர் என் நண்பர். — the respectful ending; safe with anyone, and right when either party is older or senior.

If unsure, take நண்பர். Over-respect is invisible; under-respect is not. Notice how differently Tamil makes you think from one word to the next. For a **sibling** it forces **age**: there is no bare “brother” — you must choose அண்ணன் or தம்பி, அக்கா or தங்கை, and say whether they are older or younger than you before you can say anything at all. For a **friend** it forces **sex or respect**. For **parents**, nothing: அப்பா and அம்மா came into the language whole. Tamil rarely lets you be vague about a relationship.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the introduction — “ivar eṇ naṇbar”

- the same line to a peer about a male friend — “ivar eṇ naṇbaṇ”
- the greeting and the question around it — “vaṇakkam ... uṇgaḷ ūr eṇṇa”
- what a sibling word forces you to decide — “aṇṇaṇ, older; tambi, younger”

Before you move on

Introduce a friend respectfully, and say how many verbs the sentence has. (*Ivar eṇ naṇbar*; **none**.) What does a sibling word force you to decide that a friend word does not? (**Whether they are older or younger** — *aṇṇaṇ* against *tambi*.) Which friend ending is safe when unsure, and what does இ- tell your listener? (நண்பர்; that the person is **near**.)

Chapter 38

Keeping Well, and Leaving

By the end of this chapter: I can ask உங்கள் உடம்பு எப்படி இருக்கு?, recognise சுகமா? and place it as the Sanskrit-derived option beside native நலம், say விடை பெறுகிறேன், and show that விடு, வீடு and விடை are one root while ஊர் and நண்பன் are not.

Close the visit with நன்றி. விடை பெறுகிறேன்., put விடு, வீடு and விடை in one dictionary entry, refuse the second விடை that means 'bull' and came from Sanskrit, and refuse to join ஊர் and நண்பன் to the pattern just because they are nearby.

38.1 உடம்பு (uḍambu) — “body,” and how Tamil asks after your health

Introduce a friend respectfully and name the ending. (*Ivar en nanbar* — the respectful -அர்.) Next you would ask how they are.

You'll want to know: உடம்பு

உடம்பு — uḍambu — body

The whole of it, not a part. You have தலை (*talai*) and கை (*kai*) already; this is what they belong to, and the word inside the question Tamil speakers actually ask:

உங்கள் உடம்பு எப்படி இருக்கு — *uṅgal uḍambu eppadi irukku* — how is your body, that is, how are you keeping

Every piece is yours: உங்கள், எப்படி, and இருக்கு from இரு. What is new is that the health question hangs on a **noun** rather than on you.

Tamil has a second way to ask it, through உணவு — the noun standing on உண், “to eat.” Asking whether somebody has eaten is asking whether they are all right.

The letters in this word

உ + ட + ம் + பு: the standing vowel *u*, ட, then ம் — ம shut by the pulli you have used since வணக்கம் — and பு. ம was one of the first letters you formed with a pen, alongside retroflex ண.

The letters in this word

The letters say *u-ta-m-pu*; your mouth says *uḍambu*. ட sits between vowels, so it softens — the *paḍi* rule. பு follows the nasal ம், so it voices — the *nanri* rule that also made *nanban*. Two rules, one short word, neither written down.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil has another word for the body, உடல் (*uḍal*), and the Dravidian dictionary does not treat them as rivals: உடல், உடம்பு and உடலம் sit in the **same entry**, with Kannada’s உಡಲು beside them. Usage has divided them: உடல் leans literary, உடம்பு is what you say aloud about someone unwell.

Grammar Lens: where the person goes in a health question

Two shapes Tamil uses to ask about a state:

the question	where the person sits
உங்கள் உடம்பு எப்படி இருக்கு	as a possessor
உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது	in the dative

The formal age question does not make you the subject at all — “to you, how many years are becoming.” The body question makes உடம்பு the subject.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two softenings — “uṭampu ... uḍambu”
- the question — “uṅgaḷ uḍambu eppaḍi irukku”
- the parts, the whole, and the two forms of one root — “talai, kai ... uḍambu ... uḍal”

Before you move on

Ask someone respectfully how they are keeping, through the body, and name the two sound rules inside *uḍambu*. (*Uṅgaḷ uḍambu eppaḍi irukku*; ʌ softens **between vowels**, ʌ voices **after a nasal**.) Are உடல் and உடம்பு different words, and where does the person sit in the formal age question? (**No**, same entry; **in the dative**.)

38.2 சுகம் (sugam) — “ease,” the word Tamil did borrow

Health through the body, and the other body-word in its entry. (*Uṅgaḷ uḍambu eppaḍi irukku*; uḍal.) A second answer came from abroad.

You’ll want to know: சுகம்

சுகம் — *sugam* — wellbeing, ease, comfort

The க is doing its old trick: the letter is *ka*, but between vowels it comes out *g*. *Su-g-am*, not *su-ka-m*.

சுகமா — *sugamā* — keeping well

It is **not** the ordinary Tamil “how are you,” which is நல்லா இருக்கீங்களா. சுகமா is warmer and more Sanskritic, and which you hear depends on somebody’s ஊர் — the native place whose name so often ends in *-ūr*.

The letters in this word

சு + க + ம்: ச with the *u* sign, a bare க, ம closed by the pulli. Nothing is doubled — hold that against மன்னிக்கவும், where ன்னி has ன dotted shut and written a second time, and க்க does the same to க.

Grammar Lens: where the dative is required

சுகமா has no dative in it, and a family of Tamil states demands one: எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும், “to me, Tamil is known.” Put a noun there and the shapes part:

the phrase	what happened
நான் to எனக்கு	the pronoun changes its body
நண்பர் to நண்பருக்கு	the noun just takes -உக்கு

So நண்பருக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும், and the formal age question does the same: உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது. சுகமா does not: knowing and ageing come *to* a person; being well is what a person **is**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

சுகம் is Sanskrit सुख (*sukha*), “ease” — the apology lesson in reverse. There, மன்னிக்கவும் stood on Tamil’s own மன்னி while the neighbours built their “sorry” on Sanskrit *kṣamā*. Here Tamil borrowed *sukha* and kept நலம் as the everyday word; Malayalam took the same loan, സുഖം, as its ordinary greeting.

The old parse of *sukha* is *su-* “good” plus *kha* “aperture” — a chariot’s axle-hole. **Treat that as contested:** the standard Sanskrit dictionary hedges it with “said to be,” and offers *su-stha*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the softened க — “sugam,” not “sukam”
- the state that needs a dative — “naṇbarukkuṭ tamīl teriyum”
- the state that does not, and the word kept beside it — “sugamā ... nalam”

Before you move on

Why is க heard as *g*, and what did the noun do that நான் does not? (Between vowels; it takes -உக்கு, while நான் becomes எனக்கு.) Which word did Tamil borrow, which did it keep, and how firm is the “good axle-hole” story? (சுகம்; நலம்; contested.)

38.3 விடை (vidai) — “leave,” and the root under the house

Sugam — which language it came from, and which Tamil word stayed beside it. (Sanskrit; நலம்.) You came through the door, took the நாற்காலி — four legs, counted out — were given tea, said என் தவறு when the wrong cup arrived, and introduced a friend. One thing is left.

You’ll want to know: விடை

விடை — *vidai* — leave; permission to depart

Not the act of going — you have போய் வருகிறேன் for that — but the **leave itself**, taken with பெறு (*peru*), “to obtain”:

நன்றி. விடை பெறுகிறேன். — *nanri. vidai perugirēn.* —
Thank you. I take my leave.

It is **formal and slightly literary**; leaving a friend’s house you would say போய் வருகிறேன்.

The தயவுசெய்து you learned for asking has a family across the Dravidian languages, all built on the same *daya*, “kindness,” plus a light verb. Leaving is not.

The letters in this word

வி + டை. வி is வ with the ி sign — the first vowel sign you learned, which made நன்றி possible. டை is ட with the ஐ sign ை, which wraps around the front.

நன்றி stands beside it above, so read it once more: ந + ன் + றி — dental n, alveolar n dotted shut, hard ற with that same ி. And பெறுகிறேன் has a க between vowels, so it softens.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

விடை is inherited Dravidian, and belongs to விடு (*viḍu*), “to let go.” Leave is what you are *let go* with.

Now the first word of these lessons. வீடு, “house,” is filed by the Dravidian dictionary in the **same entry as** விடு — and விடை is in it too:

the word	what it is
விடு <i>viḍu</i>	to let go, to release
வீடு <i>vīḍu</i>	the house — and, in the old sense, final release
விடை <i>viḍai</i>	leave to depart

You walked in through வீடு and walk out through விடை, one word in different clothes. Kannada’s ಬೀಡು, the same house with its *b-*, sits on that root as well.

Two cautions, because a neat pattern is when to slow down. A second விடை means “bull,” a Sanskrit borrowing from *vr̥ṣa*; and ஊர் — the settlement inside Tanjore — and நண்பன் are outside this root entirely.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the departure — “nanri. viḍai perugirēn.”
- the one root, three ways — “viḍu ... vīḍu ... viḍai”
- the two that do not join it — “ūr ... naṇban”

Before you move on

Take your leave formally, thanks in front of it, and name the earlier word that shares this root. (*Nanri. viḍai perugirēn.*; வீடு, from விடு, “to let go.”) Do ஊர் and நண்பன் belong to that root? (No — a settlement and a closeness; not everything joins up.)

The Tamil script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** க = ka, ம = ma, ர = ra.
2. **A vowel sign changes that built-in vowel.** ா = ā, ி = i, ீ = ī, ூ = u, ௃ = ū, ெ = e, ே = ē, ை = ai, ொ = o, ோ = ō.
(E.g. க ka + ி → கி ki.)
3. **A *pulli* (the dot, •) removes the built-in vowel.** க் = a bare *k*.
A vowel-less consonant then leans into the next.

Independent vowels (word-initial)

அ a · ஆ ā · இ i · ஈ ī · உ u · ஊ ū · எ e · ஏ ē · ஐ ai · ஒ o ·
ஔ ō · ஔ au.

What makes Tamil distinctive

- **Three *n*'s, three *l*'s, two *r*'s.** Place of articulation is written: dental ந / alveolar ண / retroflex ண்; ல ள ழ; ர ற. English fuses each set; Tamil keeps them apart, and they change meaning.
- **One letter, several sounds.** Tamil marks no voicing or aspiration: க can be *k*, *g*, or *h*; ச can be *s* or *ch* — **position** decides. The alphabet is small; the sound is read from context.

- **No Sanskrit-only letters in the core set.** Classical Tamil gets by with 18 consonants (a handful of *grantha* letters — ஜ, ஷ, ஸ, ஹ — are added only to spell loanwords).

Tamil in the Dravidian family

Tamil is the oldest-attested Dravidian language, and the one most protective of its native word-stock. Its sisters — Malayalam (closest), then Kannada and Telugu — share the grammar and many roots but borrowed far more freely from Sanskrit. The lessons trace, word by word, which Tamil words are home-grown and which its neighbours replaced.